
PRODUCTBEACON

The State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026

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Former-employer independence: The author was employed by NICE (9 April 2008 to 20 May 2021), holding senior product-leadership responsibility for the Recording / Workforce-Optimization line of business – the very domain this report grades NICE on – and remains bound by a confidentiality and trade-secret undertaking from that employment; this report relies solely on published material and contains no information derived from that employment, and the author holds no NICE equity.

(WFO / WEM) – An Independent Market Map · ProductBeacon Research

The bet, in brief

The thesis the whole report is built to test, in one sentence:

As WEM buyers renew through 2026–2027, the classic WFO stack – recording → quality → workforce management → coaching – is consolidating onto a single AI brain, and the value WFO captures is migrating from per-seat licensing toward per-outcome / per-resolution pricing as autonomous agents absorb the interactions a human seat used to handle.

It rests on three proxies.

- **P1: one engine** (the stack collapses onto a single AI brain): tested at the *product surface* (Proxy P1 below).
- **P2: seat → outcome** (the pricing unit changes): tested on *published price lists today* (Proxy P2 below).
- **P3: the seat absorbs** (autonomous agents take the volume a seat used to handle): tested on *deflection/fulfillment signals* – and this is the contested one (Proxy P3 below).

P1 is strongly evidenced and P2 is observable fact today; P3, the actual seat elimination, is a contested forecast, and it is the report's live falsification risk. The repricing is real; the displacement is a bet.

The Fronts of the WEM Stack

This report cuts the Workforce Engagement Management (WFO / WEM) stack into **five graded markets**, each drawn by the buyer it serves, plus a **Convergence synthesis** that reads across them. One further front – **Recording & Compliance** – is named but carried as **context, not graded** (see the note that follows).

- **Recording & Compliance** (*context front – not graded*) – the capture and retention layer, plus the compliance controls that govern it. The common capture layer every graded market consumes.
- **Quality & Interaction Analytics** – for the buyer of the interaction's content: scoring and analysing what was said.
- **Workforce Management** – for the buyer of the schedule: forecasting demand and staffing the floor.
- **Performance & Engagement** – for the supervisor: coaching, calibration, and retention.
- **Agent-Assist & Real-Time Guidance** – for the live moment: guiding the agent while the conversation is happening.
- **Autonomous CX** – for the deflected interaction: the AI agent that resolves end-to-end with no human in the loop.
- **Convergence** (*synthesis*) – how the graded markets collapse onto a single AI engine and reprice from per-seat toward per-outcome.

Recording & Compliance – the context front

Recording & Compliance is the capture layer: the recording and retention of the interaction, plus the compliance controls that govern it. It leads the map because it comes first in the workflow. Recording captures and retains the interaction, and every later market then scores, schedules around, coaches on, or acts on what was captured.

It is carried here as **context, not graded**, for one reason: the market is **commoditized**. Capture and retention are table stakes across every suite, with no live Winning / Losing tension to grade this edition. So this edition tiers it contingent and spends its pages where the contest is live – the five graded markets and the Convergence synthesis that follow. Recording still matters throughout as the input every graded market consumes; it simply is not, this year, a front where the contest is open.

Chapter 1 – The Quality & Interaction Analytics Market

1.1 What This Market Is

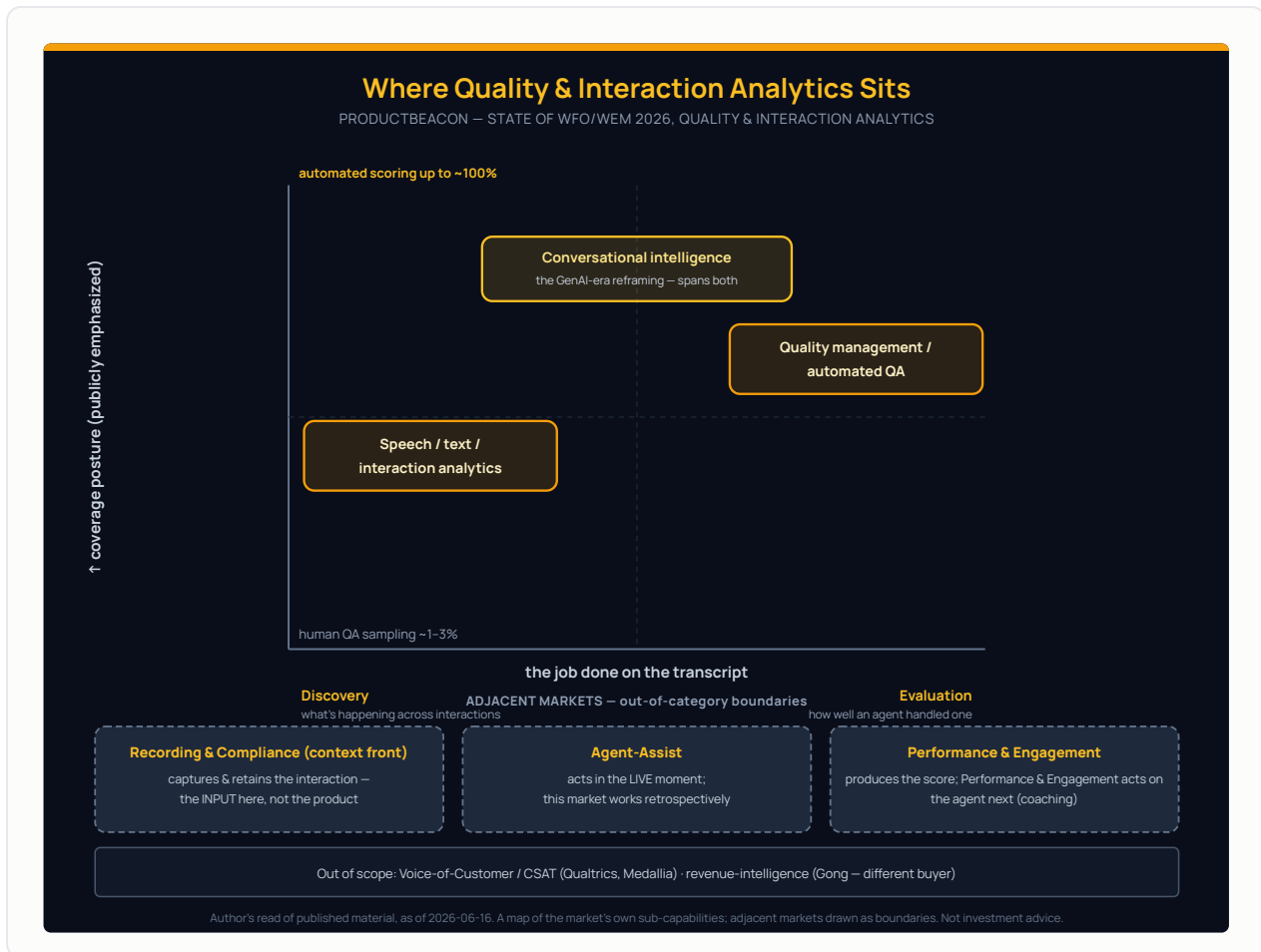
What this market is. Quality & Interaction Analytics is the software that scores and analyzes the *content* of agent-customer interactions – what was said, by whom, how well, and what it tells the business. It bundles three historically-distinct capabilities now converging on one transcript pipeline. **Quality management (QM / automated QA)** evaluates an agent's handling of an interaction against a scorecard. **Speech & text / interaction analytics** transcribes and mines interactions for topics, sentiment, compliance, and root cause. **Conversational intelligence** is the GenAI-era reframing of both. The category's defining promise in 2026 is the shift from human QA teams sampling ~1–3% of interactions to **automated scoring of up to 100%** of them.

Where the boundaries fall. The same interaction transcript feeds three markets, so the boundaries are drawn by *when* and *to what end* the content is used:

- **vs Recording & Compliance:** Recording *captures and retains* the interaction; this market *scores and analyses* it. Capture is the input, not the product here.
- **vs Agent-Assist:** Agent-Assist acts on the interaction in the *live moment* (real-time guidance); this market works *retrospectively* on the completed interaction. When a vendor does both, we classify it by its separately-positioned product line.
- **vs Performance & Engagement:** this market *produces the score*; Performance & Engagement owns *what you do with the agent next* (coaching, calibration, gamification). The QA-to-coaching loop is where the two overlap, dissected in Convergence.

What it IS NOT. It is not call capture/recording (the Recording & Compliance front), not forecasting/scheduling (Workforce Management), and not real-time assist (Agent-Assist). Voice-of-Customer / CSAT survey platforms (Qualtrics, Medallia) are deferred to v1.1: that is the *measurement layer above* WEM. Sales/revenue-intelligence (Gong and the like) serves a different buyer, the revenue org, and is excluded from this market's scope and sizing.

Three common buyer misconceptions. 1. *"Auto-QA replaces QA analysts."* In practice it reallocates them – from sampling-and-scoring to calibration, dispute handling, and coaching design. The headcount story is a *shift*, not a *delete*. Where it does delete, this report says so only on a named, public event. 2. *"100% scoring means 100% accuracy."* Scoring all interactions is a coverage claim, not an accuracy claim; GenAI auto-scores carry their own error modes and need human calibration, which is a live buyer-evaluation criterion. 3. *"Speech analytics and quality management are the same product."* Related, distinct buying motions: analytics is *discovery* (what's happening across interactions), QM is *evaluation* (how well an agent handled one). Many vendors sell both; the buyer often funds them on different lines.



Where the market sits: its own sub-capabilities on two axes, the job done on the transcript (Discovery to Evaluation) against coverage posture (human sampling ~1-3% to automated ~100%), with the adjacent markets drawn as out-of-category boundaries.

1.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. This market is sized under the analyst “**speech / interaction / conversation analytics**” segment definition: the standalone software that captures, transcribes, and analytically scores agent-customer interactions, including the automated-QA layer built on it. Grand View, MarketsandMarkets, Mordor, and DMG Consulting all use that definition. Excluded per the WEM↔Contact Center as a Service (CCaaS) boundary: the recording/capture layer (the Recording & Compliance front), real-time agent-assist (Agent-Assist), revenue-intelligence tools (Gong, different buyer), and the much larger general voice/speech-recognition market.

Market size: three independent public estimates (not averaged).

Source	Base	Forecast	CAGR
Grand View Research ¹	\$2.82B (2023)	\$7.73B by 2030	15.7%
MarketsandMarkets ²	\$3.3B (2024)	\$7.3B by 2029	17.5%
Mordor Intelligence ³	\$3.48B (2025)	\$8.16B by 2031	15.27%

The spread is the point. Base years span 2023–2026. The 2023 low (\$2.82B, Grand View)¹ against Mordor's 2026 figure (~\$4.0B)³ is a ~42% gap, partly calendar, partly category-boundary. The CAGR band, by contrast, is tight (~15.3–17.5%), and forecasts cluster near **\$7.3–8.2B in 2029–2031**. Longer-horizon outliers (Polaris ~\$11.5B/2032⁴; Research&Markets ~\$12.0B/2032⁵) roughly double that off a higher base and a longer window; SkyQuest is a low outlier (8.2% CAGR)⁶. Read it as: *analysts broadly agree on a high-teens-growth category landing near \$8B by ~2030, but disagree on where the line sits between “interaction analytics” and the broader “conversation-intelligence / Contact Center as a Service AI” blend*. That is the WEM↔Contact Center as a Service boundary tension the Convergence chapter exists to dissect. The dispersion is a boundary-definition artifact, not measurement error. *DMG Consulting's proprietary figure sits behind a paywall. It is therefore cited for vendor-roster and qualitative framing only, not as a quantitative anchor: disclosed, not estimated.*

Trends that move the buyer. (1) **100%-interaction scoring is now table stakes**⁷, not a differentiator. The value has moved up-stack from “we transcribe your calls” to “we score, coach, and flag every one.” (2) **GenAI scoring is displacing keyword-spotting**. Calabrio markets Auto QM as going “beyond simple keyword spotting”⁸. DMG calls the category “a strategic and essential enterprise AI component”⁹. (3) **The QA-to-coaching loop is the real job-to-be-done**. It closes the loop from scored interaction to skill gap to targeted coaching “without increasing headcount,”¹² which pulls the buyer toward the Agent-Assist supervisor. (4) **Adoption is broad and AI-led**. DMG's Dec-2024 survey found 78% of contact centers already actively engaged with AI.¹⁰

Compliance is decisive here. PCI DSS **data-level redaction** became mandatory 31 Mar 2025 (disk encryption no longer sufficient)¹¹, pushing redaction *into* the analytics layer. Routing conversations through third-party LLM APIs creates HIPAA/PCI/GLBA/GDPR/CCPA exposure and a live “where does my interaction data go” objection. And **EU AI Act transparency obligations reach full application in August 2026**¹¹, with AI scoring of agent performance squarely in scope. (*Sources: Grand View, MarketsandMarkets, Mordor, DMG, Deepgram, dated 2026-06-16.*)

1.3 The Contenders

Eight vendors are graded on the 3-bucket rubric (capped at eight). The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. Each positioning line carries

a verbatim, vendor-controlled pillar with a dated URL in the research ledger; capability/performance figures are quoted as *vendor claims*, never asserted as fact. AI-positioning reads are publicly-evidenced classifications, never an internal-architecture verdict.

Gravity tier

1. NICE: Enlighten AI (CXone Mpower). NICE positions Enlighten as the intelligence layer of one connected CX platform rather than a discrete QM product. The pillar is **“Purpose-built AI at the core of everything we do,”** with interaction analytics that “analyzes 100% of interactions for sentiment and agent soft-skill behaviors” feeding QM and coaching. *AI positioning:* established-platform, **legacy-data-anchored “purpose-built” AI.** NICE itself frames it as “CX-specific AI models trained and fine-tuned on 30 years of the industry’s largest CX data set.” That is a posture built on a legacy data asset, not a post-2017 agentic-native founding story.¹³ *Buyer:* large/regulated enterprise. *Pricing:* not public. *Material tier:* thick, graded on public material alone. NICE is a flagship proxy for the Convergence single-engine (P1) claim.

2. Thoma Bravo CX: Verint + Calabrio, graded as one entity. The take-private closed 26 Nov 2025 and merged Verint with Calabrio.¹⁴ The Verint pillar **“The CX Automation Company™”** rests on the open-platform bet that “the value has shifted to the intelligence layer.”¹⁵ Its 2026 QM hero, **Quality Bot,** is claimed to evaluate “up to 96% of calls”. One referenced brand is cited at “97% ... 200,000 calls/month”.¹⁶ Calabrio ONE remains the cloud-native WEM suite (verint.com). Echo AI is a capability *inside* this card. **The Echo AI acquisition** (by Calabrio, 11 Dec 2024) is reported per aggregator profile only; a primary release was not located, and terms are undisclosed. *Buyer:* large enterprise (Verint) + cloud-first mid-market (Calabrio). This card is the flagship **PE-roll-up** consolidation datapoint.

3. Genesys: Cloud Speech & Text Analytics + QM. Genesys ships native Contact-Center-as-a-Service-bundled QM/analytics that “automatically analyze 100% of customer-agent conversations,” with sentiment and agent-empathy detection feeding evaluations and coaching, and Cloud AI Studio as the connective layer.¹⁷ *Buyer:* mid-market-enterprise standardizing on one cloud suite. Genesys is a second single-engine (P1) proxy.

Attention tier

4. CallMiner: Conversation Intelligence & CX Automation. CallMiner is the largest independent best-of-breed pure-play; its pillar is **“Our platform analyzes every interaction, turning customer intelligence ... into smarter AI automation and better CX outcomes,”** on “100% of omnichannel interactions”¹⁸ with deep regulated-industry compliance. *AI positioning:* established (2002) and **proudly hybrid:** CallMiner publicly argues “LLMs are not always the optimal choice for highly specialized tasks,” treating GenAI as one technique layered on a multi-technique core. It is the cleanest vendor-endorsed “layered” read in the set. CallMiner was named a SPARK Matrix Conversational-Intelligence Leader for the fifth consecutive year on 26 May 2026 (BusinessWire).¹⁹ On 22 June 2026, after the research cut, CallMiner enhanced its RealTime product with “new AI guidance capabilities that deliver on-demand agent support with human-in-the-loop oversight” (callminer.com newsroom). That is the best-of-breed QM holder extending from after-the-fact analytics toward agent-initiated real-time assist.

5. Observe.AI: Auto QA. Observe.AI is the Auto-QA pure-play; its pillar is **“Automatically assess 100% of customer interactions ... objective, consistent, and free of bias,”** with calibration + dispute as the human control. *AI positioning:* AI-first-founded (2017) with a publicly-narrated analytics-to-**agentic** repositioning (30B-parameter domain LLM in 2023; VoiceAI Agents in 2025). The “began in 2017 ... Agentic CX Platform” origin line is a retroactive re-narration, cited as positioning, not as evidence. *Pricing:* directional third-party listings ~\$100–500/mo (not vendor-confirmed).²⁰

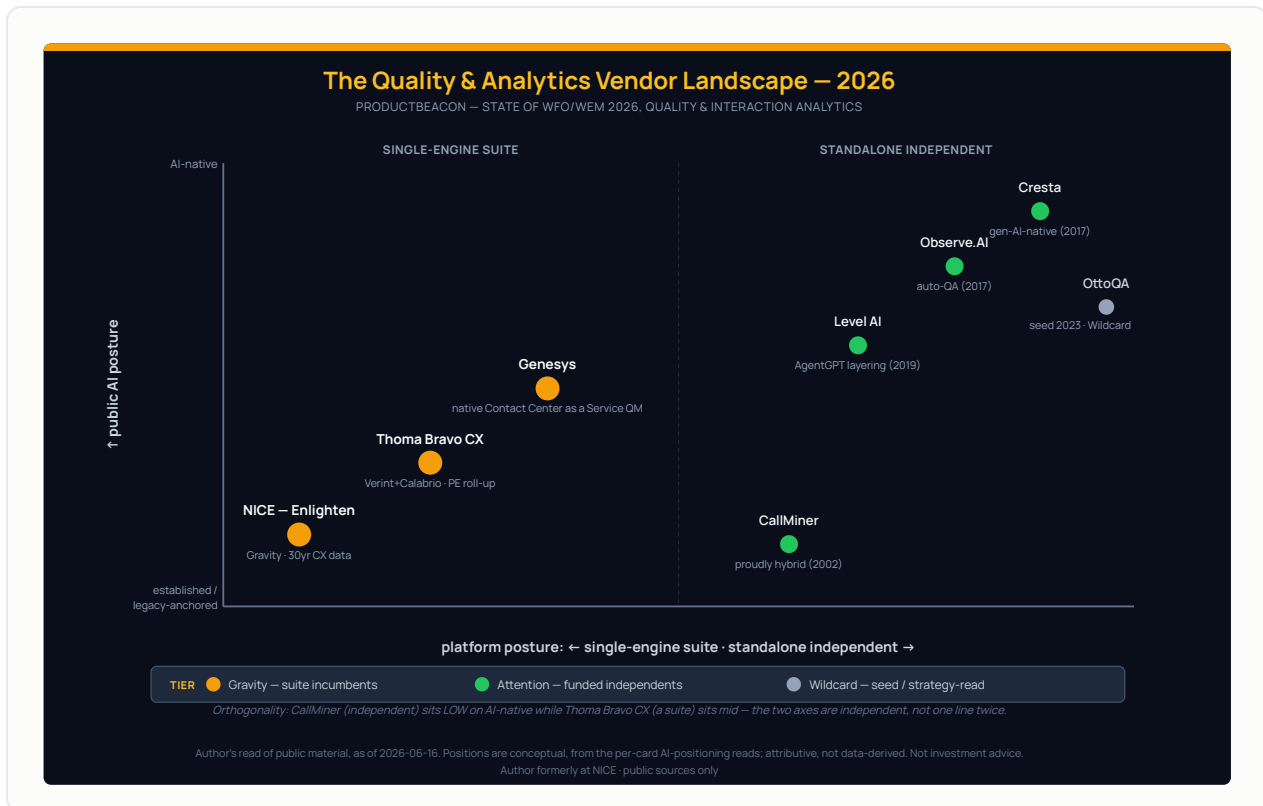
6. Cresta: Conversation Intelligence. Cresta is the Gen-AI-native platform unifying Insights, QM, and Coaching. Its differentiator: the AI “doesn’t just monitor for keywords, it understands context, behavior, and outcomes,” evaluating “100% of interactions ... at lower cost versus manual sampling.” *AI positioning:* the cleanest **AI-native** posture: founded 2017 out of the Stanford AI Lab, naming a “contact center foundation model,” Ocean-1.²¹ **Cresta’s foundation-model line** is cited as positioning; the internal training architecture is explicitly *not* adjudicated. Cresta was named a Forrester Wave Conversation-Intelligence Leader in Q2 2025. On 9 July 2026, after the research cut, Cresta launched **Training Simulator**, “an agentic training product for human agents that replaces scripted role-play with live, adaptive simulations using AI agents,” in the same platform as QA and Coaching (cresta.com / PRNewswire). The platform now spans QA, Coaching, and Training. *Present in two markets:* a card here, and a Play on Agent-Assist / Autonomous CX.

7. Level AI: Auto QA & VoC. Level AI is an analyst-recognized growth-stage challenger (Gartner Cool Vendor); it markets Auto-QA + Voice-of-Customer. *AI positioning:* a 2019 AI-first company that *itself* publishes that its generative layer “AgentGPT builds on Level AI’s existing conversational intelligence product suite”.²² That is a vendor-stated layering, citable without any internal inference. *Material tier:* medium.

Wildcard tier

8. OttoQA: self-serve auto-QA for smaller contact centers. OttoQA is the deliberately-thin sourcing hard-case: seed-stage, founded 2023 in Erie PA, on a ~\$240K seed. Its vendor pillar is **“Every call scored against your QA form. Under 30 seconds. Any language,”** with **“No IT. No platform to buy. Live in days.”** Notably it has **the most transparent public pricing in the set:** usage-based, month-to-month, a \$1,000 one-time setup, 200 free POC calls, and no seats (ottoqa.com).²³ That is a genuine pricing datapoint against the quote-gated incumbents. *Material tier:* thin; **the viability bright line applies, strategy opinion only, no survival/displacement claim absent a primary-source event.**

Cross-market note: NICE and Thoma Bravo CX span Recording and all five graded markets, each gradea once as a single entity. Cresta and Observe.AI are the two high-risk tri-market vendors whose primary home is set elsewhere. Five9, Uniphore, and Sprinklr are not covered here; they appear in What the Vendors Are Doing, with their primary home on other markets.



The eight contenders on platform posture (single-engine suite to standalone independent) against public AI posture (established / legacy-anchored to AI-native). Positions are attributive reads of the per-card public material (accessed 2026-06-16), not data-derived.

1.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: The single-engine repositioning

Suite vendors recast QM/analytics as outputs of one cross-market AI engine rather than standalone SKUs: NICE Enlighten “at the core of everything”¹³, the Verint open platform¹⁵, and Genesys Cloud AI Studio¹⁷. Best-of-breed is pushed to defend on depth, independence, and compliance. *Feeds Convergence P1.*

Play 2: The race to ~100% automated evaluation

Every tier publicly claims near-total coverage: Verint Quality Bot “up to 96%,”¹⁶ and Observe.AI, Cresta, Genesys, and NICE all “100%”. The likely outcome: coverage commoditizes by end-2026, and differentiation migrates to calibration trust, bias defensibility, and coaching action.

Play 3: Two consolidation engines pull in opposite directions

Thoma Bravo's PE roll-up (Verint+Calabrio)¹⁴ pulls against NICE's organic buy-and-build and Genesys' Contact Center as a Service bundle. Merging the overlapping Verint and Calabrio product lines is the watch-item through H1 2027.

Play 4: The acquisition sweep thins the independent bench

Echo AI went to Calabrio (Dec 2024), Loris to Contentsquare (Jul 2025)²⁴, and VOCALLS to CallMiner (Jun 2025). Genuine independent Wildcards are now scarce; the thinness of the tier is a signal in its own right.

Play 5: Adjacent-suite reach-in

Conversational-AI/VoC players extend evaluation into this market — Uniphore (agentic overlay)²⁵, Sprinklr ("Autonomous Evaluation" of AI-agent behavior, Spring '26)²⁶, Five9 Agentic QM (controlled availability 1Q 2026)²⁷. As AI agents take tier-1 volume, "quality" expands from evaluating *humans* to evaluating *AI agents*. That blurs Quality into Autonomous CX and feeds Convergence.

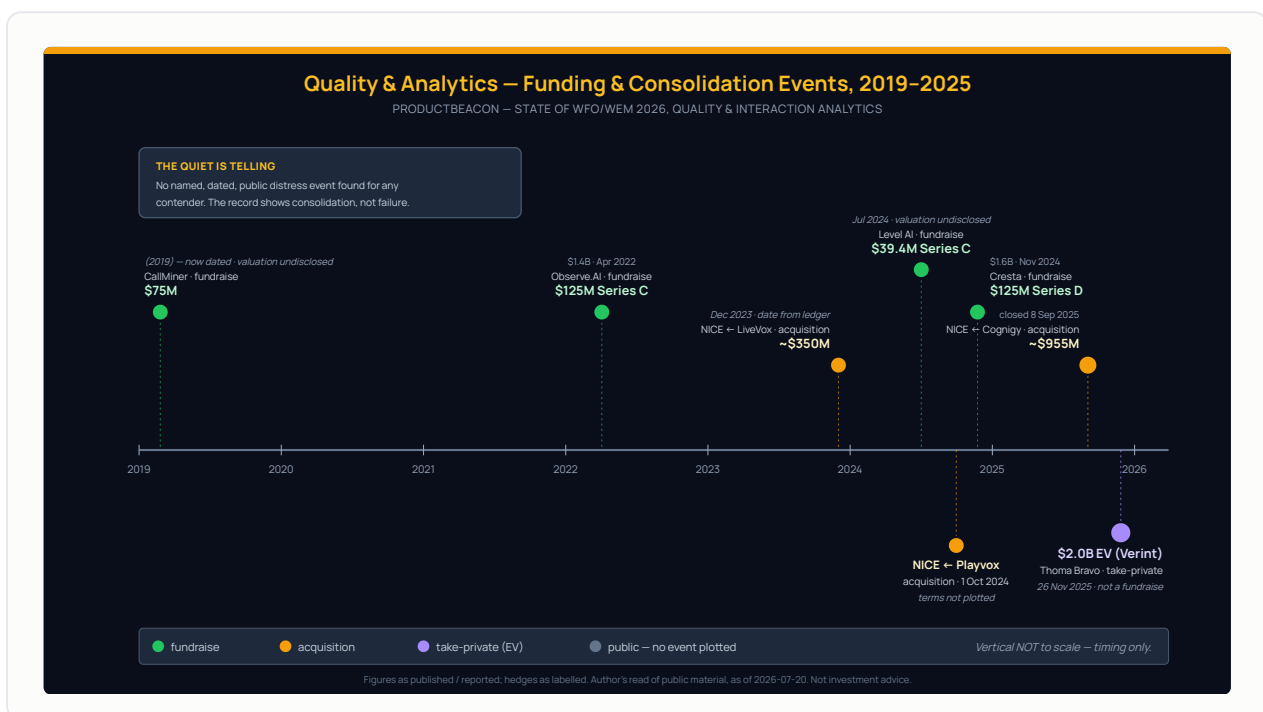
(Vendor pages cited inline in *The Contenders*, accessed 2026-06-16.)

1.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor / acquirer
NICE	Public; buy-and-build (Cognigy ~\$955M closed 8 Sep 2025 ²⁸ ; LiveVox ~\$350M ²⁹ ; Playvox ³⁰)	Public equity	Acquirer
Thoma Bravo CX (Verint+Calabrio)	Take-private closed 26 Nov 2025	\$2.0B EV (Verint) ³¹	Thoma Bravo
CallMiner	\$75M (2019) — dated ³²	Undisclosed	Goldman Sachs
Observe.AI	\$125M Series C (Apr 2022) ³³	\$1.4B	SoftBank Vision Fund 2
Cresta	\$125M Series D (Nov 2024) ³⁴	\$1.6B	WiL + QIA
Level AI	\$39.4M Series C (Jul 2024) ³⁵	Undisclosed	Adams Street
OttoQA (Wildcard)	~\$240K seed ³⁶	n/a	(seed)

Two consolidation engines. *Engine 1 – NICE’s organic buy-and-build play:* a public company buying AI capability into one owned stack (Cognigy for agentic AI, LiveVox for outbound, Playvox for WEM). It is funded off NICE’s balance sheet and integrated under CXone Mpower. *Engine 2 – Thoma Bravo’s PE roll-up:* private capital assembling a best-of-breed platform by combining Verint with Calabrio (which had itself absorbed Echo AI), run for cash generation and exit. One integrates to own its product direction; the other aggregates to own the installed base. Both point the same way: fewer independent QM/analytics vendors, more capability folded into multi-market suites.

Fault-lines (data thinness, disclosed not guessed). Level AI valuation is undisclosed; third-party \$750M–\$2.5B estimates are unsourced and not reported as fact. CallMiner’s last public round is the 2019 Goldman raise, now dated³². Echo AI’s Calabrio acquisition (11 Dec 2024) remains aggregator-verified only (Tracxn profile; primary release not located); terms undisclosed. **No named-dated-public distress event was found for any contender, so no viability claim is asserted.** (*Funding sources cited inline above, accessed 2026-06-16.*)



Funding and consolidation events by type. Vertical is not to scale; no distress event is plotted, because none was found in the public record.

1.6 Winning & Losing

The three pattern-claim callouts below are my read of where this market is heading. Each is anchored to public evidence already cited in this chapter, framed explicitly as opinion, and put as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint an outsider can watch.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Auto-QA Reallocation Thesis

Observation. Every tier now markets automated scoring of ~100% of interactions, all on dated 2026 vendor pages: - Verint Quality Bot: “up to 96% of calls”¹⁶ - Observe.AI: “100% ... objective, consistent, and free of bias”²⁰ - Cresta: “100% ... at lower cost versus manual sampling”²¹ - NICE/Genesys: “100% of interactions.”¹³¹⁷

My read. Once everyone can score everything, “100% coverage” stops differentiating; the contest moves to calibration trust, bias defensibility, and whether the score actually drives coaching. The human-in-the-loop control becomes the pitch, not the coverage number. The QA analyst is reallocated to calibration and coaching, not deleted.

Conditional prediction. If by Q4 2026 the leading vendors’ headline QM marketing copy has shifted away from coverage percentages toward calibration, bias-defensibility, and coaching-outcome language, the reallocation thesis holds; if “100%” is still the headline number, it has not.

Sources. Vendor QM/analytics pages, accessed 2026-06-16: verint.com, observe.ai, cresta.com, nice.com, genesys.com.

Claim 1 – The Auto-QA reallocation

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Once everyone scores 100%, coverage stops differentiating. The contest moves up.

TODAY – the hero number

100% coverage

every tier claims it
(Verint 96% / NICE / Cresta /
Observe.AI / Genesys)

commoditizing

contest moves

NEXT – the real pitch

calibration trust

bias defensibility

coaching outcome

analyst reallocated, not deleted

FALSIFIABLE TEST

Checkpoint Q4 2026: does QM hero-messaging drop the coverage % for calibration language?

Dashed = forecast.

Author's read of public material. Sources: vendor QM/analytics pages, accessed 2026-06-16. Not investment advice.

Claim 1 – The Auto-QA reallocation: once every tier scores ~100%, coverage commoditizes and the contest moves to calibration trust, bias defensibility, and coaching outcome; the analyst is reallocated, not deleted.

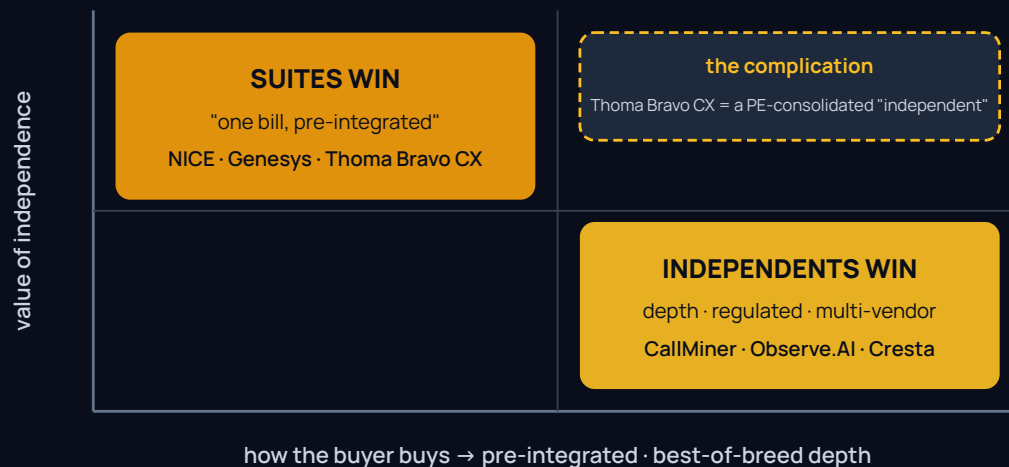
Pattern Claim 2 – The Independent-Depth Defense

Observation. Three suites position QM/analytics as outputs of one cross-market AI engine. NICE markets “purpose-built AI at the core of everything we do”¹³. Verint says “the value has shifted to the intelligence layer”¹⁵. Genesys claims native “100% of conversations”¹⁷. The independents (CallMiner, Observe.AI, Cresta) defend on analytics depth, regulated-industry compliance, and independence from any single Contact Center as a Service stack. **My read.** The suites win the “one bill, pre-integrated” buyer; the independents win the depth / regulated / multi-vendor buyer. This is the market-level instance of the report’s central question. The Thoma Bravo Verint+Calabrio combination complicates it: the largest “independent” is now a PE-consolidated platform. **Conditional prediction.** If through H1 2027 independent best-of-breed analytics vendors still win the majority of net-new competitive displacements in regulated-vertical enterprise deals, depth-and-independence remains a durable defense; if suite-bundled QM takes the majority, the single-engine collapse is real at the market level. **Sources.** Vendor platform pages, accessed 2026-06-16: nice.com, verint.com, genesys.com, callminer.com, observe.ai, cresta.com.

Claim 2 – The independent-depth defense

STAFF REPORT, Q1 2026 · QUALITY & INTERACTION ANALYTICS

Two buyers, two winners. Suites take convenience; independents hold depth.



FALSIFIABLE TEST – through H1 2027

If independent best-of-breed analytics vendors still win the majority of net-new competitive displacements in regulated-vertical enterprise deals, depth-and-independence remains durable; if suite-bundled QM takes the majority, the single-engine collapse is real at the market level.

Author's read of public material. Vendor platform pages accessed 2026-06-16. Not investment advice.

Claim 2 – The independent-depth defense: suites win the pre-integrated buyer, independents hold the depth / regulated / multi-vendor buyer, and Thoma Bravo CX complicates the line as a PE-consolidated “independent.”

Pattern Claim 3 – The Vanishing Wildcard

Observation. The independent QA-AI middle, the independent vendors sitting between the suites and the seed-stage entrants, is being absorbed before it reaches scale: Echo AI into Calabrio (Dec 2024), Loris into Contentsquare (Jul 2025)²⁴, VOCALLS into CallMiner (Jun 2025). A deliberate sweep of the vendor universe surfaced only one genuinely-independent, genuinely-thin Wildcard (OttoQA, seed-stage)²³. **My read.** The scarcity of the Wildcard tier is the signal: acquirers are buying that middle tier before it consolidates into Gravity, thinning the independent bench that the depth defense (Claim 2) relies on. **Conditional prediction.** If by mid-2027 at least two more current Attention-tier independents are acquired into a suite or PE platform, the standalone QA-AI category is consolidating toward a suite-vs-platform structure; if new independently-funded entrants reach Series B in the space, the bench is replenishing. **Sources.** The acquisition record set out in Funding & Fault-Lines and What the Vendors Are Doing: Echo AI into Calabrio (Dec 2024), Loris into Contentsquare (Jul 2025), VOCALLS into CallMiner (Jun 2025).

Claim 3 – The vanishing wildcard STATE OF WFO/WEM 2026 - QUALITY & INTERACTION ANALYTICS

The independent QA-AI middle is absorbed before it reaches scale.



A deliberate sweep of the vendor universe surfaced only ONE genuinely-independent, genuinely-thin wildcard.

FALSIFIABLE TEST

Checkpoint mid-2027: +2 more Attention-tier independents absorbed = the category is consolidating.

Sources: Echo AI → Calabrio (Dec 2024), Loris → Contentsquare (Jul 2025), VOCALLS → CallMiner (Jun 2025).

Author's read of public material, as of 2026-07-20. Not investment advice.

Claim 3 – The vanishing wildcard: the independent QA-AI middle is absorbed before it reaches scale, leaving OttoQA the lone genuinely-thin Wildcard.

Winners

NICE, Genesys, and Thoma Bravo CX. In my read, the three Gravity suites are pulling ahead on integration convenience: the “one bill, pre-integrated” buyer wants quality management delivered as an output of a connected platform, not a standalone tool. Their Gravity placement in The Contenders and the single-engine repositioning in What the Vendors Are Doing carry that read. NICE and Genesys, whose native 100%-interaction scoring is the clearest expression of that pitch, are the ones to beat for that buyer.

CallMiner, Observe.AI, and Cresta. I see the strongest independents holding the depth line for the regulated, best-of-breed, multi-vendor buyer at the center of the independent-depth defense. That buyer is buying CallMiner's hybrid multi-technique posture and regulated-industry depth, Observe.AI's auto-QA focus, and Cresta's gen-AI-native positioning²¹, all Attention-tier cards in The Contenders.

Watch

OttoQA. I'd watch the self-serve, transparent-pricing entrant opening the un-served small contact-center segment. It is a different game than the enterprise contest, and the one place in this market where pricing is actually public; the Wildcard card and pricing note in The Contenders carry that read. Its viability stays a strategy read only, not a survival call.

Level AI. I see the most likely next fold-in: a growth-stage Attention-tier independent with exactly the profile the acquisition sweep in What the Vendors Are Doing keeps absorbing. A deal here would confirm the thinning bench flagged in The Road Ahead.

Losers

I am not naming a loser in this market, and I will not manufacture one. Funding & Fault-Lines found no named, dated, public distress event for any contender. What the record shows instead is consolidation, not failure: the independent QA-AI middle being bought before it reaches scale (Echo AI into Calabrio, Dec 2024; Loris into Contentsquare, Jul 2025²⁴; VOCALLS into CallMiner, Jun 2025). Those are acquisitions of capable assets, not exits under duress. The vendors whose fate is genuinely contested sit under Watch.

1.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **Verint + Calabrio overlapping product lines** through H1 2027 – QM/WFM/analytics lines doubled up under one Thoma Bravo owner; the clearest test of whether the PE roll-up integrates or just aggregates.
2. **“Quality” turning from evaluating humans to evaluating AI agents:** Sprinklr “Autonomous Evaluation,” Five9 Agentic QM (controlled availability 1Q 2026). This is where Quality & Interaction

Analytics starts blurring into Autonomous CX.

3. **Whether “100%” gives way to calibration/bias-defensibility** as the headline claim (Pattern Claim 1’s checkpoint) by Q4 2026.
4. **Compliance pressure pushing into the analytics layer:** EU AI Act transparency (full application Aug 2026) + PCI DSS data-level redaction reshaping how interaction data is processed and where AI scores must be human-validated.
5. **The next independent acquisition** (Pattern Claim 3’s checkpoint) — a Level-AI-class vendor folded into a suite or PE platform would confirm the thinning bench.

Chapter 2 – The Workforce Management Market

2.1 What This Market Is

What this market is. Workforce Management is the software that gets the **right number of right-skilled people in the right place at the right time** – and proves it did so at minimum cost without breaking service levels or burning agents out. It is four linked jobs on one demand-and-supply loop. **Forecasting** predicts contact volume and handle time by channel and interval. **Scheduling** builds shifts and skills to match the forecast. **Intraday management** tracks adherence in real time and re-forecasts as the day drifts. And **adherence / real-time agent management** keeps the live floor on plan. Forecasting accuracy is the hard, value-determining part; scheduling is the visible part.

The three sub-segments. A buyer who runs one of these will bounce off a report that only talks about another:

- **Contact-center WFM:** the classic: interaction-arrival demand (calls/chats/emails/messaging) forecast to the interval.
- **Back-office / branch WFM:** work-item-queue demand (cases, claims, applications) and branch/field staffing, where the demand signal is a backlog, not an arrival rate.
- **Gig / flex staffing:** on-demand agent pools and flexible micro-shifts, a newer model that breaks the fixed-roster assumption WFM was built on.

Where the boundaries fall.

- **vs Quality & Analytics:** Analytics scores the *interaction*; WFM schedules the *person*. Different objects.
- **vs Performance & Engagement:** WFM puts the agent on shift; Performance & Engagement coaches and engages them. **Adherence and burnout are the overlap:** schedule flexibility is increasingly sold as a retention lever, which pulls WFM toward Performance & Engagement.
- **vs Contact Center as a Service (CCaaS) routing/ACD:** Routing decides which agent takes *this* contact in real time; WFM decides *how many agents of which skill exist on the roster* in the first place. Routing is real-time allocation; WFM is supply planning. That is the line.

What it IS NOT. It is not routing/ACD (Contact Center as a Service), not QM/analytics (Quality & Interaction Analytics), and not enterprise HCM/payroll (Workday, UKG), though gig/flex staffing blurs into workforce-scheduling-adjacent HR. It is not field-service scheduling for technicians (a separate category).

Three common buyer misconceptions. 1. “WFM is just scheduling.” Scheduling is downstream of forecasting; a perfect schedule against a wrong forecast still overstaffs or misses SLAs. The forecast is where the money is. 2. “AI forecasting removes the planner.” It shifts the planner from building forecasts to managing scenarios, exceptions, and the intraday drift the model didn't see. That is a reallocation, not

a deletion. The pattern matches auto-QA in Quality & Interaction Analytics. 3. “*Contact-center WFM and back-office WFM are the same product.*” Different demand signals (interval arrival vs work-item backlog) and different buyers; many suites do both, but the buyer funds and evaluates them differently.

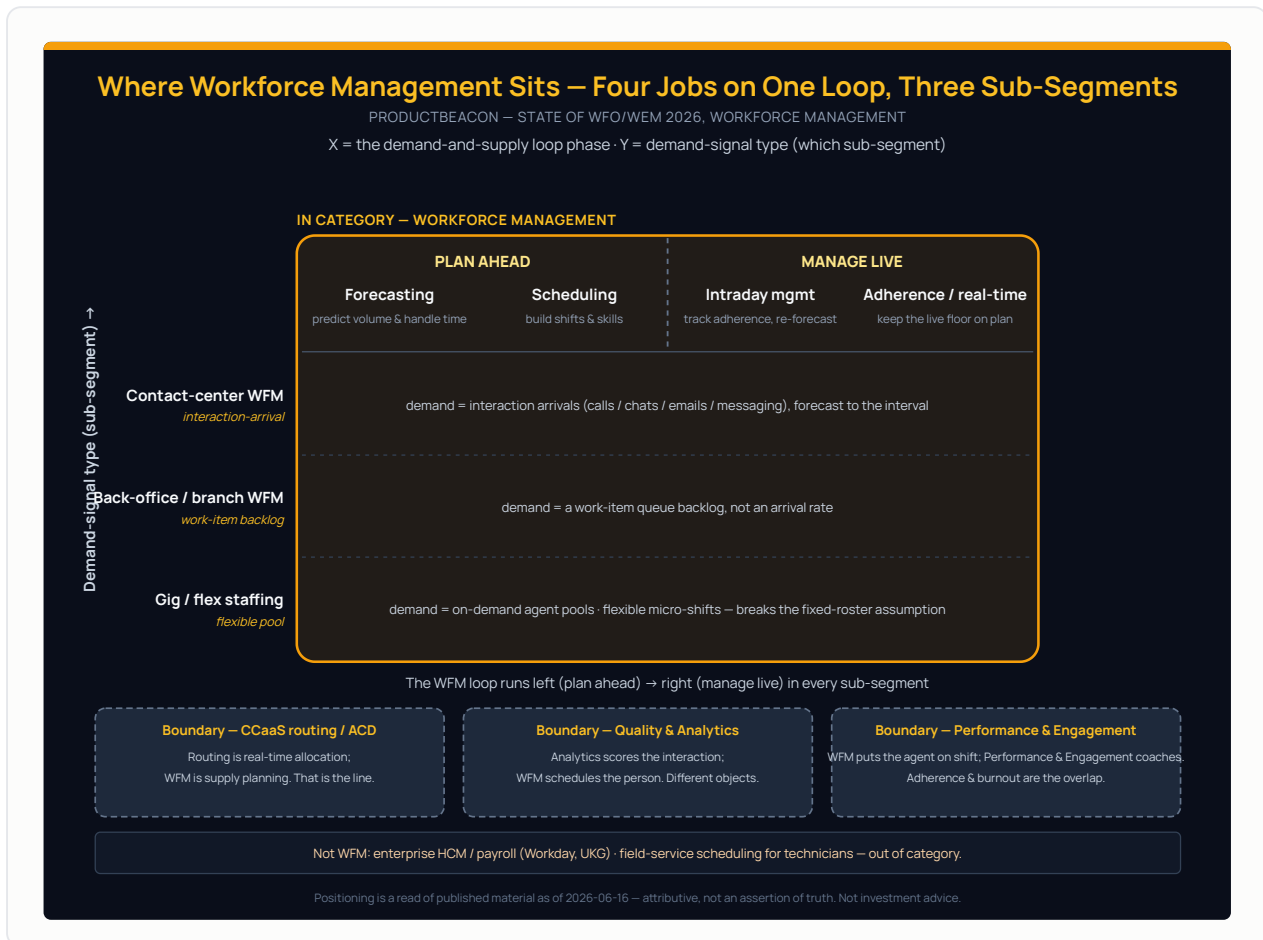


Figure 2.1 – Where WFM sits: four jobs on one demand-and-supply loop (the X axis), three demand-signal sub-segments (the Y axis), and the adjacent-market boundaries.

2.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. The market is sized under the “**workforce management (WFM) software**” category: forecasting, scheduling, intraday, and adherence, across the three named sub-segments (contact-center / back-office-branch / gig-flex). **The gap between the two market definitions is the finding.** The public named-analyst WFM dollar numbers measure a much bigger market: all enterprise HR-labor scheduling (top vendors Oracle, SAP, Workday, UKG, ADP). That is far broader than the contact-center WFM this report actually grades (NICE, Verint, Calabrio, Genesys, Aspect); no public figure isolates the contact-center slice. We report the broad market as the outer bound and anchor the contact-center floor to the one public seat-share datapoint, never a fabricated dollar carve-out.

The broad-WFM market (the outer bound, not the contact-center number).

Source	Base	Forecast	CAGR	reads the market as
Grand View Research ³⁷	\$8.07B (2022)	\$19.35B by 2030	11.7%	accelerating (AI scheduling)
MarketsandMarkets ³⁸	\$8.38B (2025)	\$13.03B by 2030	9.2%	mid
Mordor Intelligence ³⁹	\$9.36B (2025)	\$12.04B by 2031	4.29%	mature/saturated

The CAGR split is diagnostic. Base years cluster (~\$8.4–9.8B in 2026), but the CAGRs diverge ~3×: Mordor reads the Oracle/SAP/Workday installed base as mature, while Grand View reads AI-scheduling demand lifting the broad market. No single WFM TAM is defensible from these sources, and the broad market is **not** the contact-center market.

The contact-center-WFM anchor. No public, non-paywalled *dollar* sizing isolates contact-center WFM (DMG’s “Workforce Management in the Age of AI: 2026 CX Market Report,” 18 May 2026, is authoritative but paid)⁴⁰. The one public, dated, reader-checkable datapoint is a **seat-share** one: DMG has ranked **NICE the contact-center WFM share leader for 12 consecutive years at 32.1%** (workforcemanagementtoday.com republishing DMG)⁴¹. **DMG’s figure** is data through 2020 – stale, and a share, not a size. It establishes the shape that matters: contact-center WFM is a **concentrated, NICE-led sub-market inside the larger, fragmented HR-WFM market**.

Trends that move the buyer. (1) **Forecasting moved from single-model to parallel-model auto-selection:** engines now “evaluate multiple algorithms in parallel and automatically select the best-fit model” (DMG, 2026)⁴⁰. (2) **Agentic/proactive intraday is the new edge**, moving from spotting a service-level breach to systems that “predict deviations before they occur and *recommend or execute* real-time adjustments.”⁴⁰ That is intraday crossing from decision-support into autonomous *action*. (3) **Back-office / “effort-based work” expansion** runs beyond the contact-center queue (ActiveOps-class positioning). (4) **Hybrid human–AI staffing is the new planning unit:** 2026 WFM coordinates “a broader mix of human agents, AI agents, bots, and automated workflows” (DMG)⁴⁰, feeding the seat-displacement vector. (5) **Gig/flex staffing is an adjacent, far larger, separately-sized pool** (on-demand staffing ~\$74.6B⁴²; gig platforms ~\$36.7B⁴³). It is *named in scope but explicitly NOT counted in the WFM-software number, to avoid double-counting a staffing-services market into a software TAM*.

Compliance: labor-law, not data-redaction. Predictive-scheduling / “**fair workweek**” laws (Oregon; Seattle, SF, NYC, Chicago, Philadelphia) constrain algorithmic scheduling with advance-notice and predictability-pay. A demand/cost-optimizing AI can generate non-compliant schedules, so the labor-rules constraint layer is now a buyer requirement. AI scoring of adherence sits in the path of the **EU AI Act** (full application Aug 2026) and US state AI-disclosure laws. **Gig-worker classification** is the live risk on the gig-flex extension. (*Sources cited inline above, accessed 2026-06-16.*)

2.3 The Contenders

Eight contenders are graded on the three-tier rubric (the cap is eight), each card carrying a verbatim vendor pillar with its dated URL inline. The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. AI-positioning reads are publicly-evidenced classifications, never internal-architecture verdicts. WFM **inverts** the analytics market: the loudest *agentic* narrative comes from the most-established platform (Verint), while forecasting incumbents publicly *de-emphasize* GenAI.

Gravity tier

1. NICE: IEX WFM (CXone Mpower). Pillar “**AI-powered workforce management software for contact centers,**” with “**more than 45 AI-powered forecasting algorithms**” and a “**Best Pick**” model selecting the most accurate forecast per day (nice.com)⁴⁴. *AI positioning:* ML model-selection over a proprietary forecasting engine, with GenAI kept at the *insight* layer rather than the forecasting frame. The public posture is depth-led, not agentic-led. *Material tier:* thick, graded on public material alone. No public accuracy number is published, so the card stays to what the pages claim. It is also the long-standing contact-center WFM seat-share leader: DMG puts it at 32.1%.⁴¹ **DMG’s figure** is data through 2020 – stale, and a share, not a size. NICE is a Convergence P1 proxy.

2. Thoma Bravo CX: Verint + Calabrio (one entity; take-private closed 26 Nov 2025)⁴⁷. **Both absorbed lines are top-tier WFM**, so the overlap to rationalize is heavier here than on Quality & Interaction Analytics. Verint’s pillar is “**Ensure you have the right employees doing the right work at the right time,**” and it calls itself “a leading provider of workforce management software for over 20 years.” It runs a dedicated **back-office WFM** line and the **TimeFlex Bot** for AI self-scheduling, with a vendor-claimed “up to 30% decreased attrition” (verint.com)⁴⁵. Calabrio ONE WFM is “cloud-native, with AI at its core,” per its product page. Its forecasting/scheduling/intraday is pitched as software “that anticipates, adapts and acts in real time” (calabrio.com)⁴⁶. *AI positioning:* the **loudest agentic narrative in the set**, “Agentic AI doesn’t just flag a service-level miss, it reschedules, reallocates...” (verint.com, 2026-03-24)⁴⁸. The narrative is operationalized as named bots *added* to an existing platform. After the research cut, Verint and Calabrio presented unified under the **Verint** brand at Engage 2026, the first conference since the take-private close, and launched **Agent Factory**, an orchestration environment for human and AI agent workforces (verint.com / BusinessWire, 23 Jun 2026). CEO Dave Rhodes framed the announcements as “in a lot of ways... more repositioning of technology that we’ve had in place” (attributed, CMSWire). His own framing is the counterweight to the launch. This is the flagship PE-roll-up datapoint.

3. Genesys: Cloud WFM. Pillar “**Streamline Scheduling and Boost Efficiency.**” It ships AI-powered forecasting across voice/chat/email/messaging/social, with automated scheduling “without needing much, if any, human intervention.” It is positioned as native, “built into the overall platform rather than as a bolt-on” (genesys.com)⁴⁹. Genesys is a Convergence P1 proxy.

Attention tier

4. Assembled: WFM for the AI era. Assembled is the clearest WFM repositioning around AI-agent staffing. Pillar “**Workforce management built for the AI era,**” per its homepage. Its wedge is “**the only platform that unifies**” in-house agents, BPO, and AI “on separate tools,” with vendor-claimed “over 90% accuracy” ML forecasting (assembled.com)⁵⁰. *AI positioning:* founded in the AI era (2018), claiming “AI-powered schedule generation... in minutes.” It sits *inside* two Contact Center as a Service suites’ go-to-market (Five9 recommended WFM partner, 2024; Genesys integration) while staying independent. *Pricing:* published directional ~\$25/user/mo. Assembled is a falsification-condition vendor for the Convergence thesis.

5. Peopleware (injixo + InVision). Peopleware is the operating brand; the injixo product brand is retired at the domain level and continues as lineage. Pillar “**The AI-native WFM suite for contact centers,**” with three explicitly-named layers (Agentic / Predictive / Optimization AI) and EU data-residency emphasis (peopleware.com)⁵¹. *AI positioning:* established cloud-WFM that *publicly de-emphasizes* GenAI (“the applications of generative AI in workforce management are limited,” injixo/Peopleware, 2024-03-12)⁵². The posture is anti-hype: machine learning, not GenAI. *Pricing:* among the most transparent (published tiers).

6. Aspect (Alvaria subsidiary). The reborn Aspect brand carries Alvaria’s Enterprise Workforce Suite, modernized into **WorkforceOS** “powered by predictive analytics.” Its Q4-2025 “**AI-Powered Forecasting**” release includes “Predictive Forecasting... automatically generates four-week call volume forecasts that refresh daily” (BusinessWire, 18 Nov 2025)⁵³. After the research cut, Aspect launched **Aspect Intelligence™**, an AI-powered workforce intelligence platform, and appointed **Jeff Kupietzky permanent CEO** (BusinessWire, 8 Jul 2026). A formal Aspect × Five9 partnership (announced 26 Mar 2026) pairs real-time demand signals with staffing and scheduling. It is heritage scale repositioned for the AI era.

7. Central: workforce engagement / performance + gamification. Central is Israel-founded (2013, ex-Gameffective). Its pillar is the “**gamified employee performance management**” platform, combining microlearning, performance, engagement and gamification. It is named a “Leader in the 2025 SPARK Matrix for Workforce Engagement” (central.com)⁵⁴. *Cross-market note:* Central’s primary home is Performance & Engagement; it appears here as the engagement-adjacent WFM datapoint, and the full grading lives in that chapter.

Wildcard tier

8. Cisne: agentic WFM with “Swan Droids.” Cisne is the thinnest-sourced entry in the set. It is a self-described “disruptor... built AI-native from the ground up,” embedding autonomous agents (“Swan Droids”) that “manage core WFM functions, including forecasting, real-time monitoring, scheduling.” In that framing, a “Real-Time Analytics Droid detects incoming demand spikes and automatically triggers the Staffing Droid”. GA in the Americas came **30 Apr 2026** (cxfoundation.com WFM-providers roundup)⁵⁵. *Material tier:* thin, single named-outlet anchor, no disclosed funding/founder; **the viability bright line applies: strategy opinion only, no viability claim.**

Five9 appears in the Plays and the funding ledger, not as a graded card. It took the Assembled-partner route, so its public WFM surface is thinner, and the same public-evidence bar that admits the eight cards keeps it out.

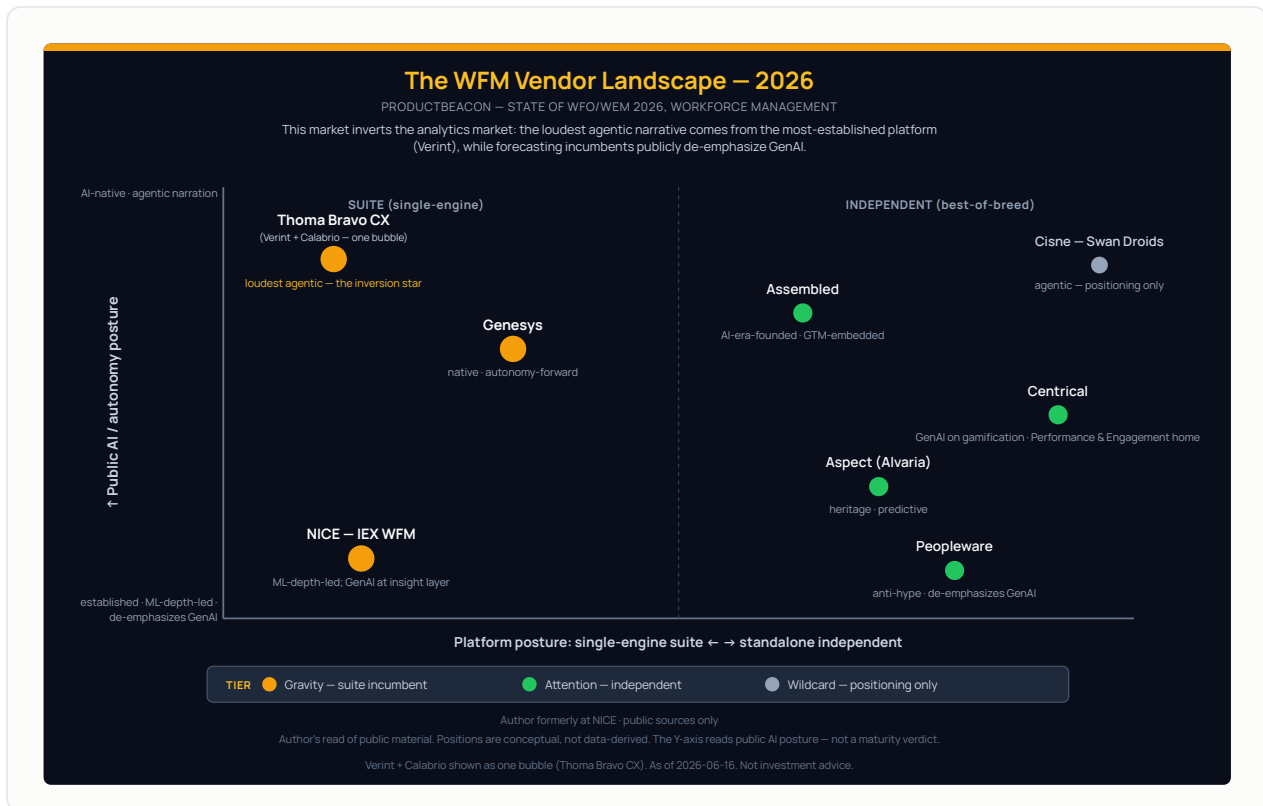


Figure 2.3 — The WFM vendor landscape: platform posture (suite ↔ independent) against public AI/autonomy posture. Verint + Calabrio are shown as one bubble; Cisne is a grey Wildcard, positioning-only. This market inverts the analytics market.

2.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: WFM becomes the planning module of one AI platform

NICE runs IEX under CXone Mpower, Genesys ships WFM native (“not a bolt-on”) ⁴⁹, and Calabrio ONE unites WFM with conversation intelligence and engagement. The independents (Assembled, Peopleware, Aspect) are pushed to defend on depth, openness, and AI-agent staffing. *The Play feeds Convergence P1.*

Play 2: The autonomous-forecasting/scheduling race

Every tier pushes its forecasting and scheduling toward greater autonomy (per the Contenders cards, dated 2026). The likely outcome: AI forecasting commoditizes by end-2026, and differentiation migrates to *autonomous intraday action* and *blended-workforce staffing*, the level above static algorithm depth.

Play 3: PE roll-up brings two full WFM stacks under one owner

Thoma Bravo now owns both Verint Enterprise/Back-Office WFM and Calabrio ONE WFM.⁴⁷ That is a harder rationalization than the quality-management overlap on Quality & Interaction Analytics, and it makes the two-stack merge the H1-2027 watch-item.

Play 4: Suites buy or partner into modern WFM, thinning the bench

Zendesk absorbed Tymeshift (2023)⁵⁶ and Dialpad absorbed Surfboard (2024)⁵⁷; Five9 partnered with Assembled rather than rebuilding. Genuinely-independent sub-Series-B WFM startups are now scarce. The thin Wildcard tier is the signal. Between mid-June and 20 July 2026, the suite side sharpened the pressure. Zendesk announced a free lite WFM tier bundled into Suite Professional (Zendesk announcement, June 2026). Microsoft shipped workforce engagement management natively in Dynamics 365 (microsoft.com, 22 Jun 2026). Suite-bundled WFM at zero or bundled marginal price is direct pressure on independent WFM economics.

Play 5: WFM expands from staffing humans to humans + BPO + AI agents

This is Assembled's explicit wedge, and the agentic/autonomous framing (Aspect, Cisne, Peopleware) points the same way. It blurs Workforce Management into Autonomous CX, and this is where the per-seat → per-outcome migration begins: the buyer stops paying per agent seat and starts paying per resolution. The seat stops being a human.

(Vendor pages cited inline in The Contenders, accessed 2026-06-16.)

2.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor / acquirer
NICE	Public; WFM heritage = IEX (~\$200M, 2006) ⁵⁸ ; + Playvox (2024) ⁵⁹	Public equity	Acquirer
Thoma Bravo CX (Verint+Calabrio)	Take-private closed 26 Nov 2025	\$2.0B EV (Verint) ⁶⁰	Thoma Bravo
Assembled	\$51M Series B (May 2022) ⁶¹ ; ~\$71M total	Not disclosed (self- reported ">5x/yr")	NEA (lead), Emergence
Peopleware (injixo+InVision)	No verifiable public round located ⁶²	—	Private (independent)
Aspect (Alvaria)	Aspect+Noble merger (May 2021), reported >\$1B combined ⁶³	Not a filing (named- outlet)	Abry Partners + Vector Capital
Central	\$32M (10 Mar 2021, Intel Capital + JVP); ~\$64M total — <i>not</i> labeled "Series C"	Not disclosed	Intel Capital, JVP
Cisne (Wildcard)	No disclosed round	n/a	—

Two consolidation engines run through WFM. NICE's engine builds and buys into one owned stack: it built WFM by owning the IEX line (DMG's contact-center WFM seat-share leader on 2020 data)⁴¹ and adding Playvox. Thoma Bravo's PE roll-up brought **two full top-tier WFM stacks** (Verint + Calabrio) under one owner. The WFM overlap is the heavier of the two consolidation tests: overlapping forecasting/scheduling/intraday lines are harder to rationalize than a single quality-management overlap. One engine integrates to own the product direction; the other aggregates two installed bases that now overlap.

Fault-lines (disclosed, not guessed). Peopleware/injixo has no verifiable public funding round located, so none is asserted. Assembled shows only a relative, self-reported ">5x/yr" mark (no absolute valuation), now ~4 years stale. Alvaria's ">\$1B" is named-outlet reporting, not a filing (both targets were already private). **No named-dated-public distress event was found for any contender, so the report asserts no viability claim.** (*Funding sources cited inline above, accessed 2026-06-16.*)

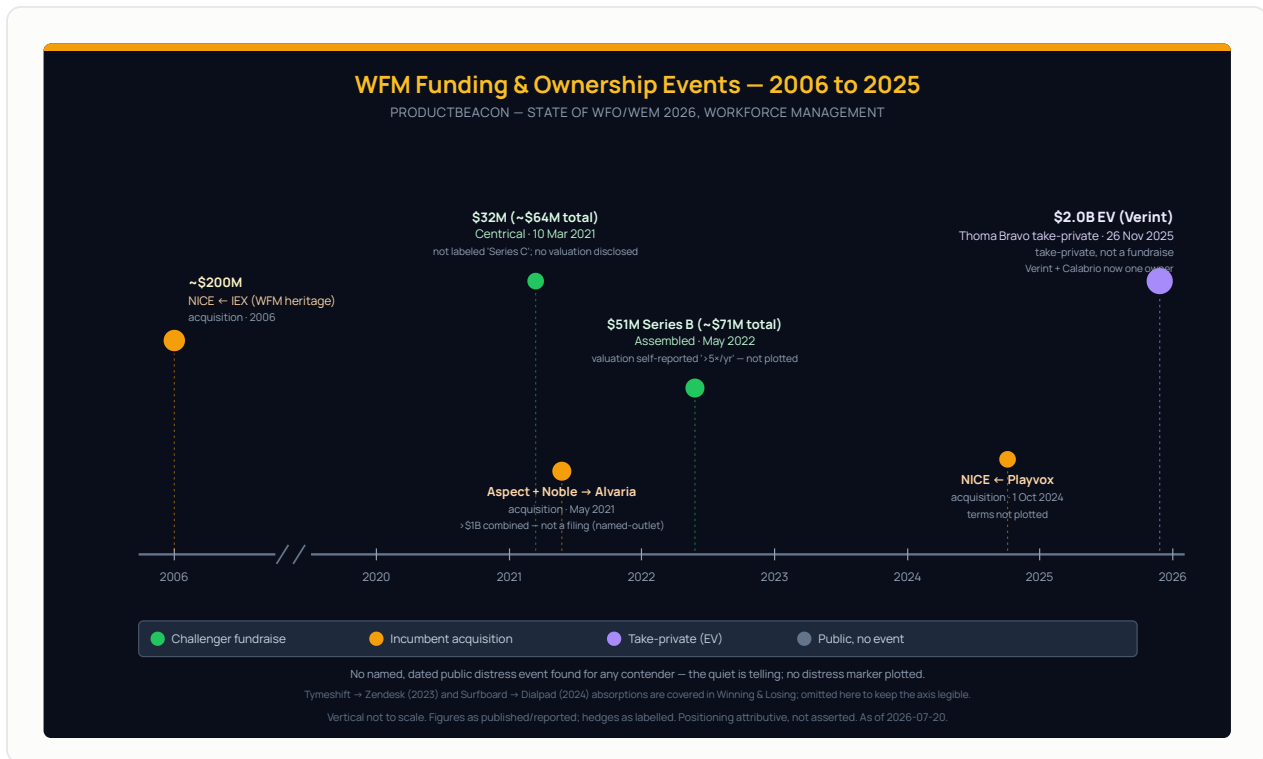


Figure 2.5 – WFM funding and ownership events, 2006–2025, by event type. Vertical not to scale; no named, dated public distress event was found for any contender.

2.6 Winning & Losing

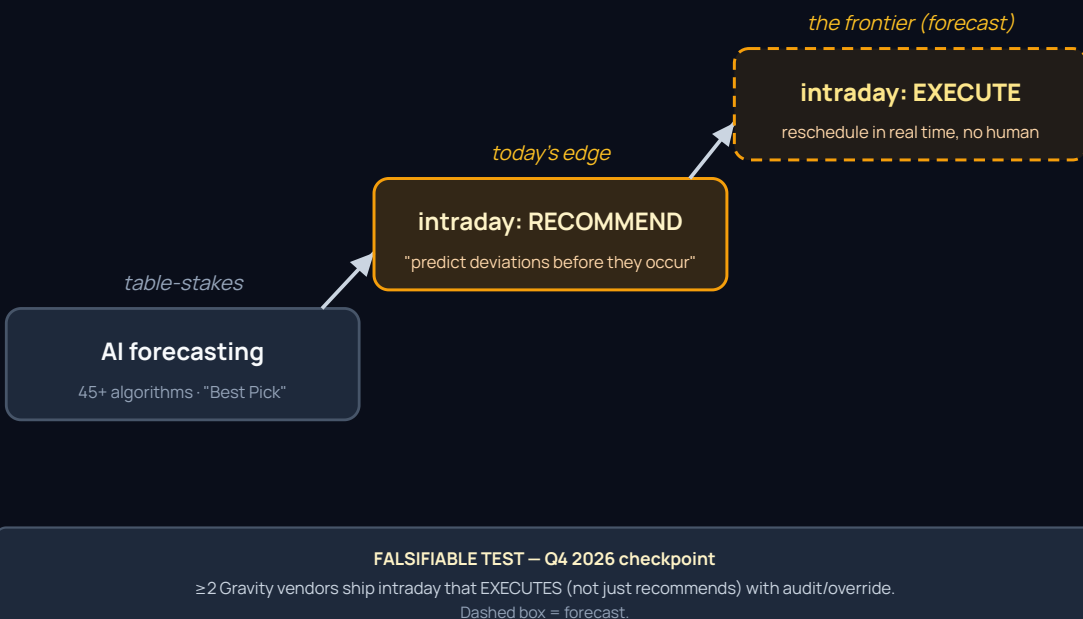
The three pattern-claim callouts below are my read of where this market is heading. Each is anchored to public evidence already cited in this chapter, framed explicitly as opinion, and put as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint an outsider can watch.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Autonomous-Intraday Frontier

Observation. AI forecasting is now claimed by every tier: NICE claims “45+ algorithms / Best Pick”⁴⁴, Genesys claims near-autonomous scheduling⁴⁹, and Aspect claims daily-refreshing predictive forecasting⁵³. Assembled claims “90% accuracy”⁵⁰. The new edge has moved to intraday systems that “predict deviations before they occur and *recommend or execute* real-time adjustments” (DMG, 2026)⁴⁰, with Cisne making autonomous “Swan Droids” the default⁵⁵. **My read.** Once “AI forecasting” is table-stakes, the contest moves up to *autonomous intraday action*: reforecast-and-reschedule in real time without a human in the loop. The incumbents with the deepest forecasting (NICE, Verint) hold the accuracy story; the agentic entrants (Cisne, Peopleware’s Agentic layer) push the *autonomy* story. Whoever pairs accuracy with trustworthy autonomous action wins the planner’s confidence. **Conditional prediction.** If by Q4 2026 at least two Gravity-tier WFM vendors publicly ship intraday that *executes* (not just recommends) schedule changes autonomously with audit/override controls, the frontier has moved to autonomy; if the headline stays on forecasting-accuracy percentages, it has not. **Sources.** Vendor WFM pages, accessed 2026-06-16: nice.com, verint.com, calabrio.com, genesys.com, aspect.com, assembled.com.

Claim 1 – The autonomous-intraday frontier

AI forecasting is now table-stakes. The edge moves up to intraday that acts on its own.



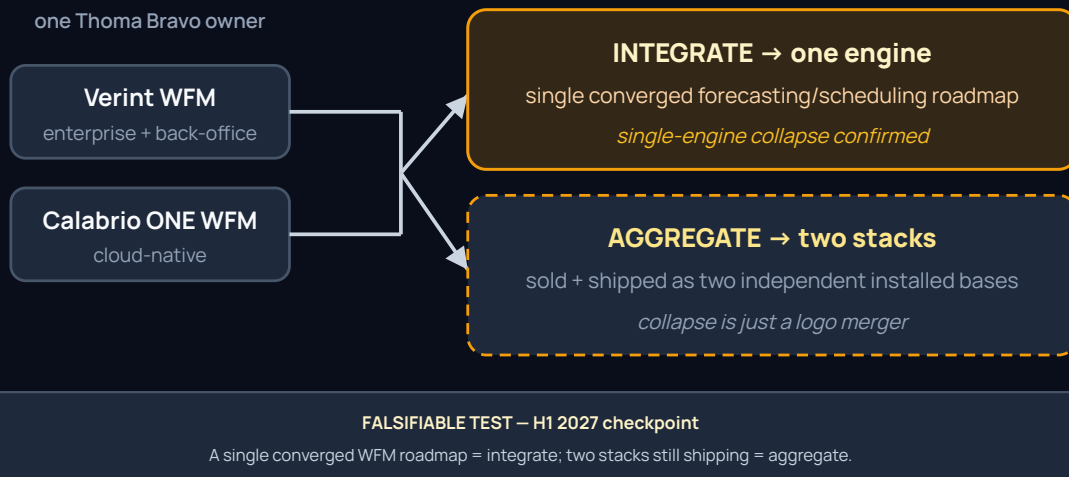
Claim 1 – The autonomous-intraday frontier: once AI forecasting is table-stakes, the edge moves to intraday that recommends, then executes.

Pattern Claim 2 – The Two-WFM-Stack Integration Test

Observation. Thoma Bravo's take-private of Verint (closed 26 Nov 2025)⁴⁷ merged it with Calabrio, and **both shipped top-tier, separately-marketed contact-center WFM** (Verint Enterprise/Back-Office WFM; Calabrio ONE WFM), now under one owner. **My read.** This is the cleanest single-owner WFM overlap in the report. A PE roll-up run for cash generation has to either rationalize two full WFM stacks into one (integrate) or run them as two installed bases (aggregate). Which it does is the most legible test of whether the single-engine-collapse thesis is real or just a logo merger. **Conditional prediction.** If by H1 2027 the combined entity has publicly announced a single converged WFM roadmap (one forecasting/scheduling engine), the integrate-thesis holds; if Verint-WFM and Calabrio-WFM are still sold and shipped as two independent stacks, it is aggregation, not collapse, and the single-engine thesis weakens at the market level. **Sources.** Verint and Calabrio WFM pages plus the Thoma Bravo take-private close, accessed 2026-06-16: verint.com, calabrio.com.

Claim 2 – The two-WFM-stack integration test

Two top-tier WFM stacks, one owner. Does Thoma Bravo integrate or just aggregate?



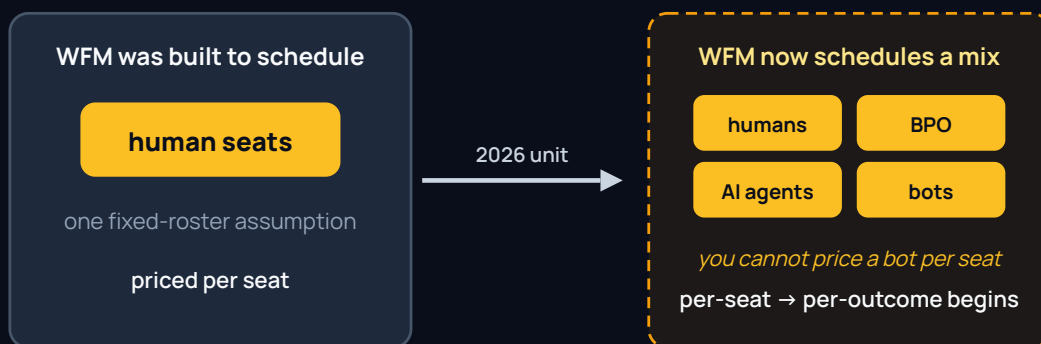
Claim 2 – The two-WFM-stack integration test: does Thoma Bravo integrate Verint + Calabrio into one engine, or aggregate two installed bases?

Pattern Claim 3 – The Blended-Workforce Planning Unit

Observation. As autonomous agents absorb tier-1 volume, the thing WFM schedules is changing. Assembled makes “unify in-house agents, BPO vendors, and AI” its explicit wedge⁵⁰, and the agentic framing (Cisne, Peopleware, Aspect) all points at planning a human + bot mix. DMG re-describes 2026 WFM as coordinating “human agents, AI agents, bots, and automated workflows.”⁴⁰ **My read.** When the unit being scheduled stops being a human seat, WFM becomes the market where the per-seat → per-outcome pricing migration physically begins: you cannot price a bot per seat. WFM is therefore an early, observable Convergence indicator, not just a planning tool. **Conditional prediction.** If by mid-2027 a Gravity-tier WFM vendor publicly prices or packages “AI-agent capacity” as a planned-and-scheduled resource alongside human seats, the blended-planning-unit shift is real; if planning stays human-seat-denominated, it remains a marketing frame. **Sources.** The blended-workforce framing set out earlier in this chapter: assembled.com, accessed 2026-06-16.

Claim 3 – The blended-workforce planning unit

When the unit being scheduled stops being a human seat, per-seat pricing breaks.



FALSIFIABLE TEST – mid-2027 checkpoint

A Gravity vendor prices “AI-agent capacity” as a scheduled resource = the shift is real.
Dashed panel = forecast.

Claim 3 – The blended-workforce planning unit: when the scheduled unit stops being a human seat, per-seat pricing breaks.

Winners

NICE. In my read, NICE holds the depth line on forecasting: a 45-plus-algorithm engine with a daily Best-Pick model selection (nice.com)⁴⁴. It also carries the longest-standing installed base, reflected in DMG’s contact-center WFM seat-share ranking.⁴¹ **DMG’s figure** is data through 2020 — stale, and a share, not a size. NICE is the accuracy story to beat.

Thoma Bravo CX. I see the combined Verint + Calabrio entity winning on two-stack scale, if it integrates. It brings two top-tier WFM stacks under one owner (Funding & Fault-Lines), the largest single-owner WFM footprint in the report. Whether that becomes an advantage or just two installed bases is the open test of Pattern Claim 2. A signal from after the research cut: at Engage 2026 the two presented unified under the Verint brand with a shared orchestration layer, Agent Factory. That is brand-level unification, with the CEO's own "repositioning" framing as the counterweight. The converged-WFM-roadmap test of Pattern Claim 2 remains open.

Genesys. I see the native-suite winner for the buyer standardizing on one cloud platform: WFM "built into the overall platform rather than as a bolt-on" (genesys.com)⁴⁹. That native position is what earns the Gravity tier.

Watch

Assembled. I'd watch the independent that the suites embed in their go-to-market but do not own. It is the clearest test of whether independent WFM survives inside the suites' channel; its Attention-tier card and its Five9/Genesys partnerships are the evidence to watch.

Cisne and Peopleware. I see the autonomy story pushed hardest here: Cisne's autonomous Swan Droids (Wildcard, controlled-availability positioning) and Peopleware's named Agentic layer. Whether autonomy pairs with trustworthy override controls is Pattern Claim 1's test.

Aspect. I'd watch the heritage-scale repositioning: Alvaria's Enterprise Workforce Suite reborn as WorkforceOS with daily-refreshing predictive forecasting (aspect.com)⁵³.

Losers

I am not naming a loser in this market, and I will not manufacture one. Funding & Fault-Lines found no named, dated, public distress event for any contender. What the record shows instead is consolidation, not failure: Verint taken private and merged with Calabrio (26 Nov 2025), and the modern-WFM independents absorbed into suites before they scaled (Tymeshift into Zendesk, 2023; Surfboard into Dialpad, 2024). Those are ownership changes and acquisitions of working products, not exits under duress, and the vendors whose fate is genuinely contested sit under Watch, not here.

2.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **The Verint + Calabrio two-stack test** through H1 2027: a converged WFM roadmap or two installed bases (Pattern Claim 2's checkpoint). It is the heaviest single-owner WFM overlap in the report.
2. **Intraday crossing from "recommend" to "execute":** autonomous reschedule-in-real-time moves from the Wildcard tier (Cisne) into Gravity product lines.
3. **Blended human + AI-agent planning** becomes a priced, packaged WFM capability (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint). It is the early edge of the per-seat → per-outcome migration.
4. **Fair-workweek / predictive-scheduling compliance** collides with demand-cost-optimizing AI schedulers. The labor-rules constraint layer becomes a buyer gate.

5. **The next modern-WFM absorption:** after Timeshift and Surfboard, whether an Assembled-class independent stays independent or is bought/partnered into a suite.

Chapter 3 – The Performance & Engagement Market

3.1 What This Market Is

What this market is. Performance & Engagement is the software that turns scored interactions and performance data into **better, more engaged, longer-tenured agents**. It bundles three linked jobs, increasingly AI-driven. **Performance management** covers scorecards, KPIs, targets, and the supervisor's view of the floor. **Gamification & engagement** is challenges, recognition, and motivation: behaviour-change design, not just points and badges. **Coaching** turns an identified gap into targeted, measured improvement. Riding on top is the **wellbeing / attrition** dimension. It is increasingly the market's actual business case: contact-center agent turnover runs ~40–45%, and replacing one agent is widely cited around ~\$35K.

The buyer is the supervisor / team-lead. This is the person who runs coaching, lives in the tool all day, and owns whether the floor's output and the agent's tenure improve. The planner buys Workforce Management; the QA auditor buys Quality & Interaction Analytics.

Where the boundaries fall.

- **vs Quality & Analytics:** Quality & Interaction Analytics *produces the score*; this market *acts on it*. The **QA → coaching loop** is where the two overlap. Many vendors sell across it, and we classify them by their separately-positioned product line.
- **vs WFM:** WFM puts the agent *on shift*; this market *develops and retains* them. **Adherence and burnout are the overlap:** schedule flexibility is increasingly sold as a retention lever. That is why Central, though adjacent on scheduling, is graded *here* as its primary market.
- **vs broad HR / HCM employee engagement (Workday, Culture Amp):** that is enterprise-wide employee engagement owned by HR; this market is **contact-center-agent-specific** performance, coaching, and engagement, bought by CX ops.

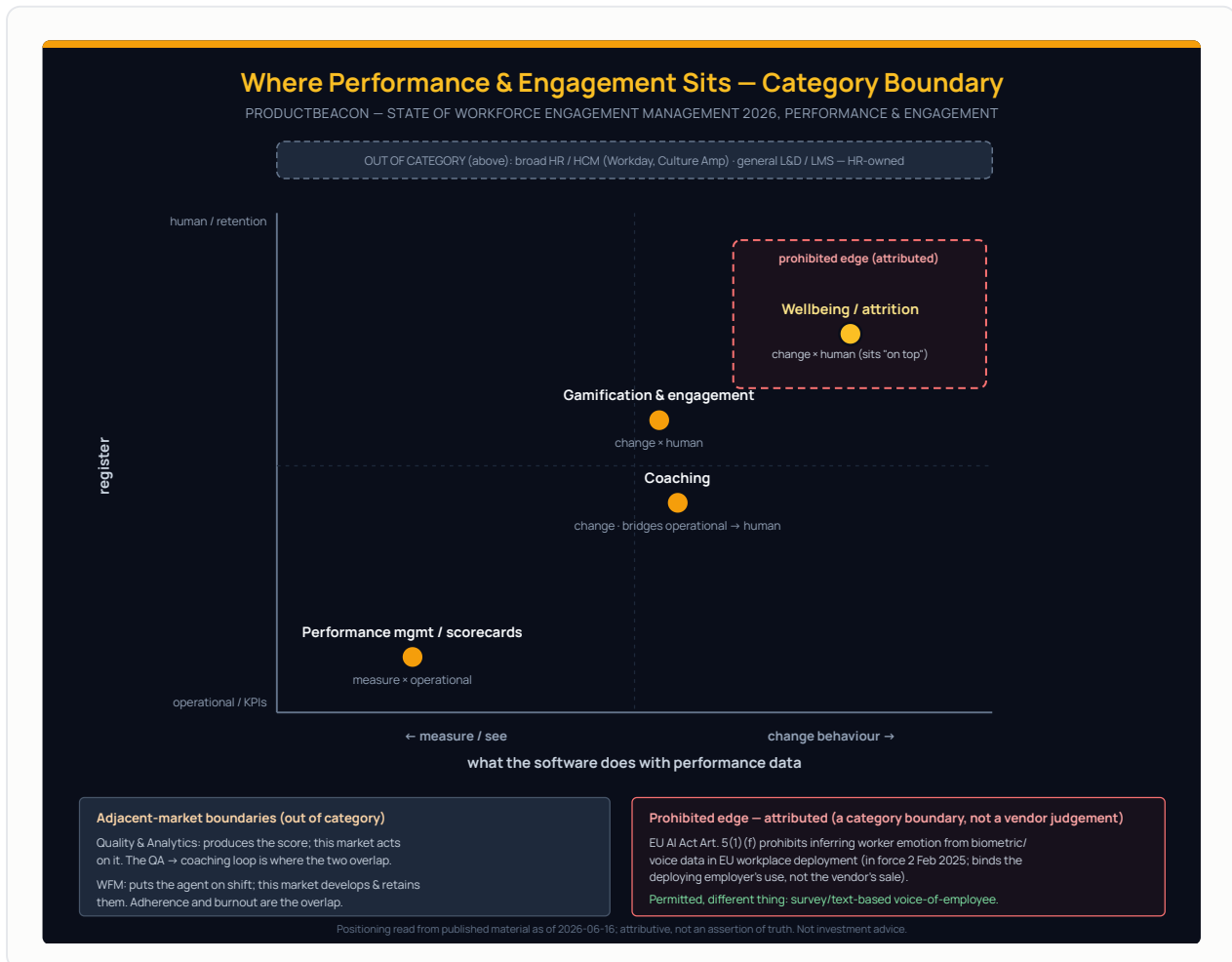
What it IS NOT. This market is not QA scoring; that is Quality & Interaction Analytics. It is not scheduling and adherence mechanics; that is Workforce Management. It is not broad HR/HCM or general learning & development (L&D/LMS) tooling. And it is not a clean single software category at all; Market Size & Trends explains why.

Three common buyer misconceptions.

1. *"Gamification is points and badges."* Superficial gamification fails; what works is behaviour-change design tied to real performance metrics and coaching. The mechanic is the surface, not the product.
2. *"AI can detect an agent's wellbeing or emotion."* This is the market's hard legal and scientific wall. Affect/emotion recognition is **scientifically contested**, and the **EU AI Act (Article 5(1)(f), in force Feb 2025)** prohibits inferring worker emotions from biometric/voice data in the workplace

(narrow medical/safety-purpose exceptions aside). Survey/text-based voice-of-employee is a different, permitted thing — do not conflate the two.

3. “Engagement is a soft, nice-to-have.” It is the **attrition business case**: turnover is a hard, quantified cost, and the market’s strongest pitch is reducing it, not “happier agents” in the abstract.



Where Performance & Engagement sits: what the software does with performance data (measure ↔ change behaviour) by register (operational ↔ human / retention), with the adjacent-market boundaries and the attributed emotion-AI prohibited edge. Positioning read from published material as of 2026-06-16; not investment advice.

3.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. This market has **no clean public dollar market size**. That absence is the point. Contact-center agent performance & engagement spend splits across three different, non-overlapping public markets that differ by up to ~57×: **call-center gamification** (~\$512M/2025)⁶⁴, **HR-wide employee-**

engagement software (~\$1.4B/2026)⁶⁵, and **broad cross-industry gamification** (~\$29B/2025)⁶⁶. Each measures something different and answers to a different buyer. We do not carve a market-size number out of any of them. Instead we size the market the way the buyer actually buys it: against an **attrition bill**.

The attrition business case (the market's real denominator). Contact-center agent turnover runs ~40–45%, average tenure ~14–15 months⁶⁷, and replacing one agent is cited around ~\$35K (Frost & Sullivan via Intradiem)⁶⁸. The supervisor doesn't buy against a market-size number; they buy against that bill. This is why the strongest vendor claims in this market are retention outcomes rather than engagement-for-its-own-sake: Calabrio's "33% more likely to stay," Verint TimeFlex's "up to 30% decreased attrition," and Zenarate's "25% Lower Attrition". *Sizing confidence: medium-low. The grade reflects market reality, not effort: there is no clean dollar category here.*

Trends that move the buyer. (1) **The supervisor's job is being rebuilt around next-best-action:** the tool tells them what to do about an agent today rather than showing a dashboard. (2) **AI-driven coaching + simulation-training** ("rehearse before the floor") opens a sub-category the quality-management (QM) and gamification incumbents address least. (3) **Wellbeing/attrition becomes a named pillar**, but mostly *acquired or partnered*, not built. (4) **Performance management extends from scoring the human agent to scoring the AI agent.**

Compliance: the sharpest legal boundary in the report. The **EU AI Act Article 5(1)(f)** (in force 2 Feb 2025) **prohibits inferring worker emotions from biometric/voice data in the workplace**⁷⁰ (save for narrow medical/safety purposes; penalties up to €35M / 7% of turnover)⁶⁹. The Act's own recital cites "serious concerns about the scientific basis" of emotion recognition⁷⁰. The obligation binds the **EU deploying employer's use**, not the vendor's act of selling. But it directly threatens the EU-deployed "real-time wellbeing/emotion AI" capability vendors are now selling, since voice-tone emotion inference of agents is squarely in scope. AI performance management is separately **high-risk** (Annex III, full obligations Aug 2026)⁶⁹. Survey/text-based voice-of-employee is a *different, permitted* thing and must not be conflated with acoustic emotion inference. The **Colorado AI Act (SB 24/26-205/189) effective date is a moving target**: it moved from 1 Feb 2026 to 30 Jun 2026, then was repealed and re-enacted to 1 Jan 2027.⁷¹ That date is re-verified at publication. *Sources cited inline above were accessed 2026-06-16.*

3.3 The Contenders

Eight contenders are graded on the 3-bucket rubric (cap 8). The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. Each card carries a verbatim vendor pillar with its dated URL inline; capability/attrition/outcome figures are quoted as *vendor claims*. AI-positioning reads are publicly-evidenced, never internal-architecture verdicts. **The emotion-AI wall set out in Market Size & Trends is the live constraint on every wellbeing claim here.**

Gravity tier

1. **NICE – CXone Mpower Performance Management + Workforce Empowerment (Enlighten)**. The native module “aggregates data from NiCE and third-party systems... into one centralized view” where “managers, supervisors, and agents gain actionable insights supported by personalized coaching and gamification” (nice.com)⁷². The 2026 **Workforce Empowerment / Enlighten Actions** pillar reframes it for the AI era: “manage performance across human and AI agents operating on the same queues,” with “personalized coaching assignments generated from interaction and performance data” (nice.com)⁷³. *AI positioning*: GenAI “Copilot for Supervisors” plus AI coaching on the legacy suite; wellbeing surfaces as supervisor-alerting, not biometric inference. **Playvox** (acquired 1 Oct 2024) is a capability *inside* this card. It is a Convergence P1 proxy.

2. **Thoma Bravo CX – Verint + Calabrio engagement (Cogito inside)**. Calabrio's engagement line leads with “Retain Great Agents and Unleash Their Full Potential” / “Your contact center only thrives when its agents do.” It adds gamification, leaderboards, an agent-centric coaching portal, and a vendor-claimed “agents who receive regular performance insights are 33% more likely to stay” (calabrio.com)⁷⁴. Verint adds the **TimeFlex Bot** (vendor-claimed “up to 30% decreased attrition”).

Cogito, the real-time emotion/EX-coaching vendor, is now *inside* this entity: Verint acquired it on 11 Oct 2024 for \$38.2M plus up to \$23.2M contingent.⁷⁶ The product delivers “a real-time score for both customer experience (CX) and employee experience (EX).”⁷⁵ *Note (the emotion-AI wall)*: Cogito's acoustic emotion/burnout-inference line is the capability EU AI Act Art. 5(1)(f) is widely read to reach in EU workplace deployment – and the prohibition binds the deploying employer's use, not the vendor's sale. It is the flagship private-equity (PE) roll-up datapoint in this market.

3. **Genesys: Cloud Workforce Engagement**. The native gamification/performance/development line is “built into the overall platform rather than as a bolt-on” (genesys.com)⁷⁷. Genesys is the lighter-surfaced of the three Gravity suites in this market, but it clears the bar on dated native positioning. It is a Convergence P1 proxy.

Attention tier

4. **Central: Employee Performance eXperience Platform** is the engagement pure-play and the primary card here; its Workforce Management overlap resolves to this chapter. Its pillar is “Go beyond monitoring. Start improving your company's performance at scale,” unifying advanced gamification, “performance-driven learning that sticks” through microlearning, real-time tracking, and AI analytics (central.com)⁷⁸. Central was named a 2025 SPARK Matrix Workforce-Engagement Leader⁷⁸. *AI positioning*: “AI Performance Experience Platform” – GenAI microlearning plus an AI digital coach on a 2013 gamification heritage. Its **voice-of-employee is survey/text-based (outside the biometric emotion-recognition prohibition)**, explicitly not Cogito-style acoustic inference. Funding: see Funding & Fault-Lines (verified figures).

5. **AmplifAI: AI Platform for Performance & CX Management**. AmplifAI is the data-unification independent: it promises to “unify contact center data, drive agent performance... all in one place,” unifying “CCaaS, CRM, WFM, voice, chat, and surveys into a single AI-ready layer.” It then uses “generative AI to deliver role-based next best actions across coaching, quality, recognition, and

performance management,” with a **Coaching Effectiveness Index** to “measure whether coaching drove measurable improvement” (amplifai.com)⁷⁹. Its wedge against the suites is “replicate your best agents”. It is a Convergence falsification-condition vendor.

6. Spinify: gamification-first. Its pillar, “**See Who’s Winning. Fix Who’s Not,**” turns CRM data into real-time leaderboards, competitions, recognition, and AI coaching (spinify.com)⁸⁰. *Pricing:* Spinify is among the most transparent here, with published single-plan pricing (spinify.com/pricing, accessed 2026-07-20): Business **\$25/user/month billed annually** with a 5-user minimum; Real Estate editions \$18/\$8; Enterprise flat-rate custom.

Correction at this refresh: the previously-carried “~\$9/user/mo, tiers ~\$40-65” reflected a page state no longer live. Archive snapshots show the single-plan structure in place by 17 Apr 2026, before the original access date, so the prior figures are corrected as a baseline error, not recorded as a repricing between 16 June and 20 July 2026. Spinify is sales-primary and contact-center-secondary.

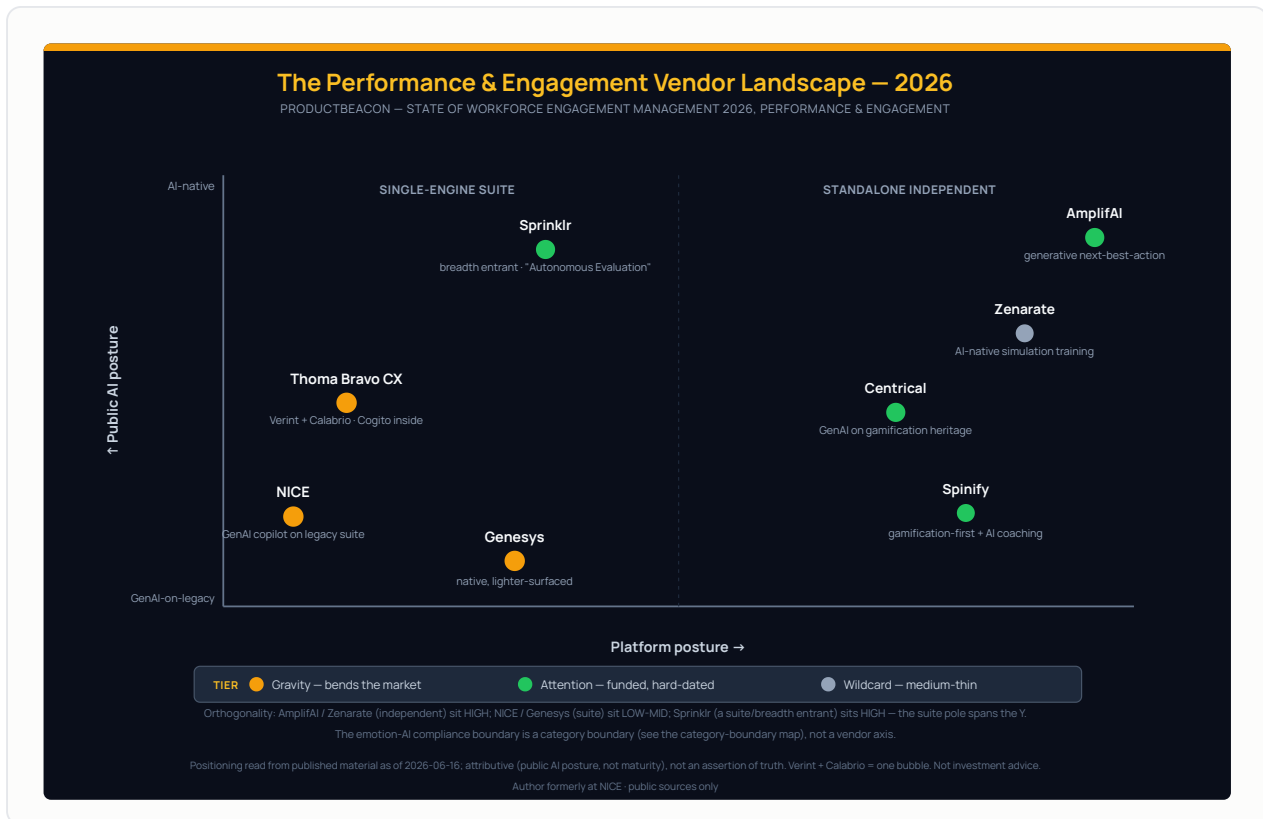
7. Sprinklr: Unified-CXM Service (secondary engagement surface). Sprinklr is public (NYSE: CXM), with engagement secondary to its CXM core. But its dated **Spring '26** release adds “**Autonomous Evaluation... so teams can understand, trust, and continuously refine agent behavior**” (investors.sprinklr.com)⁸¹. That extends performance/evaluation from human agents toward AI agents. The 20 July 2026 re-check added three events. Sprinklr acquired the assets of **ViralMoment**, an AI social-video-intelligence solution, on 28 May 2026, terms undisclosed (sprinklr.com); the event predates the 16 June 2026 research cut-off and was folded in at this refresh. It shipped a Summer '26 release of 16 AI features, reported by CMSWire around 17 Jul 2026. And it appointed **Thomas Addis** Chief Revenue Officer effective 1 Jul 2026 (BusinessWire).

Sprinklr enters on breadth, not depth.

Wildcard tier

8. Zenarate: AI Coach / Simulation Training. Zenarate is the AI-coaching/simulation wedge. Its pillar is “**AI Conversation & Software Simulation Training + LXP**”, where agents “**practice real conversations before they ever talk to customers**”. It is the “flight simulator” for agents. The vendor-claimed outcomes are “40% Faster Speed to Proficiency” and “25% Lower Attrition” (zenarate.com)⁸². *Material tier:* medium-thin, but a dated primary-source funding event exists (\$15M led by Volition Capital, TechCrunch 27 Jun 2023; ~\$18M total)⁸³, so the **viability bright-line anchor is satisfied: strategy opinion permitted, viability verdict withheld**.

Duplicate listings resolved: Cogito is graded inside Thoma Bravo CX (acquired). Cresta and Observe.AI are Agent-Assist Plays: their coaching line is the Quality QM-scoring line, not a separate Performance SKU. Balto is Agent-Assist primary, a Play here.



The Performance & Engagement vendor landscape: platform posture (single-engine suite ↔ standalone independent) by public AI posture (GenAI-on-legacy ↔ AI-native). Verint + Calabrio are one bubble; the emotion-AI compliance boundary is kept to the category map, not a vendor axis. Attributed read of published material, accessed 2026-06-16.

3.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: Engagement becomes the empowerment module of one AI platform

NICE's Enlighten Actions pillar reads "manage performance across human and AI agents"⁷³; Calabrio's portal ships inside Calabrio ONE⁷⁴; Genesys builds engagement native to the platform⁷⁷. The independents (Central, AmplifAI, Spinify) are pushed to defend on depth, data-unification, and outcome-measurement. *This feeds Convergence P1.*

Play 2: The supervisor's job is rebuilt around next-best-action, not dashboards

AmplifAI sells "role-based next best actions" and promises to "replicate high-performer actions with AI"⁷⁹. NICE generates "personalized coaching assignments"⁷³. "Dashboard" commoditizes; differentiation migrates to *measured coaching outcomes* and *data unification*.

Play 3: Wellbeing/attrition becomes a named pillar, acquired or partnered, not built

Verint acquired Cogito⁷⁶; Cisco Webex ships burnout detection⁸⁴; Intradiem partners with Thrive Global.

With Cogito absorbed, the standalone wellbeing-AI bench thins, and the EU AI Act emotion-recognition prohibition reshapes what the survivors can claim.

Play 4: AI-coaching/simulation opens a sub-category the suites haven't closed

Zenarate's "flight simulator"⁸² anchors the sub-category, and the suites bolt on copilots faster than they build simulators. That makes simulation the most likely Agent-Assist acquisition target, mirroring Workforce Management's thin-middle pattern.

Play 5: Performance/evaluation extends from scoring the human agent to scoring the AI agent

NICE manages "human and AI agents on the same queues"⁷³; Sprinklr ships "Autonomous Evaluation"⁸¹; AmplifAI covers "human + AI agents"⁷⁹. This pulls Performance & Engagement toward Autonomous CX. The shift from paying per agent seat to paying per resolution (the per-seat→per-outcome migration) starts where the agent being managed stops being human.

Vendor pages are cited inline in The Contenders, accessed 2026-06-16.

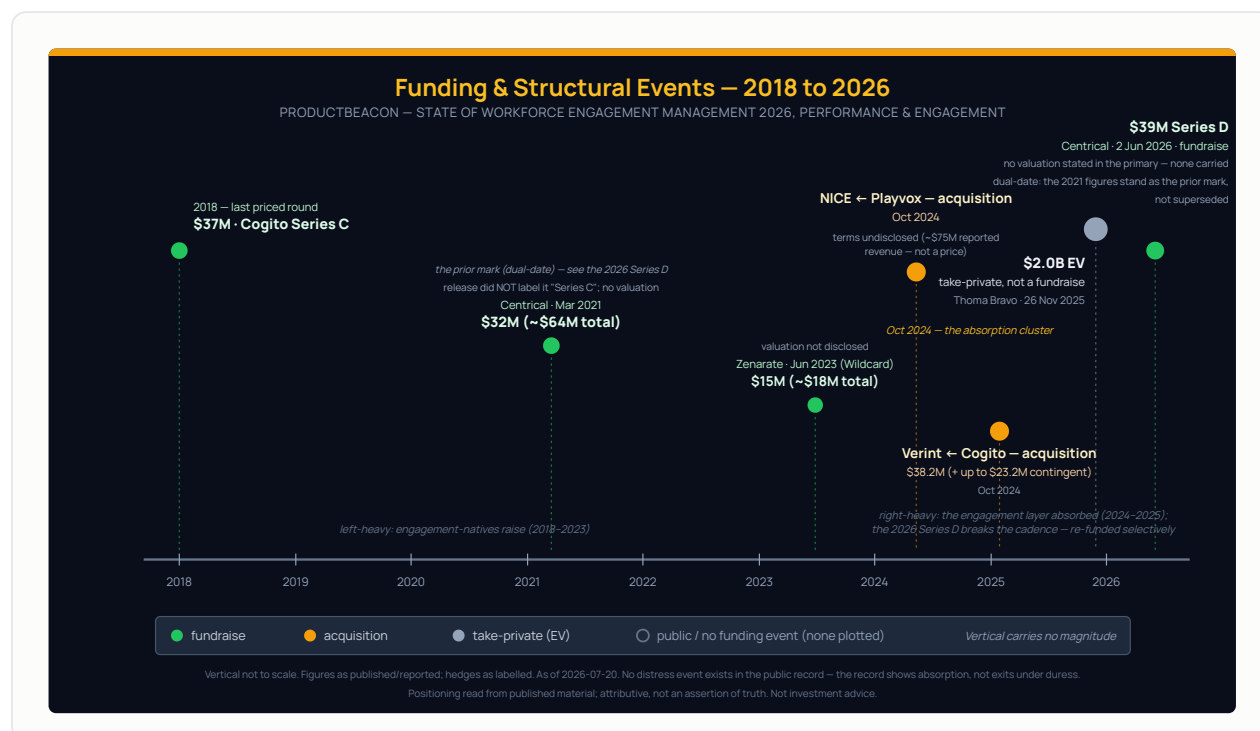
3.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor / acquirer
NICE	Public; engagement asset = Playvox (closed into NICE 1 Oct 2024, terms undisclosed, ~\$75M reported revenue) ⁸⁵	Public equity	Acquirer
Thoma Bravo CX (Verint+Calabrio)	Take-private closed 26 Nov 2025 ⁸⁶ ; Cogito acquired by Verint 11 Oct 2024 (\$38.2M + up to \$23.2M contingent) ⁷⁶	\$2.0B EV (Verint) ⁸⁷	Thoma Bravo
Central	\$39M Series D, 2 Jun 2026 (Leeds Illuminate + Kingfisher Investment, participation JVP); prior mark \$32M, 10 Mar 2021 ⁸⁸ (Intel Capital + JVP; that release did NOT label it “Series C”); ~\$103M total (arithmetic on verified rounds)	Not disclosed (no valuation stated in either primary)	Leeds Illuminate, Kingfisher, JVP (+ Intel Capital, 2021)
AmplifAI	Private; funding not deeply public this pass	Not disclosed	—
Spinify	Thin / bootstrapped, no verifiable primary round	—	—
Zenarate (Wildcard)	\$15M, 27 Jun 2023 (~\$18M total) ⁸³	Not disclosed	Volition Capital
Sprinklr	Public (NYSE: CXM); acquired assets of ViralMoment (28 May 2026, undisclosed)	Public equity	—

Two consolidation engines, plus a funding-cadence tell, partially revised at this refresh. The structure is the same NICE-organic vs Thoma-Bravo-PE-roll-up split. Performance & Engagement's distinctive signal *had been* that the **independent performance-natives were mostly running on pre-2022 capital**: Central raised in 2021⁸⁸, Cogito's last priced round was 2018, before its acquisition⁹⁰, and Zenarate raised in 2023⁸³. Meanwhile the engagement layer gets *absorbed* into suites: Verint took Cogito, and NICE took Playvox. The 20 July 2026 re-check partially broke the first half of that read: **Central closed a \$39M Series D on 2 June 2026** (see the Fault-lines correction below). That is new primary capital into the performance-native middle. The absorption half of the read stands; the “isn't being re-funded” half is retired, contradicted by a primary event. What remains is the thinner claim: the middle is being re-funded *selectively*, while the engagement layer continues to be absorbed.

Fault-lines (disclosed, not guessed). Central's funding — our own initial working figure of “\$45M Series C” was an internal-brief error, not a Central claim. The primary release says **\$32M, co-led by Intel Capital and JVP, no valuation, ~\$64M total, and is not labeled “Series C”** — corrected here (LL-2 / verify-primary discipline). **Update (as of 2026-07-20)**: Central announced a **\$39M Series D on 2 June 2026** (company release + GlobeNewswire; led by Leeds Illuminate and Kingfisher Investment, with

participation from JVP, the company's largest shareholder; no valuation stated in the primary – none carried). The 2021 figures above stand as the prior mark, not superseded (dual-date / verify-primary discipline). **Cogito's "\$45M" floating in aggregators is a cumulative, not a single round**: its priced Series C was \$37M (Goldman, 2018)⁹⁰; the Oct-2023 round closed undisclosed; the acquisition was \$38.2M (11 Oct 2024)⁷⁶. Spinify is thin/bootstrapped⁸⁹ and carries **no viability claim. No discrete agent-wellbeing/attrition M&A or funding event exists in the public record**: wellbeing is a feature-theme inside coaching suites, not a separately-funded segment, and nothing is asserted there. *Funding sources are cited inline above, accessed 2026-06-16.*



Funding & structural events, 2018–2026: the engagement-natives raise early, the engagement layer is absorbed late. Figures as published/reported with hedges as labelled; vertical not to scale; no distress event exists in the public record. As of 2026-07-20.

3.6 Winning & Losing

The three pattern-claim callouts below are my read of where this market is heading. Each is anchored to public evidence already cited in this chapter, framed explicitly as opinion, and put as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint an outsider can watch.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Emotion-AI Wall

Observation. Vendors increasingly market “real-time agent wellbeing/emotion” detection (Cogito’s CX/EX scoring and burnout-inference; suite wellbeing pillars)⁷⁵. Yet the **EU AI Act Article 5(1)(f) (in force 2 Feb 2025) prohibits inferring worker emotions from biometric/voice data**⁷⁰ (up to €35M/7%)⁶⁹, and the Act’s recital cites “serious concerns about the scientific basis.”⁷⁰ Meanwhile, the leading emotion-AI pure-play (Cogito) has been absorbed into Verint/Thoma Bravo CX (11 Oct 2024)⁷⁶. **My read.** The acoustic-emotion-inference pitch is on a collision course with EU law and contested science at the same moment its category leader stops being independent. The durable survivor is **survey/text-based voice-of-employee and outcome-based attrition reduction** (permitted, evidence-backed), not real-time emotion scoring of agents – and vendors that lump the two will have to separate them. **Conditional prediction.** If by mid-2027 the major suites have publicly re-scoped their agent “wellbeing/emotion” features toward consent-based, non-biometric, or supervisor-alerting framing (and away from automated emotion inference), the wall is binding. If acoustic emotion-scoring of agents is still marketed as a headline EU-available capability, enforcement is lagging the marketing. **Sources.** The emotion-AI wall set out in Market Size & Trends, plus vendor wellbeing pages accessed 2026-06-16: verint.com, calabrio.com, central.com.

Claim 1 – The emotion-AI wall

The acoustic-emotion pitch meets EU law and contested science head-on.

what is marketed

real-time emotion AI

voice-tone burnout score

Cogito-style acoustic inference
(now absorbed into Verint)

THE WALL

what the wall is

EU AI Act Art. 5(1)(f)

prohibits inferring worker
emotion from voice/biometric
(in force 2 Feb 2025)

+ contested science

recital: "serious concerns
about the scientific basis"

Durable survivor: survey/text voice-of-employee + outcome-based attrition (permitted), not acoustic emotion scoring.

FALSIFIABLE TEST – checkpoint mid-2027

WALL IS BINDING if by mid-2027 the major suites publicly re-scope agent "wellbeing/emotion" features toward consent-based, non-biometric, or supervisor-alerting framing.

ENFORCEMENT LAGS if acoustic emotion-scoring of agents is still marketed as a headline EU-available capability.

Attributed read of published material; not an assertion of truth. The prohibition binds the deploying employer's use, not the vendor's sale.
Sources: verint.com, calabrio.com, central.com; EU AI Act Art. 5(1)(f). Accessed 2026-06-16.

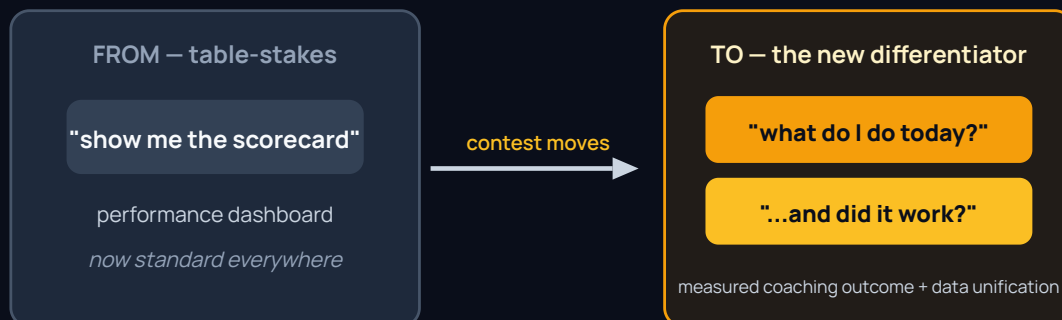
The emotion-AI wall: the acoustic-emotion pitch meets the EU AI Act Article 5(1)(f) prohibition and contested science. Attributed read of published material; the prohibition binds the deploying employer's use, not the vendor's sale, and this is a category boundary, not a vendor judgement.

Pattern Claim 2 – The Coaching-Outcome Contest

Observation. Performance dashboards are now table-stakes across suites and independents. The differentiation is moving to *whether the coaching changed behavior* and to *data unification*. AmplifAI markets a “Coaching Effectiveness Index”⁷⁹ and unifies “CCaaS, CRM, WFM, voice, chat, and surveys”⁷⁹. NICE markets “coaching assignments generated from... performance data”⁷³. **My read.** The supervisor’s question is shifting from “show me the scorecard” to “what do I do about this agent today, and did it work.” The suites win on owning the QA→coaching loop end-to-end: the Quality & Interaction Analytics score becomes Performance & Engagement action on one platform. The independents win on *measured* coaching outcomes and on seeing data the single-suite buyer’s stack can’t. **Conditional prediction.** If by H1 2027 at least two Gravity suites publicly ship a *measured-coaching-outcome* metric as a headline capability, the suites have captured the loop, closing it from score to coaching to demonstrated improvement. If measured-outcome remains the independents’ wedge (AmplifAI-class), the depth defense holds. **Sources.** Vendor performance/coaching pages, accessed 2026-06-16: amplifai.com, nice.com, calabrio.com.

Claim 2 – The coaching-outcome contest

Dashboards commoditize. The contest moves to whether the coaching changed behavior.



Suites win owning the QA→coaching loop end-to-end; independents win on measured outcome (AmplifAI's index).

FALSIFIABLE TEST – checkpoint H1 2027

SUITES CAPTURE THE LOOP if by H1 2027 at least two Gravity suites publicly ship a measured-coaching-outcome metric as a headline capability (score → coaching → demonstrated improvement).

DEPTH DEFENSE HOLDS if measured-outcome remains the independents' wedge (AmplifAI-class).

Attributed read of published material; not an assertion of truth. Figures quoted are vendor claims, not verified outcomes.

Sources: amplifai.com, nice.com, calabrio.com. Accessed 2026-06-16.

The coaching-outcome contest: the supervisor's question shifts from "show me the scorecard" to "what do I do today, and did it work." Figures shown are vendor claims, attributed to dated pages.

Pattern Claim 3 – Simulation as the Independent Wedge

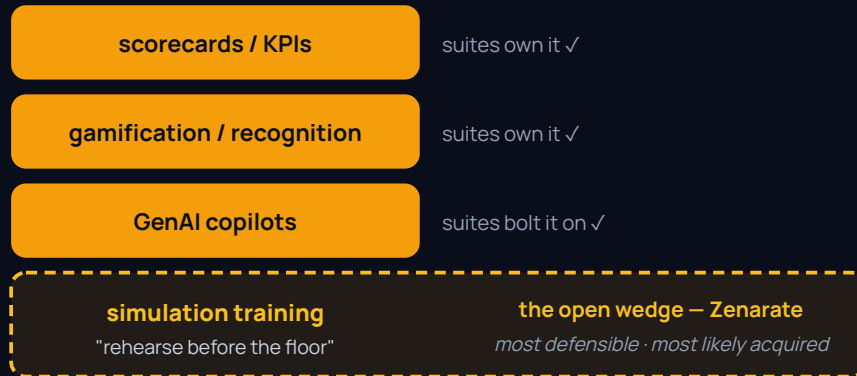
Observation. "Rehearse before the floor" AI-simulation training is the one engagement/coaching slice the QM/gamification incumbents address least directly. Zenarate's "flight simulator," with its vendor-claimed "40% Faster Speed to Proficiency", anchors the slice⁸². And the modern coaching-middle is thin and acquirable, mirroring Workforce Management's Tymeshift/Surfboard pattern.

My read. Simulation-training is the most defensible independent wedge in this market through 2026 because the suites bolt on copilots faster than they build simulators. That also makes it the most likely Agent-Assist acquisition target. The attrition business case set out in Market Size & Trends is what funds it. **Conditional prediction.** If by mid-2027 a Gravity suite has acquired or shipped a native agent-simulation-training capability, the wedge is closing, and the thin-middle-gets-absorbed pattern repeats in a third market. If simulation stays an independent specialty, the suites are still bolting copilots, not building simulators. **Sources.** The simulation-training wedge and funding set out in What the Vendors Are Doing and Funding & Fault-Lines: zenarate.com, accessed 2026-06-16.

Claim 3 – Simulation as the independent wedge

The suites bolt on copilots faster than they build simulators. One slice stays open.

The coaching surface



FALSIFIABLE TEST – checkpoint mid-2027

WEDGE CLOSING if by mid-2027 a Gravity suite has acquired or shipped a native agent-simulation-training capability (the thin-middle-gets-absorbed pattern repeats a third market).

WEDGE STAYS OPEN if simulation stays an independent specialty (the suites still bolting copilots, not building simulators).

Attributed read of published material; not an assertion of truth. "40% Faster Speed to Proficiency" is a vendor claim.
Sources: zenarate.com. Accessed 2026-06-16.

Simulation as the independent wedge: the one coaching slice the suites address least, and by this read the most likely Agent-Assist acquisition target. Vendor-claimed outcomes are attributed, not verified.

Winners

NICE and Thoma Bravo CX. In my read, the two Gravity suites win by owning the QA→coaching loop end-to-end: the Quality & Interaction Analytics score flows into Performance & Engagement action on one platform. NICE's Enlighten Actions reach across human and AI agents⁷³, and Calabrio's agent-retention framing anchors the Thoma Bravo entity here. Both are Gravity-tier cards in The Contenders.

AmplifAI and Central. I see the strongest independents holding the depth line: AmplifAI on data-unification and measured coaching outcomes, Central as the engagement pure-play (both Attention-tier cards). They win the buyer who wants coaching that is demonstrably working and data the single-suite stack cannot see.

Watch

Zenarate. I'd watch the simulation-training wedge: the "rehearse before the floor" slice the suites address least, and by my read the most defensible independent position in this market through 2026. That same fact makes it the most likely Agent-Assist acquisition target; its card and dated funding event in The Contenders are the evidence. The squeeze signal, my read as opinion: Cresta shipped a Training Simulator using AI-agent simulated customers on 9 Jul 2026, after the research cut-off (cresta.com/PRNewswire), and performance vendors are shipping AI role-play. The standalone simulation-training premise is being approached from two directions. But no Gravity *suite* has yet shipped or acquired native simulation, so Pattern Claim 3's conditional has not fired.

The agent-wellbeing claim itself. I'd watch what survives the emotion-AI wall. The EU AI Act's Article 5(1) (f) prohibition and contested science are reshaping every real-time "wellbeing/emotion" pitch, and the category's leading pure-play, Cogito, is now inside a suite⁷⁶. The durable version, by my read, is survey/text-based voice-of-employee and outcome-based attrition reduction, not acoustic emotion scoring of agents.

Sprinklr. I'd watch the breadth entrant extending evaluation from human agents toward AI agents ("Autonomous Evaluation," Spring '26)⁸¹. That is an Agent-Assist-into-Autonomous CX blur more than a core engagement play.

Losers

I am not naming a loser in this market, and I will not manufacture one. Funding & Fault-Lines found no named, dated, public distress event for any contender. What the record shows instead is absorption: the standalone wellbeing and emotion-AI bench thinning as Cogito was acquired into Verint (11 Oct 2024) and Playvox folded into NICE — capable assets bought into suites, not exits under duress. The genuinely contested question, what the emotion-AI wall leaves standing, sits under Watch, not here.

3.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **EU AI Act emotion-recognition enforcement** (Art. 5(1) (f)) and the **Colorado AI Act effective date** (re-verify, it has moved three times), the live legal reshaping of every agent-wellbeing/emotion claim.
2. **The next wellbeing/coaching acquisition** after Verint acquired Cogito: whether another emotion-AI or coaching independent is absorbed (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint).
3. **Measured coaching outcomes** becoming a headline suite capability (Pattern Claim 2's checkpoint): the QA → coaching loop captured end-to-end.
4. **AI-agent performance/evaluation** ("score the AI agent") maturing: Performance & Engagement blurring into Autonomous CX and the per-seat → per-outcome migration.
5. **Simulation-training** staying independent vs being acquired/built into a suite (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint).

Chapter 4 – The Agent-Assist & Real-Time Guidance Market

4.1 What This Market Is

What this market is. Agent-Assist & Real-Time Guidance is the software that changes the outcome of a conversation **while it is happening**. It covers real-time guidance and nudges, in-the-moment knowledge surfacing, next-best-action, live compliance prompts, and the after-call-work (auto-summary, disposition) that closes the interaction. It is the **live moment** of the WEM stack: where Quality & Interaction Analytics scores the interaction *after* and Performance & Engagement coaches the agent *later*, this market acts *during*. It also absorbs the buyer-visible, knowledge-in-the-flow half of **knowledge management (KM)**.

The buyer is the live moment. In practice the buyer is the supervisor or CX-ops leader who wants the agent to say the right thing, find the right answer, and finish the after-call work without a hold, on this call.

Where the boundaries fall – and this is the report’s sharpest one.

- **vs Quality & Analytics:** Quality & Interaction Analytics is *retrospective* (score the completed interaction); this market is *real-time* (act during it). Same transcript, different time.
- **vs Performance & Engagement:** Performance & Engagement develops the agent *between* calls (coaching, gamification); this market guides them *on* the call.
- **vs Autonomous CX, the control-surface boundary:** This is the line the whole report turns on. **Assist returns a suggestion to a person who acts; autonomous is the resolution itself: the AI takes the action, and the human is out of the loop.** The discriminator is *who performs the resolving action*, not how capable the AI is, and **a human-approval gate is what keeps a system in Agent-Assist**. Vendors draw this line *themselves*, with two separately-named SKUs on one engine: NICE Copilot vs Autopilot, Cresta Agent Assist vs AI Agent, Genesys Copilot vs autonomous agents, and Five9 assist vs agents that “Reason, Decide, and Take Action”. That is the single-engine thesis made physical: **one engine, two SKUs, gated by whether a human is in the loop** (see the Winning & Losing section below and the Convergence chapter).

What it IS NOT. It is not post-interaction quality management (QM), which is Quality & Interaction Analytics. It is not between-call coaching or gamification, which is Performance & Engagement. It is not autonomous deflection or virtual agents that resolve without a human, which is Autonomous CX on the other side of the control-surface line. And it is not standalone enterprise knowledge management: only the in-the-flow, buyer-visible half lives here.

Three common buyer misconceptions. 1. “Agent assist is live transcription.” Transcription is table-stakes; the product is the *guidance* on top – what the agent should say or do next, grounded in something (top-performer behaviors, your own data). 2. “A copilot and an autonomous agent are different products.” Increasingly they are the **same engine** exposed as two SKUs separated only by a human-

approval gate, which is why the assist vendor and the autonomous vendor are usually the same vendor. 3. “More AI guidance is always better.” The mature pitch is *calibrated* guidance and *trusted* guidance: Five9 explicitly suppresses prompts for seasoned agents “so as not to annoy them”, and explainability/evaluation is the 2026 enterprise gate.

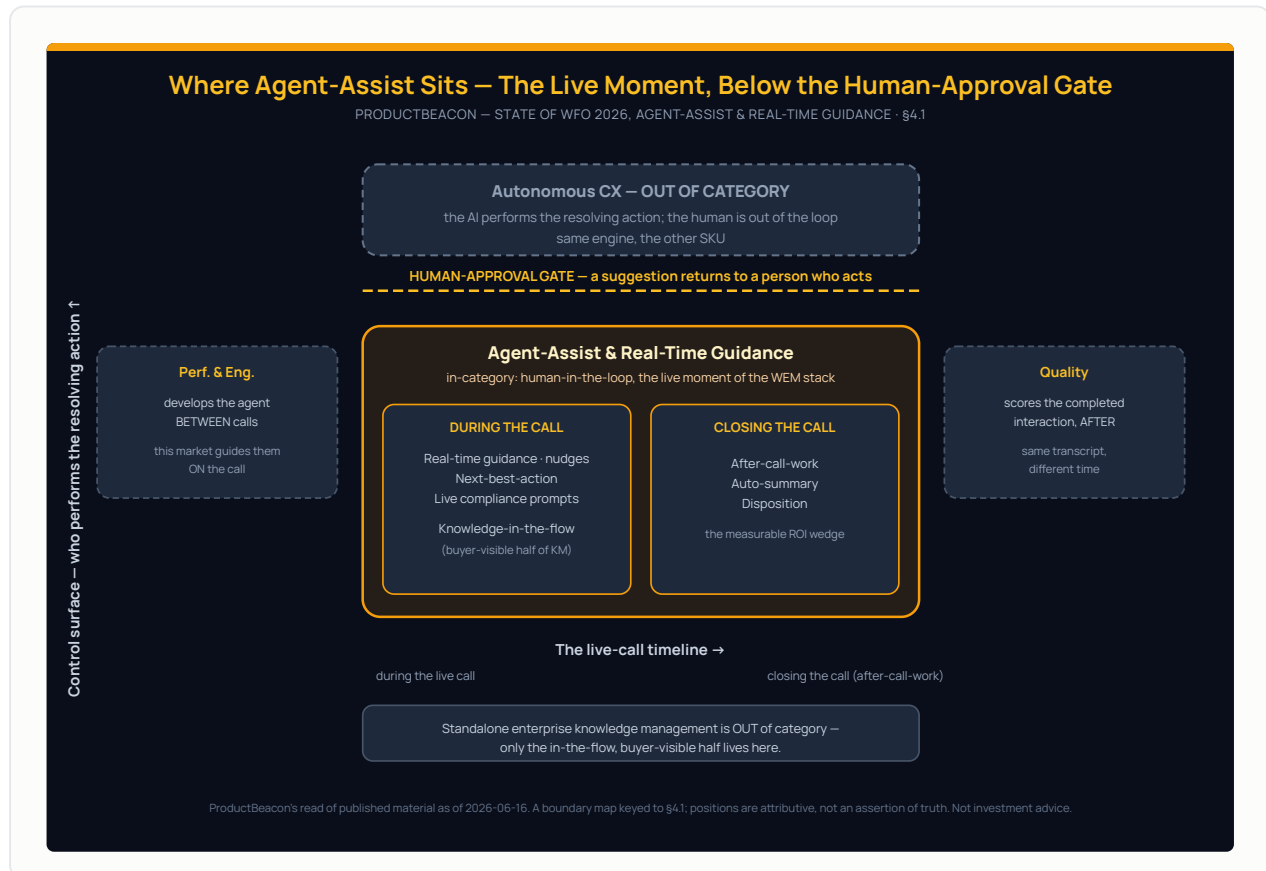


Figure 4.1 – Where Agent-Assist sits: the live-call timeline on the X-axis (from during the call to closing the call), the control surface on the Y-axis, with the human-approval gate as the boundary to Autonomous CX. Quality and Agent-Assist are the

adjacent-time boundaries; only the in-the-flow half of knowledge management is in category.

4.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. The market is sized as **real-time assist to a human agent**: live guidance, knowledge-in-the-flow, next-best-action, and auto-summary / after-call work (ACW). **In scope**: the copilot/guidance layer a human agent uses live. **Out of scope**: autonomous deflection / virtual agents that resolve without a human (Autonomous CX, the control-surface line), and post-interaction QM (Quality & Interaction Analytics). This is the **newest and least cleanly-sized** WEM-core market. Agent-assist is still being separated from the broader Contact Center as a Service (CCaaS) AI blend it was born inside.

Market size: blended and single-source-thin. Exactly one widely-circulated source, market.us, names “real-time agent assist” as its own category: ~\$4.4B in 2024 growing to \$124.6B by 2034 at ~40% CAGR.⁹¹

The market.us figure is reported single-source with improbably-hot growth: carried here as a claim, not settled. The directional anchor is the better-corroborated “**call center AI**” **blend** from Grand View and Fortune, with labeled outliers.⁹²⁹³ Every figure in it is marked **blended**, since agent-assist is one line item inside it. There is no clean standalone dollar total addressable market (TAM) here.

Trends that move the buyer. (1) **Auto-summary / after-call-work automation is the measurable killer app.** The figures are vendor-claimed: Five9 ~40% of agent time⁹⁴, Verint ~30 sec/call⁹⁵. It is the wedge that proves ROI before autonomous resolution. (2) **Real-time RAG (retrieval-augmented generation) knowledge-surfacing**, the buyer-visible half of KM, becomes a default assist capability and thins standalone in-agent KM.⁹⁶ (3) **Next-best-action whisper guidance** is grounded in top-performer behavior.⁹⁷ (4) **The assist-to-autonomous gradient** is the structural story: Gartner’s “80% autonomous by 2029”⁹⁸ pull runs against the counter-signal that a large share of agentic projects get canceled⁹⁹. Both feed the Convergence falsification condition.

Compliance. Real-time processing puts customer data in the live loop, so the HIPAA/PCI/GDPR exposure from Quality & Interaction Analytics applies in real time. On top of that, the **EU AI Act’s prohibition on workplace emotion/sentiment recognition (Art. 5(1)(f)) bites real-time agent-sentiment scoring** specifically (the live version of the Agent-Assist emotion-AI wall — binding the EU deploying employer’s use, narrow medical/safety carve-outs aside), with full application Aug 2026.¹⁰⁰

4.3 The Contenders

Eight vendors are graded on the 3-bucket rubric (cap 8). The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. Each card carries a verbatim vendor pillar with its dated URL inline; latency/accuracy/outcome figures are quoted as *vendor claims*. AI-architecture verbs are publicly-evidenced positioning, not internals.

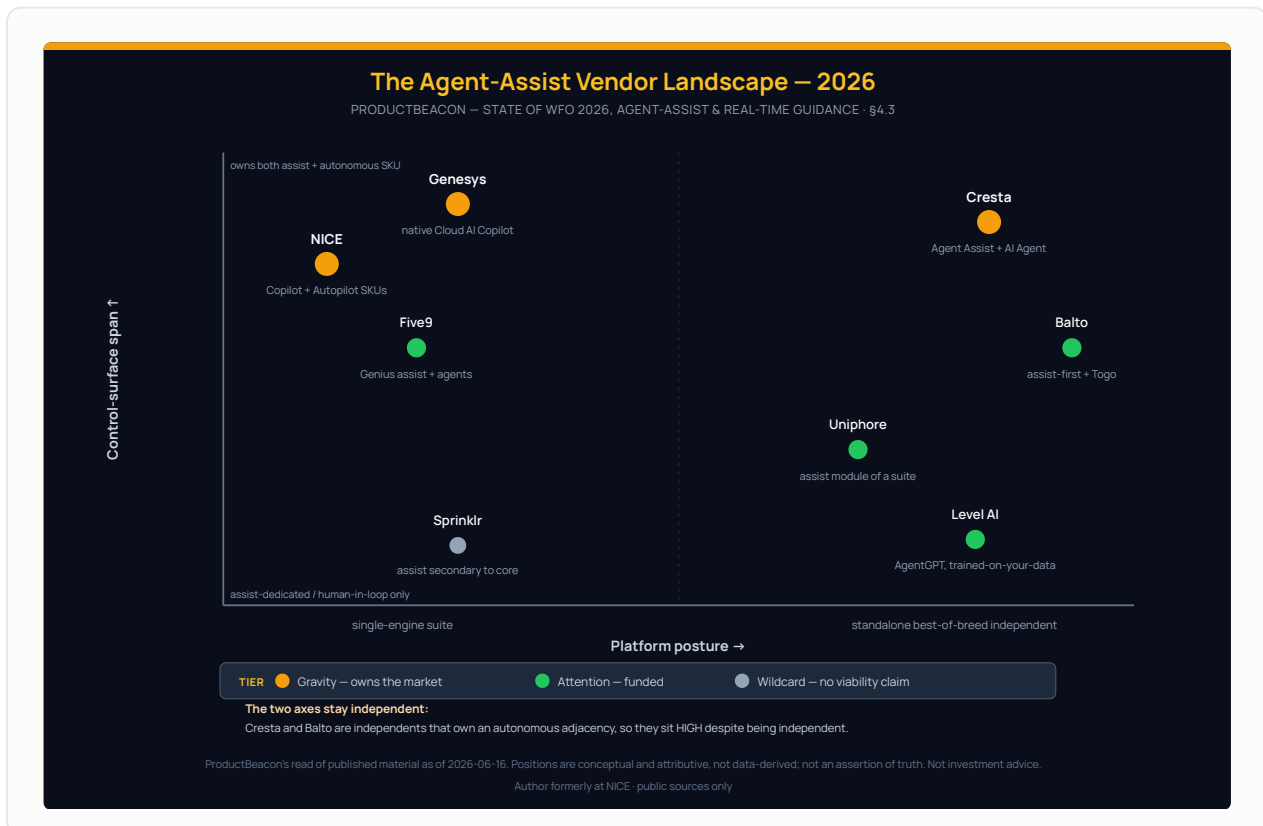


Figure 4.3 – The eight contenders on platform posture (single-engine suite ↔ standalone independent) against control-surface span (assist-dedicated ↔ owns both an assist and an autonomous SKU). Cresta and Balto are the independents that own an autonomous adjacency, so they sit HIGH despite being independent; Sprinklr is the public-company thin-surface hard-case. Positions are attributive reads of published material, not data-derived.

Gravity tier

1. NICE: CXone Mpower Copilot for Agents (Enlighten Copilot). NICE's pillar is "AI copilot for customer service agents" / "Simplify agent work, amplify human impact," across its paired Copilot pages (nice.com).¹⁰¹ The pages promise "Real-time AI assistance... proactively delivers knowledge and next best steps". They add "Knowledge when you need it... The right information appears exactly when

needed". Copilot is the live-moment surface of the same Enlighten engine that scores and coaches; its **Autopilot** is the autonomous SKU on the other side of the control-surface line. NICE is a Convergence P1 proxy.

2. Genesys: Cloud AI Copilot. Genesys pitches **"AI Copilot Agents for Smarter Service"** (genesys.com).¹⁰² On the capability page, **"knowledge, insights, next-best action support, translation and summarization come standard"** in **"a common copilot agent interface"**. The copilot is native to the platform that already routes the interaction; this market is an anchor card, since Genesys's primary home tilts assist/autonomous. Genesys is a P1 proxy.

3. Cresta: Agent Assist (the independent that earns a *second* card). Cresta positions gen-AI-native real-time guidance as a distinct, separately-positioned product, one of four named products: **"Unlock your team's true potential with real-time Agent Assist... real-time hints, reminders, and workflows tailored to each conversation."** The pillar adds **"near-zero latency"** and source-backed knowledge (cresta.com).¹⁰³ A named outlet puts the latency "under 200 ms". *AI positioning:* gen-AI-native. Assist "guides them... without interacting with the customer directly", the human-in-the-loop side of its own AI-Agent line. The scale signal, from vendor and named outlet, is "surpassed \$100M ARR in 2026" (claim, not fact). **Cresta is present in two markets, with a Quality card, this Agent-Assist card, and an Autonomous Play (AI Agent):** the one vendor with two cards.

Attention tier

4. Balto: Real-Time Guidance Platform (the assist-primary independent). Balto's pillar is **"AI Powered Real-Time Guidance Platform"**. The homepage promises **"Help every agent perform like your best with the most advanced agent assist,"** pulling answers from knowledge bases live, "no holds to look up information" (balto.ai).¹⁰⁴ Balto is built assist-first, not bolted onto a QM / Contact Center as a Service core; its **Togo** voice-AI is the autonomous adjacency. *Funding (primary-source): ~\$52M total* per Balto's own Series B release (\$10M Series A from Sierra Ventures, \$37.5M Series B from Stripes in Aug 2021, plus seed).¹⁰⁵ *A later ~\$5.7M round and a ~\$57.6M total appear aggregator-only and are unconfirmed at primary source.*

5. Uniphore: Real-Time Guidance Agent (Business AI Suite). Uniphore pitches **"AI agent assist for the customer journey"** (uniphore.com).¹⁰⁶ The product page promises **"Real-time guidance, contextual answers, and intelligent automation"**, plus after-call-work automation. It adds **"surface the right answers... no search required"**. Uniphore is the heavily-funded independent at the Gravity boundary. Its verified-primary record is **Series E \$400M (Feb 2022, NEA), ~\$2.5B post-money at that round, >\$610M total.**¹⁰⁷ **A Series F of \$260M announced 22 Oct 2025** followed, with investors reported to include NVIDIA, AMD, Snowflake, Databricks, and NEA. **The Series F figure** is reported at this refresh by a single named outlet and is unverified at primary.

Uniphore's last established valuation mark is the ~\$2.5B Series E (Feb 2022). Total raised comes to **>\$870M:** the primary-verified Series E plus the single-outlet-reported Series F. Broader outlet totals of ~\$886M–\$961M remain estimates. Uniphore is graded Attention on symmetric assist-surface-depth grading: assist is one module of a broad suite.

6. Level AI: AgentGPT. Level AI positions AgentGPT as a distinct gen-AI-native assist product, separate from its Quality Auto-QA card: **“a secure, omniscient generative AI system... trained on a client’s proprietary customer conversational data,”** giving **“instant access to documents, links, hints, and warnings while you’re in a conversation”** (thelevel.ai).¹⁰⁸ Its wedge against generic copilots is “trained on your data”. *Total funding is reconciled on its Quality & Interaction Analytics card, not restated here.*

7. Five9: Genius AI Agent Assist (Contact Center as a Service suite assist anchor). It pitches **“real-time guidance cards... personalized to their competency level”**. The calibration is explicit: **“a seasoned agent might receive no real time guidance... whereas new hires will be pushed an exact talk track.”** It adds GPT-powered transcription and summarization that **“reduces... after-call work (ACW)”** (five9.com).¹⁰⁹ Five9 is public (NASDAQ: FIVN); this is its anchor card, and it is a Play on Quality, Workforce Management, and Performance & Engagement. Five9 is a P1 proxy.

Wildcard tier

8. Sprinklr: Agent Copilot (the thin/secondary-surface hard-case). Sprinklr is a public customer-experience suite (NYSE: CXM) whose assist surface is real and dated but secondary to its core: **“GenAI-Powered Support for Agents”** with **“real-time nudges that improve metrics like first call resolution (FCR) and average handle time”** (Spring '26, BusinessWire 7 Apr 2026).¹¹⁰ *Wildcard rationale:* no genuinely-thin seed/Series-A **human-agent-assist-primary** startup with a dated primary-source event cleared the viability bright line for a thin-surface card. The modern assist independents (Balto, Uniphore, Cresta, Level AI) are all well-funded, and the thin privates in the live-moment space are *autonomous-CX-primary*: Sierra, Decagon, and Wonderful sit in Autonomous CX, pre-Series-B, and are held to strategy opinion only there. Carrying a public company as the thin-surface hard-case avoids a viability stretch on an unsourceable private. **No viability claim is at stake (public company).**

Present but graded elsewhere: Observe.AI is Quality-primary with an Agent-Assist Play (its assist is secondary to QM, and the Quality-vs-Autonomous call resolved to Quality); Cogito is the assist capability of Thoma Bravo CX, which is not covered here; Cresta, resolved above, is the one two-card vendor.

4.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: Assist becomes the live-moment module of one AI platform

NICE Copilot, Genesys’s native copilot, and Five9 Genius carry the play for the suites. The independents (Balto, Cresta, Uniphore, Level AI) defend on latency, behavioral-guidance depth, and trained-on-*your*-data. *This play feeds Convergence P1.*

Play 2: The live moment is rebuilt around next-best-action, not transcripts

Cresta pitches “behavioral guidance... grounded in the behaviors of top performers”¹⁰³. NICE pitches “next best steps.” “Live transcription” commoditizes, and differentiation moves to behavioral grounding plus latency.

Play 3: Knowledge-in-the-flow folds into assist, collapsing standalone KM

Cresta ships Knowledge Agent¹¹¹. NICE promises “knowledge when you need it”. Genesys makes “automatic knowledge” standard. Standalone in-agent KM thins, a Convergence input.

Play 4: Real-time assist becomes the on-ramp to autonomous CX

Cresta sells Agent Assist beside AI Agent; Balto sells assist beside Togo; Five9 runs assist inside the Genius agentic motion. The “guide the human” engine and the “be the agent” engine converge. That pulls Agent-Assist into Autonomous CX, where the seat question begins.

Play 5: “Trust the copilot” becomes the enterprise gate, via evaluation + explainability

Sprinklr pitches “Autonomous Evaluation... explainable logs”¹¹⁰. Cresta pitches “Responsible AI.” The same evaluation lens that validates a copilot validates an autonomous agent.

4.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor / acquirer
NICE	Public (NASDAQ/TASE)	Public equity	—
Genesys	Private (Permira/Hellman & Friedman)	not isolated here	—
Cresta	\$125M Series D (Nov 2024); vendor "\$100M ARR 2026" (claim)	\$1.6B	WiL + QIA
Balto	~\$52M total (primary-source) — \$10M A / \$37.5M B (Stripes, Aug 2021) / seed ¹⁰⁵ ; \$57.6M is aggregator-only, unconfirmed	Not disclosed	Sierra Ventures, Stripes
Uniphore	Series E \$400M (Feb 2022, NEA) ¹⁰⁷ ; Series F \$260M (22 Oct 2025, single named-outlet, unverified at primary) ; >\$870M total (primary-verified E + single-outlet F)	~\$2.5B (Series-E mark, Feb 2022)	NEA (Series E); NVIDIA/AMD/Snowflake/Databricks reported (Series F); now an acquirer: ActionIQ/Infoworks ¹¹²
Level AI	(on Quality card, not restated)	—	Adams Street
Five9	Public (NASDAQ: FIVN)	Public equity	—
Sprinklr	Public (NYSE: CXM)	Public equity	—



Figure 4.5 – The primary-source funding events in this market: Balto's Series B, Uniphore's Series E and Series F (the F single-outlet-reported at this refresh, unverified at primary, Oct 2025), Verint's acquisition of Cogito, and Cresta's Series D. Aggregator-only figures (Balto's "\$57.6M total", Cresta's "\$100M ARR") are excluded. Hedges travel verbatim onto the labels. No distress event was found for any contender, so none is plotted. Vertical is not to scale.

The funding story is the spine made visible. The well-funded AI-led assist money mostly sits with vendors that *card on Quality & Interaction Analytics* (Cresta \$1.6B, Observe.AI \$1.4B).

Assist is a line of a bigger AI platform, not a standalone raise. The one dedicated real-time-guidance pure-play (Balto) runs on pre-2022 capital. And the suites *absorbed* assist rather than out-raising it: Verint bought Cogito for \$38.2M.¹¹³ Uniphore is the outlier, ~\$2.5B-valued at a mark set at its Feb 2022 Series E¹⁰⁷, and now itself an acquirer. Uniphore's \$260M Series F was reported Oct 2025 by a single named outlet, unverified at primary.

Fault-lines, disclosed rather than guessed. Balto's "\$57.6M total" did not reconcile at primary source: Balto's own release says ~\$52M¹⁰⁵; the extra round and total are aggregator-only (PitchBook and Tracxn diverge), so the report carries ~\$52M with the caveat. A **name-collision** exists: an unrelated "Balto" acquired by Fubo in 2020 is NOT the contact-center vendor. **Cogito's "\$45M" is an aggregator cumulative** (Series C \$37M in 2018 plus an extension), not a round.¹¹⁴ No distress event was found for any contender, so the report makes no viability claim. The viability bright line applies: strategy opinion only, absent a primary-source event.

4.6 Winning & Losing

These are my read of where this market is heading: each is anchored to public evidence already cited above, framed as opinion, and stated as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Control-Surface, Not the Engine

Observation. The same vendors sell real-time *assist* and *autonomous* CX as two separately-named SKUs on one platform, gated by whether a human acts. The pairs are explicit. NICE sells **Copilot** vs **Autopilot**¹⁰¹. Cresta sells **Agent Assist** (“guides... without interacting with the customer directly”) vs **AI Agent**¹⁰³. Genesys pairs **Copilot** with autonomous agents¹⁰². Five9 pairs **Agent Assist** with agents that “Reason, Decide, and Take Action”¹⁰⁹ (dated vendor pages, accessed 2026-06-16). **My read.** The Agent-Assist / Autonomous CX boundary is a **control-surface** boundary (who performs the resolving action), not an engine boundary – vendors run one engine and expose it as two products separated by a human-approval gate. This is the single-engine thesis made physical, and it is *also* the pricing hinge: the assist SKU keeps a human seat; the autonomous SKU removes it. **Conditional prediction.** If by **Q4 2026** at least **3** Gravity-tier vendors publicly position assist and autonomous as **one platform with a human-in-the-loop gate** (rather than two separate products), the control-surface thesis is confirmed. If instead they keep them architecturally separate, the single-engine collapse is weaker than the marketing implies. **Sources.** The dated vendor SKU pages quoted in the Contenders section (NICE Copilot/Autopilot, Cresta Agent Assist/AI Agent, Genesys, Five9; accessed 2026-06-16) and the control-surface boundary set out earlier in this chapter.

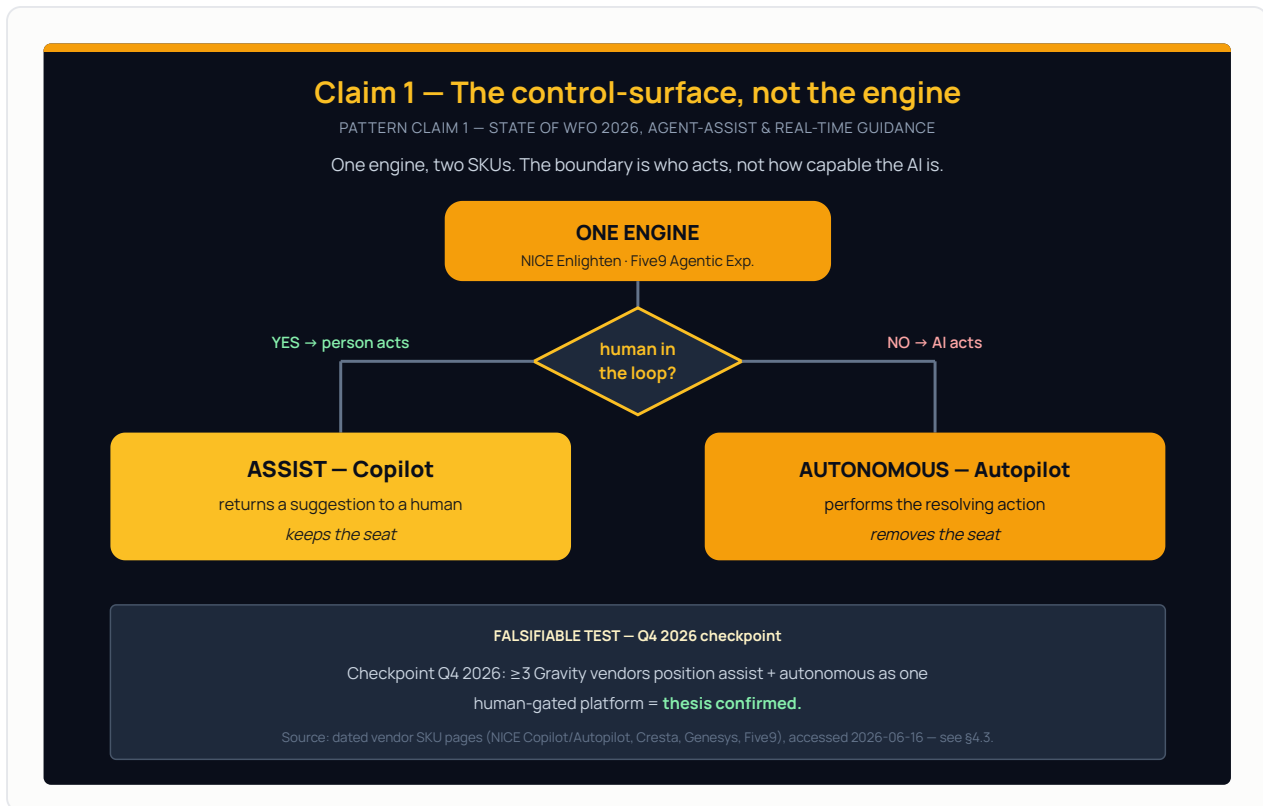


Figure 4.6a – One engine exposed as an assist SKU (Copilot) or an autonomous SKU (Autopilot), gated by whether a human is in the loop. The falsifiable test is boxed at the foot of the figure.

Pattern Claim 2 – Auto-Summary Is the Beachhead

Observation. After-call-work automation (auto-summary, disposition) is the market's measurable ROI wedge, and it ships as a *standard* assist capability across NICE, Genesys, Five9, and Uniphore. The wedge figures are vendor-claimed: Five9 ~40% of agent time⁹⁴, Verint ~30 sec/call⁹⁵. **My read.** After-call work (ACW) automation is the beachhead that proves assist ROI *before* the buyer trusts autonomous resolution — it is low-risk (post-call, human-reviewed), quantifiable, and universal. The vendor that wins ACW credibility earns the right to sell the rest of the copilot, then the autonomous SKU. **Conditional prediction.** If by **H1 2027** auto-summary/ACW automation is a standard, default-on capability across **all** Gravity assist products (not an add-on), it has commoditized as the table-stakes beachhead and differentiation has moved up to live guidance and autonomy. If it is still sold as a premium add-on, the ROI case is not yet settled. **Sources.** The Market Size & Trends section's after-call-work figures (vendor-claimed Five9 ~40% of agent time, Verint ~30 sec/call) and Plays 1 and 3 above.

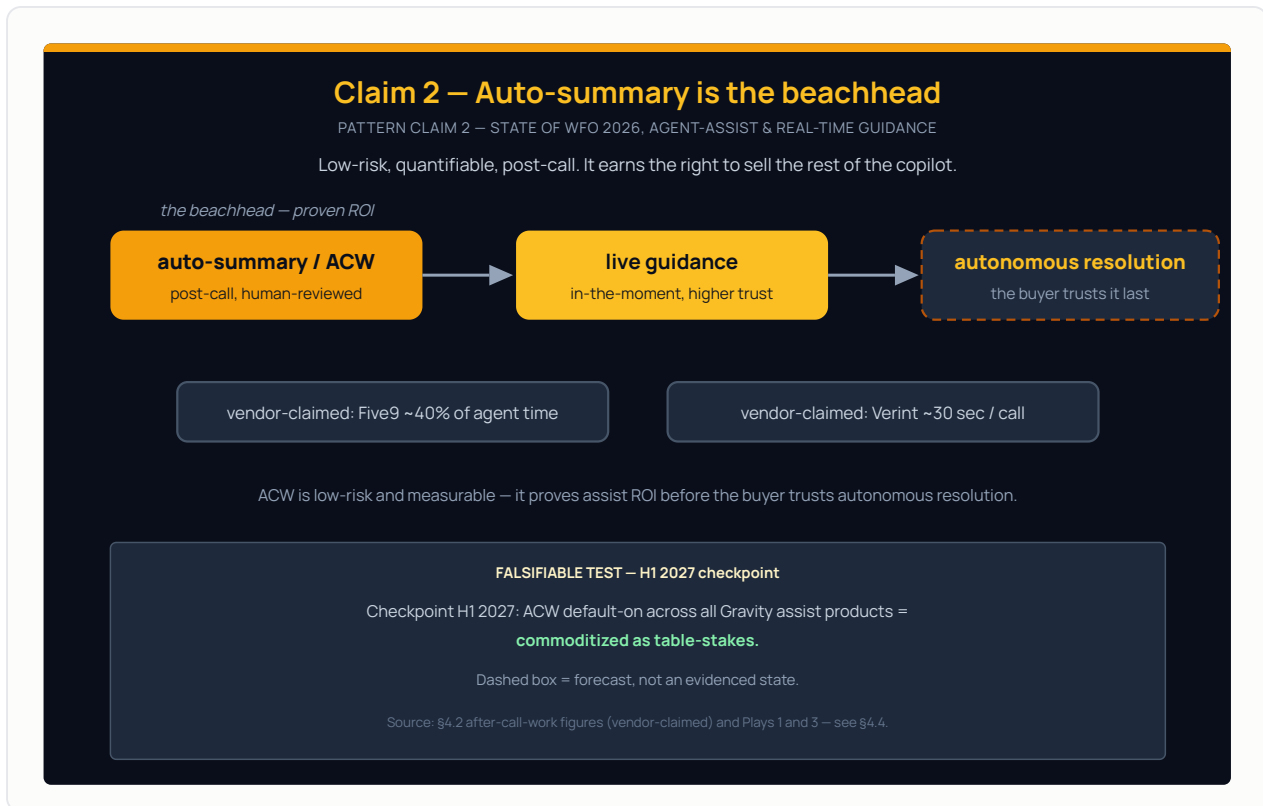


Figure 4.6b — After-call-work automation is the low-risk, measurable ROI wedge the buyer trusts before live guidance and, last, autonomous resolution. The vendor-claimed proof points and the falsifiable test are carried in the figure.

Pattern Claim 3 — The Seat Question Starts at This Boundary

Observation. Assist keeps the human seat, because it guides a person; the *same vendors'* autonomous SKUs remove it (Cresta AI Agent, Balto Togo¹⁰⁴, NICE Autopilot, Five9 agentic CX). Pricing is starting to follow: autonomous-CX vendors publicly list per-resolution/outcome pricing while assist stays per-seat. **My read.** The per-seat → per-outcome pricing migration the Convergence chapter tracks *physically begins at the Agent-Assist / Autonomous-CX control-surface line*: the moment the engine that guided the human starts replacing the human, the unit being priced stops being a seat. Agent-Assist is therefore the earliest observable site where the human seat count starts to fall. **Conditional prediction.** If by **mid-2027** at least **2** Gravity-tier vendors price their assist SKU per-seat but their autonomous SKU per-resolution/outcome on the same platform, the pricing hinge is confirmed at this boundary. If autonomous stays per-seat-priced, the seat-reset thesis is delayed. **Sources.** Play 4 above and the control-surface boundary set out earlier in this chapter; the per-resolution pricing evidence carried in the Autonomous CX chapter.

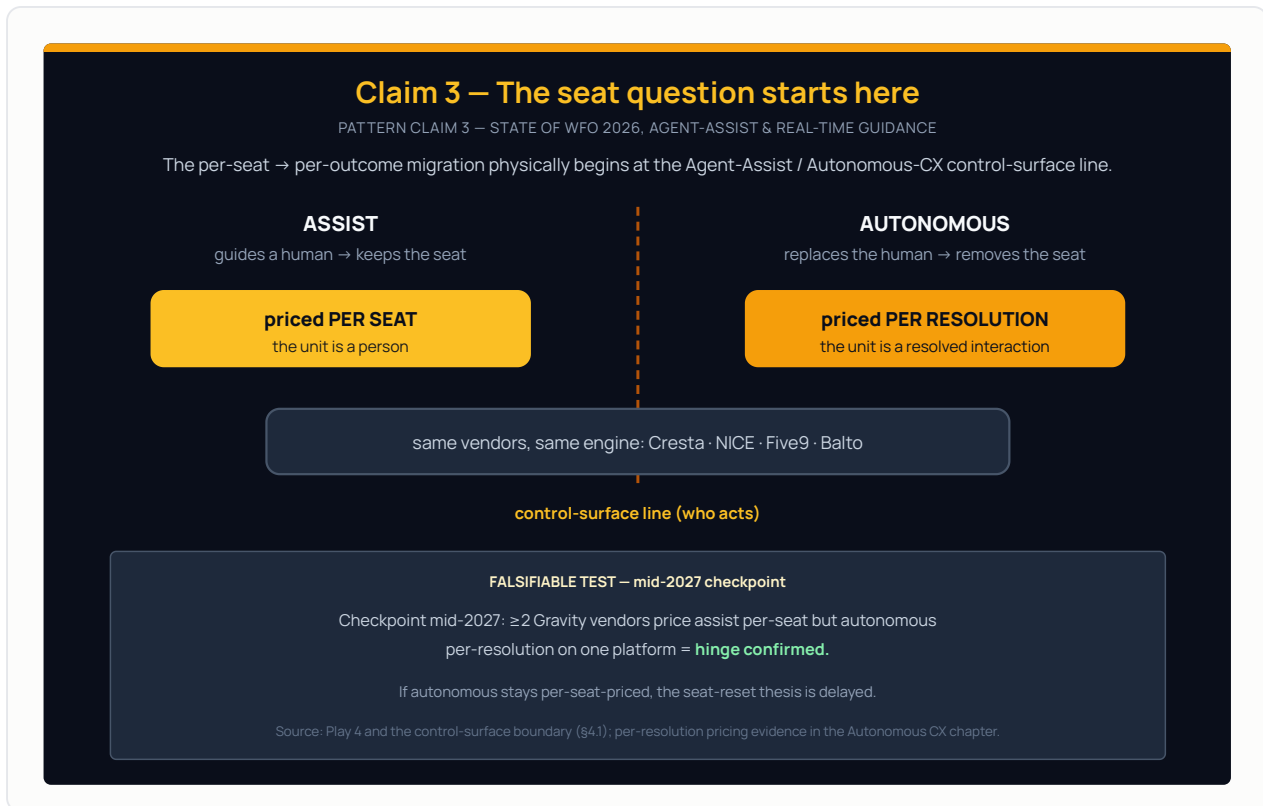


Figure 4.6c – At the control-surface line, assist is priced per seat while the same vendors' autonomous SKU is priced per resolution – the earliest observable site where the human seat count starts to fall. The falsifiable test is boxed at the foot of the figure.

Winners

These verdicts translate the tier placements and plays above; they are my opinion, not a scoreboard. **NICE, Genesys, Five9**. They own the live moment as one surface of a single-engine platform (their Gravity-tier cards above); assist is a module of the AI platform the buyer already runs, not a separate purchase. **Cresta**. It is the independent that earns a second card, on generative-AI depth and named-outlet “under 200 ms” latency; it is the clearest depth-and-latency answer to the suites. **Balto**. It is the assist-primary independent, built assist-first rather than added onto a QM / Contact Center as a Service core.

Watch

The control-surface line itself. The question is whether assist and autonomous stay one human-gated platform or fork into separate products (Pattern Claim 1's Q4 2026 checkpoint). This single question decides the report's single-engine thesis, and Agent-Assist is the earliest place it is observable. **Uniphore**. It is the heavily-funded scale outlier whose assist is one module of a broad suite: its ~\$2.5B mark was set at its Feb 2022 Series E, and Uniphore's \$260M Series F was reported Oct 2025 by a single named outlet, unverified at primary. The watch item is whether that capital converts into live-moment leadership.

Losers

No graded contender here carries a public distress or failure signal: the Funding & Fault-Lines section found no distress event for any of the eight, so I name none rather than manufacture one. The clearest *restructuring* evidence in this market is absorption, not failure. The standalone assist/emotion-AI capability folded into a suite: Cogito was absorbed into Verint, now Thoma Bravo CX, for \$38.2M.¹¹³ And per three of the plays above, knowledge-in-the-flow is collapsing the standalone in-agent knowledge-management surface. I read that as consolidation of the category, not the death of a vendor.

4.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **The control-surface line:** whether ≥ 3 Gravity vendors keep assist and autonomous on one human-gated platform (Pattern Claim 1's checkpoint); the single most important Convergence signal.
2. **Auto-summary/ACW** going default-on across all suites (Pattern Claim 2's checkpoint), the beachhead commoditizing.
3. **Per-seat (assist) vs per-resolution (autonomous) pricing** appearing on the same platform (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint), the seat-reset's first observable site.
4. **Copilot evaluation/explainability** becoming the enterprise procurement gate (Sprinklr "Autonomous Evaluation"; the same lens validates autonomous agents).
5. **The assist-to-autonomous ramp:** whether the Gartner "80% autonomous by 2029" pull or the "agentic projects canceled" counter-signal proves out, the live falsification input to Convergence.

Chapter 5 — The Autonomous CX Market

5.1 What This Market Is

What this market is. Autonomous CX is software where an **AI agent resolves the customer's issue end-to-end with no human in the loop**. It is self-service that *acts*: it executes the refund, processes the claim, and navigates back-office systems to close the case. It does more than answer. It is the other side of the **control-surface line** from Agent-Assist: where Agent-Assist guides a human who acts, Autonomous CX *is* the action. This is the market that physically **resets the seat count** the rest of WFO is priced against. When the agent stops being a human, the unit being staffed, scheduled, scored, and coached changes.

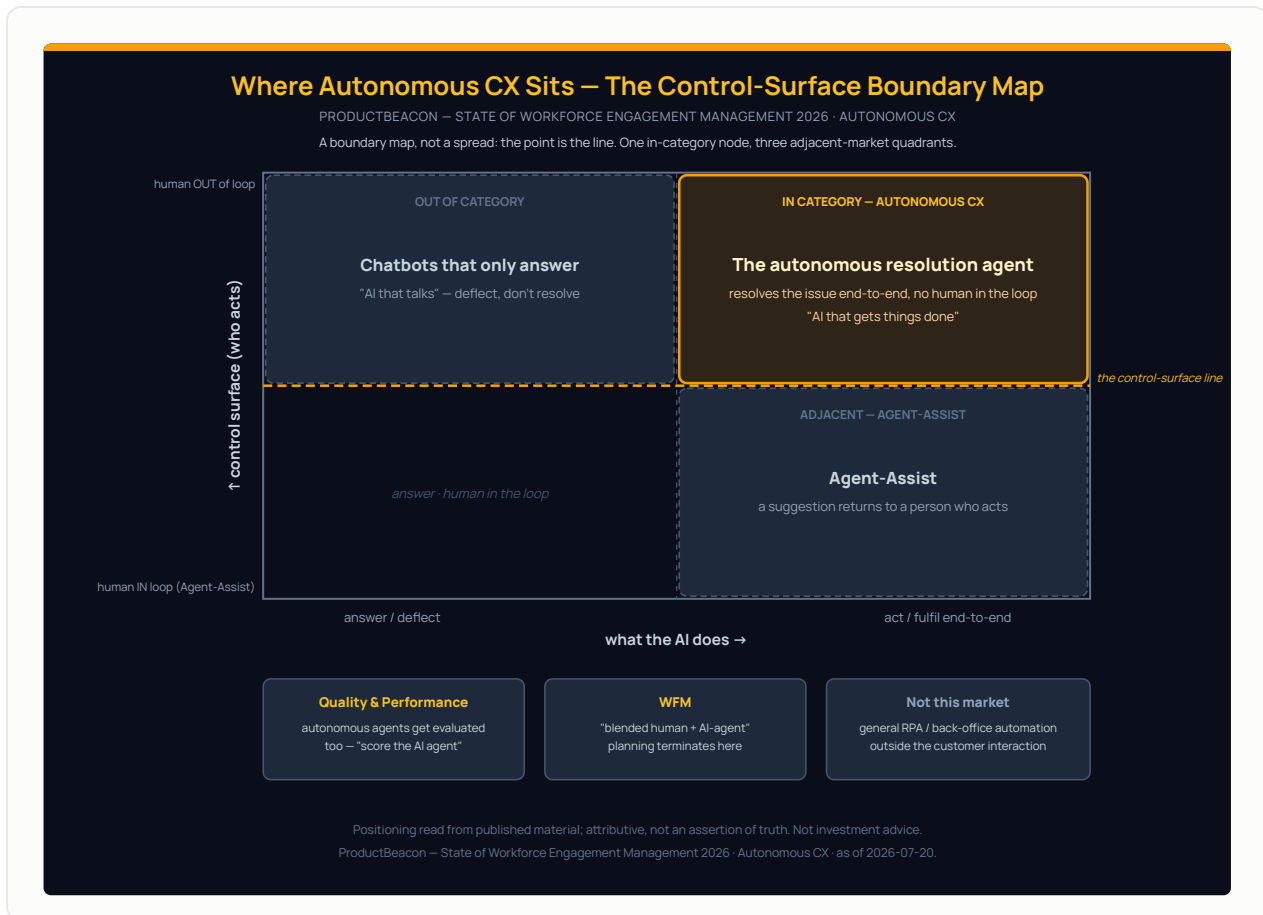
The buyer is the deflected interaction. In practice the buyer is the CX/automation leader buying autonomous resolution, and the thing being bought is the share of contacts that never reach a human at all.

Where the boundaries fall.

- **vs Agent-Assist — the control-surface line:** assist returns a suggestion to a person; autonomous performs the resolving action. **Same engine, two SKUs, gated by who acts**, which is why the assist vendor and the autonomous vendor are usually the same vendor (NICE Copilot/Autopilot; Cresta Agent Assist/AI Agent).
- **vs QM / Performance:** autonomous agents get *evaluated* too — “score the AI agent” pulls quality and performance management onto this market (Sprinklr “Autonomous Evaluation”).
- **vs WFM:** the thing being scheduled stops being only human. WFM's “blended human + AI-agent” planning (Workforce Management Pattern Claim 3) terminates here.

What it IS NOT. Not assist (Agent-Assist — the human still acts). Not chatbots that only *answer* (the “AI that talks” vs “AI that gets things done” line the vendors themselves draw). Not general RPA / back-office automation outside the customer interaction.

Three common buyer misconceptions. 1. *“Autonomous CX is just a better chatbot.”* A chatbot answers; an autonomous agent *acts*: it executes a 40-step refund flow, triggers fulfillment, and works across systems. The dividing line is execution, not eloquence. 2. *“Deflection rate is the metric.”* It is becoming **fulfillment rate**: the share of interactions the agent *resolves end-to-end*, instead of merely keeping them away from a human. 3. *“The frontier valuations mean autonomous has already won.”* The seat-reset is **observable in pricing today** (per-resolution), but the *displacement* is a forecast — and a contested one. Gartner's “80% autonomous by 2029” pull sits against its own counter-signal that a large share of agentic projects get canceled. Price migration is fact; seat elimination is a bet (see the Winning & Losing section).



Where Autonomous CX sits: a boundary map on the control-surface line. One in-category node (the autonomous resolution agent), with the adjacent markets at the edges.

5.2 Market Size & Trends

Category-scoping note. Sized as **autonomous AI agents that resolve customer interactions with no human in the loop** (voice + digital). **In scope:** the autonomous resolution agent. **Out of scope:** real-time assist to a human (Agent-Assist, the control-surface line), and the inflated horizontal "AI agents / agentic AI" market numbers (43–46% CAGRs, hundreds of billions)¹¹⁷. We report those horizontal numbers separately and do not add them into a CX-autonomy TAM. There is no clean standalone autonomous-CX dollar TAM. The nearest CX-scoped market is AI-for-customer-service (~\$12B/2024 → ~\$48B/2030 at ~25.8%, MarketsandMarkets¹¹⁵; CAGR corroborated by Grand View / Mordor conversational-AI ~23–24%¹¹⁶), reported as the wider category, not the autonomous-CX number.

The seat-reset is a direction (P3), not a market size. Public deflection/resolution signals point one way but carry their own caveat. Klarna publicly claimed its AI assistant did the work of ~700 agents / two-thirds of chats – and then, per CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski's 2025 public statements, *partly reversed course* and moved to re-add human support, the single most important counter-datapoint¹¹⁸¹¹⁹. Salesforce cites Agentforce resolving ~84% of its own support (~380K conversations)¹²⁰. Both are reported as labeled, dated vendor/named-outlet claims. In-window coverage (July 2026) enriches both sides of the Klarna datapoint without resolving it: Forbes reports the assistant's workload has grown to the equivalent of ~850 agents (16 Jul 2026), while the re-added human support is reported as gig-structured – “an Uber type of set-up,” per CEO Siemiatkowski (The Guardian, 18 Jun 2026). Both at named-outlet attribution; neither a new reversal nor a retraction.

The central finding: per-resolution pricing is published today (P2). This market is where per-seat licensing visibly breaks. Unlike the seat-displacement *forecast*, the pricing migration is **reader-checkable right now** on dated public pages:

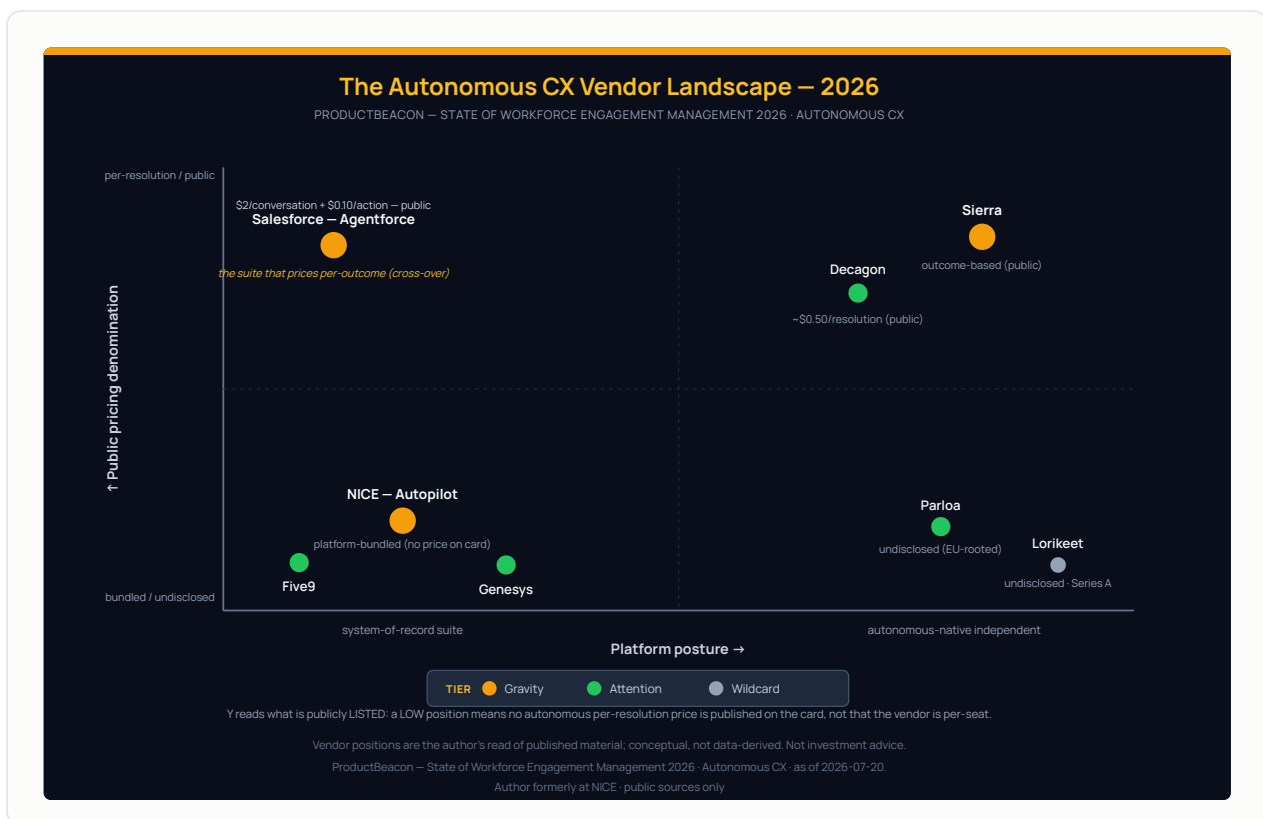
- **Sierra:** outcome-based (“pay on successful resolution”)¹²¹.
- **Salesforce Agentforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action** (Flex Credits)¹²².
- **Fin (formerly Intercom) \$0.99/outcome**¹²³. Its acquisition by Salesforce was announced 15 Jun 2026 (~\$3.6B, close expected Salesforce fiscal Q4 2027).
- **Decagon ~\$0.50/resolution**, on a \$50K platform fee.¹²⁴ **Decagon's price** is reported, not published: the company has no public pricing page.
- **Zendesk per automated resolution** (the construct is printed on its pricing page; the \$1.50–2.00 range as previously reported)¹²⁵.
- **Gorgias ~\$0.60–1.27/resolution**¹²⁵.

On 25 June 2026, after the research cut, **Salesforce announced pay-per-resolution** for its Agentforce Help Agent, “charged when Help Agent resolves an issue autonomously, start to finish” (salesforce.com; GA July 2026). The \$2 price point is reported by CIO and was not yet printed on the pricing page as of 20 July 2026. The result is a coherent pricing layer denominated in *resolutions*, not seats. We re-verified every anchor page above live on 20 July 2026: **none withdrawn, none reverted**. This is the cleanest public proof the Convergence P2 thesis survives its first test. *Sizing confidence is moderate: no clean TAM exists, and that is reported as a gap. P2-pricing confidence is high.*

Compliance. Human-out-of-the-loop resolution sharpens the liability profile. The **EU AI Act deployer bears liability** for an autonomous agent's actions¹²⁶, with full application in August 2026¹²⁷. The agent-governance gap is already a procurement blocker¹²⁸.

5.3 The Contenders

Eight vendors are graded on the 3-bucket rubric (cap 8). The three tiers group vendors by market weight: **Gravity** is the largest incumbents that pull the market, **Attention** is the credible mid-players worth watching, and **Wildcard** is the challenger or thin, early entrant. Each card carries a verbatim vendor pillar + inline dated URL. **The viability bright line is the key discipline here:** funding raises are reported as primary-source fact; viability verdicts on pre-Series-B privates are withheld. AI-architecture verbs are publicly-evidenced positioning.



The Autonomous CX vendor landscape: platform posture (suite vs autonomous-native) against public pricing denomination. Salesforce is the suite cross-over that prices per-outcome.

Gravity tier

1. Salesforce: Agentforce. The market's gravitational center (NYSE: CRM). GA (29 Oct 2024): the pitch is “Trusted, Autonomous AI Agents...” built on the **Atlas Reasoning Engine** (salesforce.com)¹²⁹. Salesforce positions them as going “beyond chatbots and copilots, using advanced reasoning abilities to make decisions and take action, like resolving customer cases,” per the launch release. The same release describes an agent that “doesn’t depend on human engagement to get work done,” in its own words. *Pricing (a flagship P2 anchor, public): \$2/conversation*, then **\$0.10/action** (Flex Credits, May 2025)¹³⁰, plus per-user add-ons, three coexisting publicly-listed models, plus a fourth, pay-per-resolution for Help Agent, announced 25 Jun 2026 (see Market Size & Trends). *Scale (vendor-reported,*

attributed): Salesforce reports Agentforce at “\$1.2 billion in ARR in Q1 FY27, up 205% year-over-year” (salesforce.com release 15 Jun 2026, originating in its 27 May 2026 Q1 FY27 results). It is native autonomous CX on the system of record.

2. NICE: CXone Mpower Autopilot + Mpower Agents. The customer-facing twin of the same Enlighten spine graded across all four preceding markets. **Mpower Agents** (17 Jun 2025): “**fully automated, AI agents... created and deployed in seconds**” that “**automate complete journeys, not just conversations**”. They also “**actively move across systems, trigger actions,**” with the category line “**AI that gets things done**” vs “**AI that talks**” (nice.com)¹³¹. **Cognigy** (acquired 8 Sep 2025, ~\$955M)¹³² is the agentic capability *inside* this card. **The single-engine proof:** NICE positions Mpower agents to “support employees via **Mpower Copilot** or serve customers directly via **Mpower Autopilot**, tapping into the full CXone Mpower ecosystem.”¹³³ That is *one platform, two SKUs, gated by who acts*: the P1 proxy made physical. In a 9 Jun 2026 platform announcement, NICE re-architected the story around the acquired asset: “agentic AI native at the core of its platform,” with NICE Cognigy as the brain and three named layers: NICE AI Agents, Agentic Engagement Plane, Agentic Analytics (nice.com, 9 Jun 2026). The spanning-engine narrative now centers Cognigy alongside Enlighten: the platform story deepens while the engine NAME migrates. It is a Convergence P1 proxy.

3. Sierra: AI agents for CX (autonomous-native, post-Series-E). The most heavily-valued independent (co-founded by ex-Salesforce co-CEO Bret Taylor): “**Better customer experiences. Built on Sierra,**” one agent across “chat, SMS, WhatsApp, email, voice, and ChatGPT” (sierra.ai)¹³⁴. *The P2 signature:* “**only pay for the value Sierra delivers with outcome-based pricing,**” billed “**when the AI agent achieves a successful resolution**” with no charge on escalation (sierra.ai)¹³⁵. *Funding (primary-source):* Series C \$350M at ~\$10B (4 Sep 2025); **Series E \$950M at ~\$15.8B (4 May 2026, GV + Tiger Global).**¹³⁶ *Sierra is post-Series-E, so the viability restriction does not apply.* On 16 July 2026, after the research cut, Sierra extended the model with **Horizon** agents that orchestrate interactions “over days or weeks,” on the same outcomes basis (sierra.ai). The pricing line is unchanged: “you pay for results, not tokens”. TechCrunch reports ~\$200M ARR per a CEO announcement (8 Jul 2026, reported, not primary). The outcome-pricing page was re-verified intact on 20 July 2026.

Attention tier

4. Genesys: Agentic Virtual Agent (suite-native). “**Go beyond responses to real customer outcomes,**” agents that “**reason, plan and execute complete workflows across systems,**” and the blunt line “**Conversations don’t resolve customer issues: execution**”. Its 9 Sep 2025 launch claims “**the industry’s first agentic virtual agent built with large action models (LAMs)**” with A2A + MCP support (genesys.com)¹³⁷. On 30 June 2026, after the research cut, Genesys acquired **Pinkfish**, an agentic-orchestration workflow company, expanding Agentic Virtual Agent with MCP-based tool integration and workflow automation (genesys.com; terms undisclosed). It is a P1 proxy. *Funding note: Genesys’s press-estimated \$15–21B valuation is not carried on the card; the confirmed \$1.5B Salesforce+ServiceNow event was a share-repurchase strategic investment with no post-money.*¹³⁸

5. Five9: AI Agents / Agentic CX (NASDAQ: FIVN). Launch (10 Jun 2025): “**AI Agents that can Reason, Decide, and Take Action,**” “**built on the Agentic Experience Engine,**” paired with an explicit **AI trust & governance** layer (five9.com)¹³⁹. The “**Agentic Experience Engine**”, one named engine powering both Agent Assist and the autonomous AI Agents, is the strongest single-engine-named evidence in the

report. *Freshness note (20 Jul 2026): the Agentic Experience Engine name remains present across Five9's public surfaces as observed this cycle: the launch release ("draw on the Five9 Agentic Experience Engine"), current blog and Genius AI resource pages, and localized product pages. So Five9 counts in the P1 tally as-is. The observed drift is de-emphasis, not fragmentation. The mid-2026 EN product page and the 23 Jun 2026 Voice AI Agents release ("a completely new, purpose-built architecture") keep the name out of primary copy. That is a watch item; the human-oversight gate persists per launch coverage. It is a P1 proxy.*

6. Decagon: AI concierge (autonomous-native, post-Series-D). **"The AI concierge for every customer,"** resolving end-to-end across "voice, chat, and email" with **"cross-channel memory"** on a **"Build once. Deploy everywhere"** model, with a vendor-claimed 70%+ resolution rate (decagon.ai)¹⁴⁰. *Funding (primary-source): Series C \$131M at ~\$1.5B (23 Jun 2025); Series D \$250M at ~\$4.5B (28 Jan 2026, Coatue + Index)*¹⁴¹. *The \$1.5B is the older round; the current mark is \$4.5B.* Decagon is post-Series-D, so the viability restriction does not apply. In June 2026, after the research cut, Decagon launched **Duet Autopilot** and an operator-led positioning push around Agent Operating Procedures (decagon.ai), with no funding delta.

7. Parloa: Agentic AI (autonomous-native, post-Series-D, EU-rooted). The **AI Agent Management Platform**, framed **"Reinvent Customer Service with Agentic AI,"** voice-first at enterprise scale (BusinessWire)¹⁴². *Funding (primary-source): Series C \$120M at ~\$1B (6 May 2025); Series D \$350M at ~\$3B (15 Jan 2026, General Catalyst) — valuation "tripled in ~8 months" (TechCrunch).*¹⁴³ Post-Series-D → no viability restriction. On 17 June 2026, after the research cut, Parloa announced a strategic partnership with Alvaria, calling itself "the first and only agentic AI provider to integrate with the Alvaria Intelligence Platform" (PRNewswire): an autonomous-native vendor tying up with a heritage outbound platform. *(The partner is the Alvaria outbound/compliance platform, not the Aspect WFM line — this is not a WFM event.)*

Wildcard tier

8. Lorikeet: AI Customer Concierge (the genuine viability hard-case, Series A). **"The AI Customer Concierge for complex companies,"** with the wedge **"Where other agents deflect, Lorikeet leans in, handling high-stakes problems with precision": "whether it's a three-step form or a 40-step refund flow, Lorikeet executes with precision."** The positioning pairs honest escalation with a compliance frame (lorikeetcx.ai)¹⁴⁴. *Funding (primary-source): Series A \$35M (~Aug 2025, QED Investors), preceded by \$5M seed (Oct 2024) + \$9M extension (Feb 2025).*¹⁴⁵ **Held to strategy opinion only at this Series-A funding stage: funding reported as fact; NO viability/displacement/distress claim.** *(Named-outlet "~\$75M total / val >\$200M" carried as a claim, not audited fact.)*

Cross-market bookkeeping: Cresta's AI Agent is a Play here (Cresta is a two-card vendor, Quality + Agent-Assist); Observe.AI's VoiceAI is a Play (Quality is its primary card); Sprinklr's Autonomous Evaluation is a Play (recorded once in the cross-market ledger, not double-listed). Cognigy sits inside NICE; Thoma Bravo CX appears only as a Play via Cogito (not covered here). The viability bright line held for the alternates too: Wonderful (\$100M Series A)¹⁴⁶, Crescendo (\$50M/~\$500M)¹⁴⁷, Gradient Labs (\$26M Series A): all funding as fact, viability silent.

5.4 What the Vendors Are Doing

Play 1: Two engines – the system-of-record suite vs the autonomous-native independent

Suites sell autonomous CX as a native module on the platform you already run (Agentforce, NICE Mpower Agents, Genesys, Five9). The natives sell the agent as the whole product (Sierra, Decagon, Parloa, Lorikeet). The market's central falsification condition: does "it's already on your platform" beat "we resolve harder, end-to-end, priced per outcome." *Feeds Convergence P1*.

Play 2: Per-resolution / outcome pricing becomes the market's economic signature

Sierra outcome-based; Salesforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action; Decagon ~\$0.50; Intercom Fin \$0.99: the cleanest public **vendor-pricing-disclosure** evidence for P2, reported as pricing disclosure, *never* a seat-count forecast.

Play 3: "Reason + act across systems" replaces "answer the question" – deflection becomes fulfillment

NICE "AI that gets things done"; Genesys "goal attainment" over "intent matching"; Salesforce Atlas; Five9 "reason, decide, act." The buyer's metric becomes *fulfillment rate*, not deflection rate.

Play 4: The assist engine becomes the autonomous engine – the two-market pull from Agent-Assist completes here

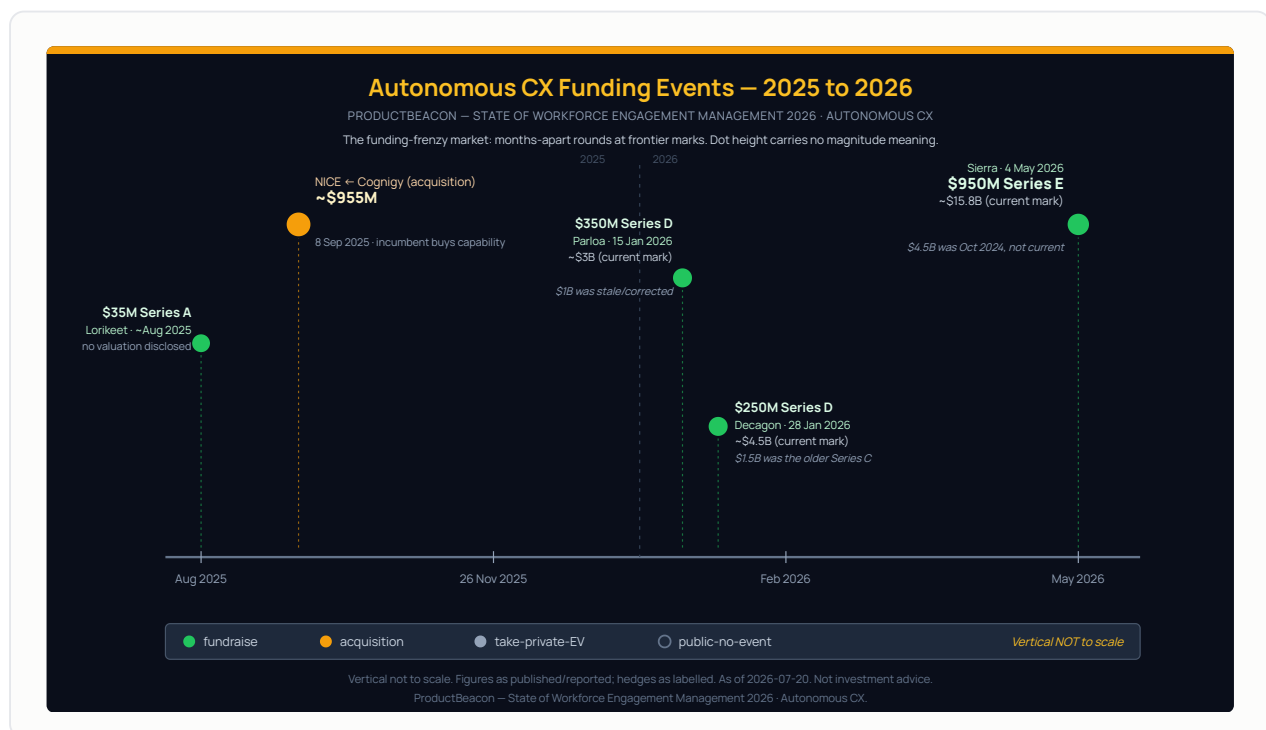
Cresta AI Agent¹⁴⁸; Observe.AI VoiceAI¹⁴⁹; Balto Togo. The per-seat→per-outcome migration begins exactly where the engine that *guided* the human starts *replacing* the human.

Play 5: Trust, governance, and evaluation become the autonomous-CX procurement gate

Five9 trust & governance; Genesys guardrails + A2A/MCP; Salesforce "Trusted"; Sprinklr "Autonomous Evaluation."¹⁵⁰ The same evaluation lens that validates a copilot validates an autonomous agent.

5.5 Funding & Fault-Lines

Vendor	Round / status	Valuation	Investor
Salesforce	Public (NYSE: CRM)	Public equity	—
NICE	Public (NASDAQ/TASE); Cognigy ~\$955M (8 Sep 2025) ¹⁵¹	Public equity	acquirer
Sierra	Series E \$950M (4 May 2026) ¹⁵²	~\$15.8B	GV, Tiger Global
Genesys	Private (Permira/H&F); \$1.5B Salesforce+ServiceNow <i>share-repurchase</i> (no post-money) ¹⁵³	not carried (press-estimate \$15–21B unconfirmed)	—
Five9	Public (NASDAQ: FIVN)	Public equity	—
Decagon	Series D \$250M (28 Jan 2026) ¹⁵⁴	~\$4.5B	Coatue, Index
Parloa	Series D \$350M (15 Jan 2026) ¹⁵⁵	~\$3B	General Catalyst
Lorikeet (Wildcard)	Series A \$35M (~Aug 2025) ¹⁵⁶	not disclosed (no viability claim)	QED



Autonomous CX funding events, 2025 to 2026: months-apart rounds at frontier marks alongside the NICE-Cognigy acquisition. Vertical not to scale.

The funding-frenzy market. The autonomous-native independents are raising at frontier valuations on months-apart rounds: Sierra ~\$15.8B, Decagon ~\$4.5B, Parloa ~\$3B, each re-priced within ~7–8 months. The incumbents *build or buy* (NICE→Cognigy ~\$955M) rather than out-raise. The structural read: autonomous CX is the one WEM market where independent capital is genuinely competing with the suites for the category, not just the feature.

Fault-lines (disclosed, not guessed; figures re-verified at primary source). Multiple valuations in the report's working brief were **stale and corrected**: Decagon's current mark is \$4.5B, not \$1.5B (that was the older Series C); Parloa is \$3B, not \$1B; Sierra's \$4.5B was Oct 2024, not current. **Genesys's \$15–21B is press-estimate-only and is NOT carried here**: the confirmed event was a share-repurchase strategic investment with no post-money. **Lorikeet has no disclosed valuation** at any round (none asserted). No distress/viability claim on any private (strategy opinion only, absent a primary-source event).

5.6 Winning & Losing

These are my read of where this market is heading — each anchored to public evidence already cited above, framed as opinion, and stated as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint.

Pattern Claim 1 — The Seat-Reset Is Priced, Not Forecast

Observation. Autonomous-CX vendors publicly list pricing denominated in *resolutions*, not seats, on dated pages today: Sierra outcome-based (“pay on successful resolution”) ¹²¹, Salesforce Agentforce \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action ¹²², Fin (formerly Intercom) \$0.99/outcome ¹²³. Decagon is at ~\$0.50 (reported) ¹²⁴, and Zendesk prices per automated resolution (vendor pages / named-outlet, 2026-06-16; anchor pages re-verified 2026-07-20: none withdrawn or reverted) ¹²⁵. **My read.** The per-seat→per-outcome migration the Convergence chapter tracks is *observable in pricing now* — a published, reader-checkable fact, distinct from the *seat-displacement forecast* (which is contested). The economic unit of CX is moving from the seat to the resolved interaction. The vendors have already re-denominated their price lists to match. This is the strongest single piece of public evidence for the report's central bet. **Conditional prediction.** If by **H1 2027** at least **2** Gravity-tier vendors price a flagship customer-facing CX-agent SKU primarily off per-seat (to per-resolution / per-conversation / per-action) on a dated public page, the pricing migration is confirmed. If the flagship SKUs revert to or stay per-seat, the seat-reset is a marketing frame, not an economic one. (*Watch the single most important counter-signal: any vendor publicly reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat.*) **Sources.** The Market Size & Trends section's published per-resolution price lists (Sierra, Agentforce, Intercom Fin, Decagon, Zendesk; vendor pages / named outlets, accessed 2026-06-16) and Play 2 above.

Claim 1 — The seat-reset is priced, not forecast

Per-resolution price lists are public, dated, and reader-checkable today.

Sierra	outcome-based — pay on successful resolution
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Salesforce Agentforce	\$2 / conversation + \$0.10 / action
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Intercom Fin	\$0.99 / resolution
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Decagon	~\$0.50 / resolution (+ platform fee)
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Zendesk	\$1.50–2.00 / automated resolution
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the unit of value: SEAT → RESOLVED INTERACTION (pricing = fact)

Counter-signal to watch: any Gravity vendor reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat.

FALSIFIABLE TEST — checkpoint H1 2027

CONFIRMED if at least 2 Gravity-tier vendors price a flagship customer-facing CX-agent SKU off per-resolution / per-conversation / per-action on a dated public page.

FALSIFIED if the flagship SKUs revert to or stay per-seat — the seat-reset is a marketing frame, not an economic one.

ProductBeacon — State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026 · Autonomous CX · Pattern Claim 1 · as of 2026-07-20.

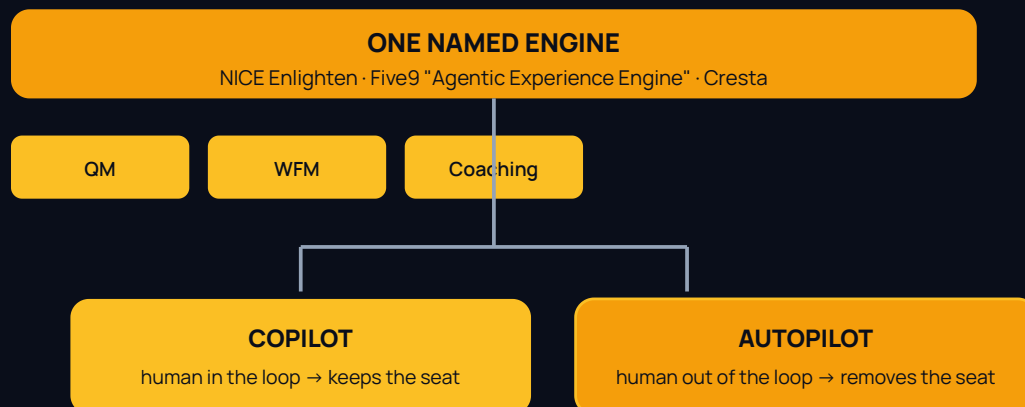
Claim 1 — the seat-reset is priced, not forecast: per-resolution price lists are public, dated, and reader-checkable today.

Pattern Claim 2 – One Engine, Gated by Who Acts

Observation. The suites position autonomous CX as the customer-facing SKU of the *same* engine that powers their assist SKU. NICE's Mpower agents "support employees via Mpower **Copilot** or serve customers directly via Mpower **Autopilot**, tapping into the full CXone Mpower ecosystem."¹³³ Five9's autonomous AI Agents and Agent Assist both run on one named "**Agentic Experience Engine**"¹³⁹. Cresta pairs Agent Assist with AI Agent on one platform (dated vendor pages, 2026-06-16)¹⁴⁸. **My read.** The single-engine P1 thesis is *made physical* at the control-surface gate: one engine, exposed as assist or autonomous depending only on whether a human is in the loop. The suite's advantage is that the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs for QM/WFM/coaching/assist. That is exactly the single-engine-collapse claim, now visible as a SKU boundary rather than an architecture diagram. **Conditional prediction.** If by **Q4 2026** at least **3** Gravity-tier vendors publicly name one platform/engine spanning assist *and* autonomous (a Copilot/Autopilot-style paired SKU on one ecosystem), the single-engine collapse is confirmed at the product surface. If assist and autonomous remain separately-branded, separately-architected products, the collapse is weaker than the marketing implies. **Sources.** The NICE Mpower Copilot/Autopilot and Five9 "Agentic Experience Engine" copy quoted in the Contenders section (accessed 2026-06-16) and Play 1 above.

Claim 2 – One engine, gated by who acts

The autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs.



NICE's own copy: Mpower agents serve via Copilot OR Autopilot, "tapping the full CXone Mpower ecosystem." Checkpoint Q4 2026: ≥3 vendors.

FALSIFIABLE TEST – checkpoint Q4 2026

CONFIRMED if at least 3 Gravity-tier vendors publicly name one platform / engine spanning assist and autonomous (a Copilot / Autopilot-style paired SKU on one ecosystem).

FALSIFIED if assist and autonomous stay separately-branded, separately-architected products – the collapse is weaker than the marketing implies.

ProductBeacon – State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026 · Autonomous CX · Pattern Claim 2 · as of 2026-07-20.

Claim 2 – one engine, gated by who acts: the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the engine the buyer already runs.

Pattern Claim 3 – Fulfillment, Not Deflection, and the Contested Displacement

Observation. Vendors are redefining the metric from *deflection* (keep it from a human) to *fulfillment* (the agent executes the resolution end-to-end: NICE “AI that gets things done,”¹³¹ Genesys “execution,”¹³⁷ Lorikeet “40-step refund flow”¹⁴⁴). Meanwhile the displacement evidence is genuinely two-sided (Salesforce ~84% self-resolution¹²⁰ vs Klarna’s public partial *reversal* of its agent-replacement claim¹¹⁹; Gartner’s 80%-by-2029¹⁵⁷ vs its ~40%-of-agentic-projects-canceled-by-2027¹⁵⁸). **My read.** The category’s *capability* claim (fulfillment, not deflection) is advancing fast and is the right buyer metric. The *displacement* claim (autonomous removes the human seat at scale) is contested and is the report’s real falsification condition. Price migration is fact, fulfillment is rising, but seat elimination at scale is a bet with a live counter-signal.

Conditional prediction. If by **mid-2027** named enterprises publicly report *sustained* (not pilot-only) autonomous fulfillment rates above 50% on a primary channel **without a Klarna-style reversal**, the displacement thesis strengthens. If the public reversals/cancellations outweigh the sustained-fulfillment disclosures, the seat-reset stays a pricing phenomenon ahead of a staffing one. **Sources.** The Market Size & Trends section’s deflection and counter-signal evidence (Salesforce ~84% self-resolution; the Klarna counter-signal; Gartner’s 80%-by-2029 vs its cancellation projection) and Play 3 above.

Claim 3 — Fulfillment, not deflection

The metric shifts; the displacement stays a genuinely two-sided bet.



Honest position: pricing = fact · fulfillment = rising · seat elimination = the bet.

Checkpoint mid-2027: sustained (non-pilot) fulfillment above 50% on a primary channel, no Klarna-style reversal.

FALSIFIABLE TEST — checkpoint mid-2027

DISPLACEMENT STRENGTHENS if named enterprises publicly report sustained (not pilot-only) autonomous fulfillment above 50% on a primary channel, no Klarna-style reversal.

STAYS PRICING-ONLY if public reversals / cancellations outweigh sustained-fulfillment disclosures — the seat-reset stays a pricing phenomenon ahead of a staffing one.

ProductBeacon — State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026 · Autonomous CX · Pattern Claim 3 · as of 2026-07-20.

Claim 3 — fulfillment, not deflection: the metric shifts while seat-displacement stays a genuinely two-sided bet.

Winners

These verdicts translate the tier placements and plays above. They are my opinion, not a scoreboard.

Salesforce. Agentforce is native autonomous CX on the system of record, with per-conversation and per-action pricing already public¹³⁰ (its Gravity-tier card above). **NICE.** Autonomous on the WEM incumbent: Mpower Autopilot is the customer-facing SKU of the same Enlighten spine graded across all four preceding markets, with Cognigy (~\$955M)¹³² bought in as the agentic capability. The system-of-record pull is the strongest position in this market: the autonomous SKU is a configuration of the platform the buyer already runs.

Watch

Sierra, Decagon, Parloa: the autonomous-native independents funded at frontier marks (~\$15.8B¹⁵², ~\$4.5B¹⁵⁴, ~\$3B¹⁵⁵) and priced per outcome; whether that capital out-runs the suites' installed-base advantage is the market's central contest. **The whole thesis:** whether rising fulfillment plus public per-

resolution pricing (fact) converts into seat elimination (forecast), or the live counter-signal wins (Pattern Claim 3's mid-2027 checkpoint). **Lorikeet** and the thin Series-A cohort: funding is real and reported as fact, and under the viability discipline the report makes no call on their survival.

Losers

No graded contender in this market carries a public distress or failure signal: the Funding & Fault-Lines section records no distress or viability event on any private. The clearest *restructuring* here is consolidation rather than failure: incumbents buying capability into the owned stack (NICE's ~\$955M Cognigy purchase) rather than any vendor going under. The genuinely exposed position is not a company at all. It is per-seat licensing itself – and the published per-resolution price lists are already displacing it. The live counter-signal to the whole displacement thesis remains the Klarna reversal discussed in Pattern Claim 3.

5.7 The Road Ahead (H2 2026 watchlist)

1. **Per-resolution pricing on flagship SKUs** (Pattern Claim 1's checkpoint), plus the single most important counter-signal: any vendor reverting off per-resolution.
2. **One named engine spanning assist + autonomous** across ≥ 3 Gravity vendors (Pattern Claim 2's checkpoint): the single-engine collapse at the product surface.
3. **Sustained (not pilot) autonomous fulfillment rates** vs Klarna-style reversals (Pattern Claim 3's checkpoint): the displacement falsification.
4. **Autonomous-agent trust/governance/evaluation tooling** becoming the procurement gate (Five9, Genesys, Salesforce, Sprinklr).
5. **The funding frenzy's first correction**: whether the frontier valuations (Sierra/Decagon/Parloa) hold or the Gartner cancellation counter-signal reaches the cap table.

The Convergence Synthesis — One Engine, One Seat-Count Reset

The Bet

The thesis the whole report is built to test, in one sentence:

As WEM buyers renew through 2026–2027, the classic WFO stack — recording → quality → workforce management → coaching — is consolidating onto a single AI brain, and the value WFO captures is migrating from per-seat licensing toward per-outcome / per-resolution pricing as autonomous agents absorb the interactions a human seat used to handle.

It is a *bet*, not a description: falsifiable, with a dated falsification condition (the unified verdict below). It rests on three proxies. The five preceding markets were each structured to test one of them on **public, reader-checkable evidence**, never on a forecast:

- **P1: one engine** (the stack collapses onto a single AI brain): tested at the *product surface* (Proxy P1 below).
- **P2: seat → outcome** (the pricing unit changes): tested on *published price lists today* (Proxy P2 below).
- **P3: the seat absorbs** (autonomous agents take the volume a seat used to handle): tested on *deflection/fulfillment signals* — and this is the contested one (Proxy P3 below).

The honest headline, delivered before the evidence: **P1 is strongly evidenced and P2 is observable fact today; P3, the actual seat elimination, is a contested forecast, and it is the report's live falsification risk.** The repricing is real; the displacement is a bet.



Figure C.1 — The bet in one frame: the classic stack collapses onto one AI brain, and value migrates from per-seat licensing toward per-outcome pricing. P1 and P2 are evidenced; P3 is the contested forecast.

Proxy P1: One engine, made physical

The single-engine claim is not an architecture diagram we drew; it is a **SKU boundary the vendors drew themselves**, and it is visible three ways across the markets:

1. **The multi-market card pattern.** The same suites card as *distinct, separately-positioned products* on market after market. **NICE carries a card on all five WEM-module markets** (Quality, WFM, Performance, Assist, Autonomous); Genesys carries one on five; Thoma Bravo CX (Verint+Calabrio) on three. Thoma Bravo CX is a *Play*, not a card, on Assist and Autonomous, where its surface is the absorbed Cogito. That breadth is not double-counting, since each card is a genuinely distinct product per the cross-market ledger. It is the single vendor positioning one platform across the whole stack. On 22 June 2026, after the research cut, Salesforce extended the same pattern beyond its Autonomous CX card with **Agentforce Contact Center WEM**, “the only WEM solution with AI, CRM, and every channel built in,” per the vendor page (salesforce.com). It adds workforce management and quality management, with visibility of both human and AI activity.

The multi-market card pattern

One vendor, positioned across the whole stack. Card = graded contender · Play = appears, primary home elsewhere.

	QM	WFM	Perf	Assist	Auton.
NICE	Card	Card	Card	Card	Card
Genesys	Card	Card	Card	Card	Card
Thoma Bravo CX	Card	Card	Card	Play	Play
Five9	Play	Play	Play	Card	Card
Cresta	Card	—	—	Card	Play

Card = graded contender
 Play = appears, primary home elsewhere

The breadth is not double-counting — each card is a distinct product (cross-market ledger). It is one platform spanning the stack.
 5 WEM-module markets shown (Quality, WFM, Perf, Assist, Auton.); Recording context front deferred this edition. — = not present on

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Figure C.2a — The multi-market card pattern: one vendor positioned across the whole WEM stack. Card = graded contender; Play = appears, primary home elsewhere.

2. **The named engine.** The suites increasingly give the engine *one name* spanning the modules. NICE's **Enlighten** scores in Quality, forecasts in WFM, coaches in Performance, guides in Assist, and resolves in Autonomous. Five9's **"Agentic Experience Engine"** explicitly powers both Agent Assist and the autonomous AI Agents.¹⁵⁹ One engine, many surfaces.

Freshness (to 20 Jul 2026): the naming surface moved on three vendors. **Verint**, merged with Calabrio and now presenting unified under the Verint brand, launched **Agent Factory**, a named orchestration environment for human + AI agent workforces beside its Workforce / Desktop / Quality Intelligence agentic capabilities (verint.com / BusinessWire, 23 Jun 2026). The counterweight is the CEO's own framing: "in a lot of ways... more repositioning of technology that we've had in place" (Dave Rhodes, attributed, CMSWire). **NICE**'s June 2026 re-architecture names NiCE Cognigy's agentic AI as "the brain of the platform," with three new layers: NiCE AI Agents, Agentic Engagement Plane, Agentic Analytics (nice.com, 9 Jun 2026). The spanning-engine NAME is migrating from Enlighten-only toward Cognigy-plus-Enlighten even as the one-platform story deepens. **Five9**'s Agentic Experience Engine name remains present across its public surfaces as observed this cycle (the launch release, current blog and Genius AI resource pages, and localized product pages), so Five9 counts in the Q4-2026 tally as-is. The observed drift is de-emphasis: the mid-2026 EN product page and the June 2026 Voice AI Agents release keep the name out of primary copy. That is a watch item, not fragmentation.

3. **The control-surface SKU gate (the physical proof).** The cleanest evidence is the Agent-Assist / Autonomous-CX boundary established in Agent-Assist and completed in Autonomous CX: the same engine is exposed as *assist* or *autonomous* depending only on **whether a human is in the loop**. NICE's own copy is the report's single clearest instance: its Mpower agents "support employees via

Mpower Copilot or serve customers directly via **Mpower Autopilot**, tapping into the full CXone Mpower ecosystem.”¹⁶⁰ The result is one platform, two SKUs, gated by who performs the action. Cresta (Agent Assist ↔ AI Agent) and Five9 (Agent Assist ↔ AI Agents on one engine) draw the same gate.

The per-market Winning/Losing sections kept returning to the same strategic consequence: the suite's autonomous (or assist, or coaching) SKU is a *configuration of the engine the buyer already runs*. That is the “one AI brain collapses the stack” claim rendered as a procurement reality rather than a slide.

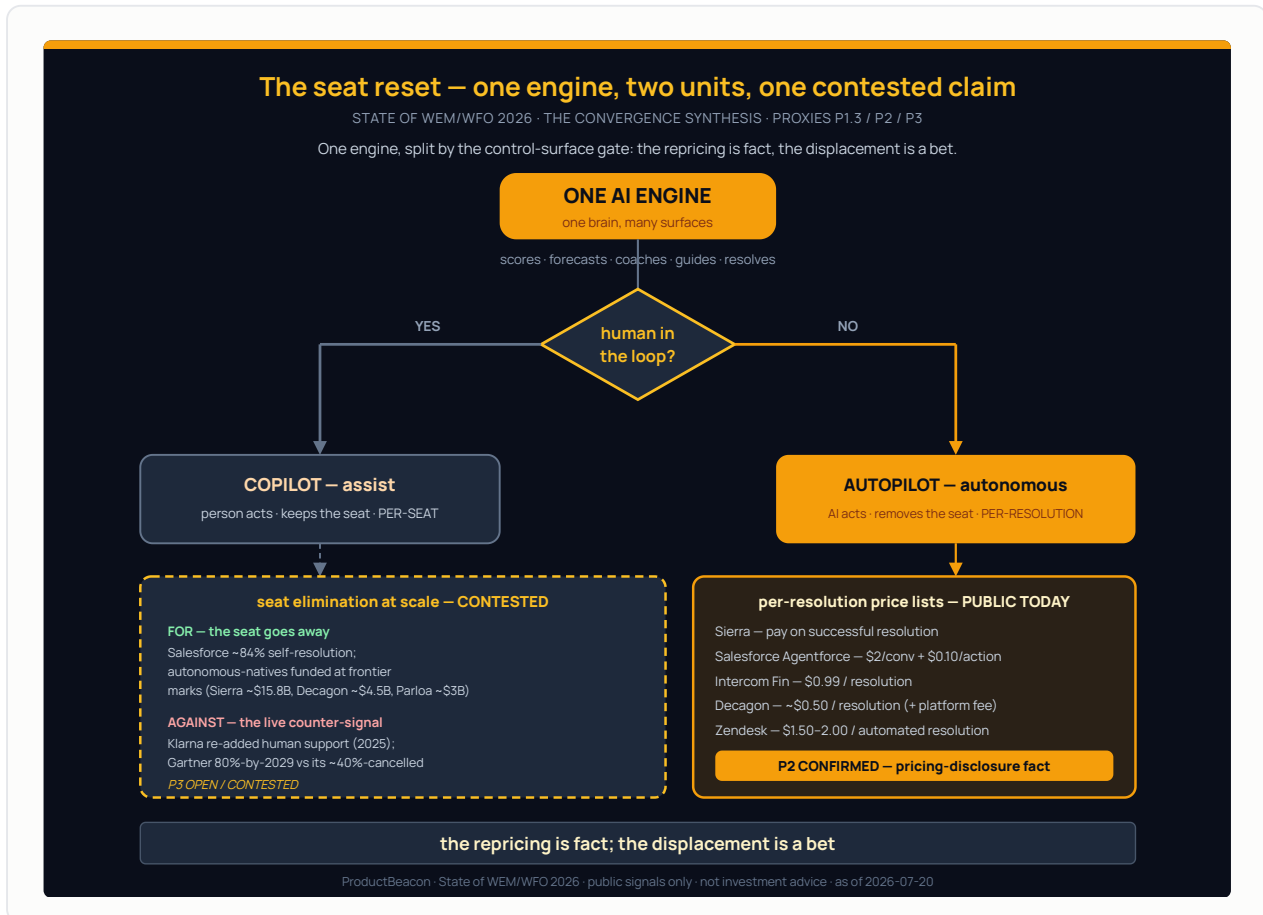


Figure C.2b — The seat reset: one engine, split by the control-surface gate into per-seat assist and per-resolution autonomous. The repricing (P2) is an observable fact; the displacement (P3) is contested.

Proxy P2: Seat → outcome, observable in price lists today

P2 is the proxy that most cleanly survives public testing, because, unlike the displacement forecast, the **pricing migration is already printed on dated public pages**. Autonomous CX is where per-seat licensing visibly breaks:

Vendor	Published unit	(market)
Sierra	outcome-based — “pay on successful resolution,” no charge on escalation ¹⁶¹ ; extended to Horizon agents (“you pay for results, not tokens,” 16 Jul 2026)	Autonomous
Salesforce Agentforce	\$2 / conversation + \$0.10 / action (Flex Credits) ¹⁶² ; pay-per-resolution announced for Help Agent (25 Jun 2026, GA July 2026 — \$2 reported, not yet printed on the pricing page)	Autonomous
Fin (formerly Intercom)	\$0.99 / outcome ¹⁶³ — Salesforce acquisition announced 15 Jun 2026 (~\$3.6B; close expected Salesforce fiscal Q4 2027)	Autonomous (adjacent)
Decagon	~\$0.50 / resolution (+ platform fee) — reported; Decagon publishes no pricing page ¹⁶⁴	Autonomous
Zendesk	per automated resolution — construct printed on its pricing page; the \$1.50–2.00 range as previously reported ¹⁶⁵	Autonomous (adjacent)

The unit of value is moving from the **seat** to the **resolved interaction**, and it is moving in public. The chain that makes this a WEM-wide finding, not just an Autonomous CX one, runs backward through the stack. WFM already re-described its planning unit as “humans + BPO + **AI agents**”: you cannot price a bot per seat. Agent-Assist located the pricing hinge at the control-surface line: assist keeps the seat, autonomous removes it. Autonomous CX is where the per-resolution price list actually appears. **P2 is confirmed as a pricing-disclosure fact**: reported as exactly that, never as a seat-count volume forecast. Freshness (2026-07-20): every anchor above was re-verified live or at Tier-1 corroboration; **none withdrawn, none reverted**. Salesforce announced a fourth pricing construct (pay-per-resolution for Help Agent, 25 Jun 2026). It also completed its acquisition of **m3ter**, a consumption-metering platform (announced 8 Jun 2026; completed 1 Jul 2026). m3ter is the billing plumbing for outcome pricing at platform scale.

Proxy P3: The contested displacement (where the bet is genuinely at risk)

P3 is the proxy the report refuses to overclaim. The *capability* direction is clear and advancing. Vendors have redefined the metric from **deflection** (“keep it from a human”) to **fulfillment** (“the agent executes the resolution end-to-end”): NICE with “AI that gets things done,”¹⁶⁶ Genesys with “execution,”¹⁶⁷ and Lorikeet with its “40-step refund flow.”¹⁶⁸ But the *displacement* claim, that autonomous agents remove human seats at scale, is genuinely two-sided on public evidence:

- **For**: Salesforce reports ~84% self-resolution on its own support¹⁶⁹; the autonomous-native independents are funded at frontier marks (Sierra ~\$15.8B¹⁷⁰, Decagon ~\$4.5B¹⁷¹, Parloa ~\$3B¹⁷²) on

the premise that the seat goes away.

- **Against (the live counter-signal):** Klarna publicly said it had leaned too far into AI automation and moved to re-add human support (CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski, public statements, 2025).¹⁷³ Gartner's "80% autonomous by 2029"¹⁷⁴ pull sits against its own projection that a large share of agentic projects are cancelled by 2027¹⁷⁵. In-window (July 2026) reporting enriches both legs of the Klarna datapoint: the assistant's workload is reported grown to ~850 agent-equivalents (Forbes, 16 Jul 2026), while the re-added human support is reported as gig-structured – "an Uber type of set-up," per Siemiatkowski (The Guardian, 18 Jun 2026). The counter-signal stands: more textured, neither retracted nor repeated elsewhere.

The repricing is happening (P2, fact), fulfillment is rising (P3 capability, evidenced), but **seat elimination at scale is a forecast with a live, public counter-example**. The report stakes its credibility on keeping that distinction visible at every turn: pricing is fact, displacement is a bet.

The consolidation engines (the M&A spine across all markets)

The cross-market M&A pattern resolves into **three** structurally distinct consolidation engines, all pointing the same direction (fewer independent WEM vendors, more capability folded into multi-market platforms), by opposite mechanisms:

1. **NICE: organic / acqui-suite.** It is a public company building the single-engine on its own balance sheet and *buying capability into the owned stack*: Cognigy (~\$955M, agentic → Autonomous)¹⁷⁶, LiveVox (~\$350M, outbound)¹⁷⁹, Playvox (WEM/engagement)¹⁷⁷. NICE integrates to own the product direction. The engine investment's reported line: **Q1 2026 AI ARR up 66% year over year** (NICE Q1 2026 earnings release, May 2026). The 66% figure is the AI ARR line specifically, not total revenue: total revenue grew ~10%.
2. **Thoma Bravo CX: PE roll-up.** It is private capital *aggregating* best-of-breed into one platform: Verint (\$2.0B take-private, closed 26 Nov 2025)¹⁷⁸ merged with Calabrio (which had itself absorbed Echo AI), plus Verint's earlier acquisition of Cogito (emotion-AI). Thoma Bravo CX aggregates to own the installed base. On WFM, this engine literally de-dups two top-tier WFM stacks into one.
3. **The autonomous-native venture wave.** This is a *third* engine the prior State-of-X reports did not have: frontier-funded independents (Sierra, Decagon, Parloa) raising at marks that let them compete with the suites for the *category*, not just a feature. This is the one market (Autonomous CX) where independent capital is genuinely contesting the platform.

The freshness window (to 20 Jul 2026) added buy-side datapoints in the same direction. **Salesforce** signed a definitive agreement to acquire **Fin (formerly Intercom)**, the per-resolution-priced independent anchor, for approximately **\$3.6B** (announced 15 Jun 2026). The deal is announced, not closed: the close is expected in Salesforce's fiscal Q4 2027, subject to regulatory clearances. Salesforce also **completed** its acquisition of **m3ter** (consumption metering; 1 Jul 2026). **Genesys** acquired **Pinkfish**

(agentic orchestration; 30 Jun 2026, terms undisclosed), and **Sprinklr** acquired the assets of **ViralMoment** (social-video intelligence; 28 May 2026, terms undisclosed). The direction is unchanged: fewer independents, more capability folded into multi-market platforms.

The first two integrate/aggregate the installed base; the third tries to out-run it. The falsification condition (the Winning & Losing section below) is, in effect, a bet on which engine wins net-new.

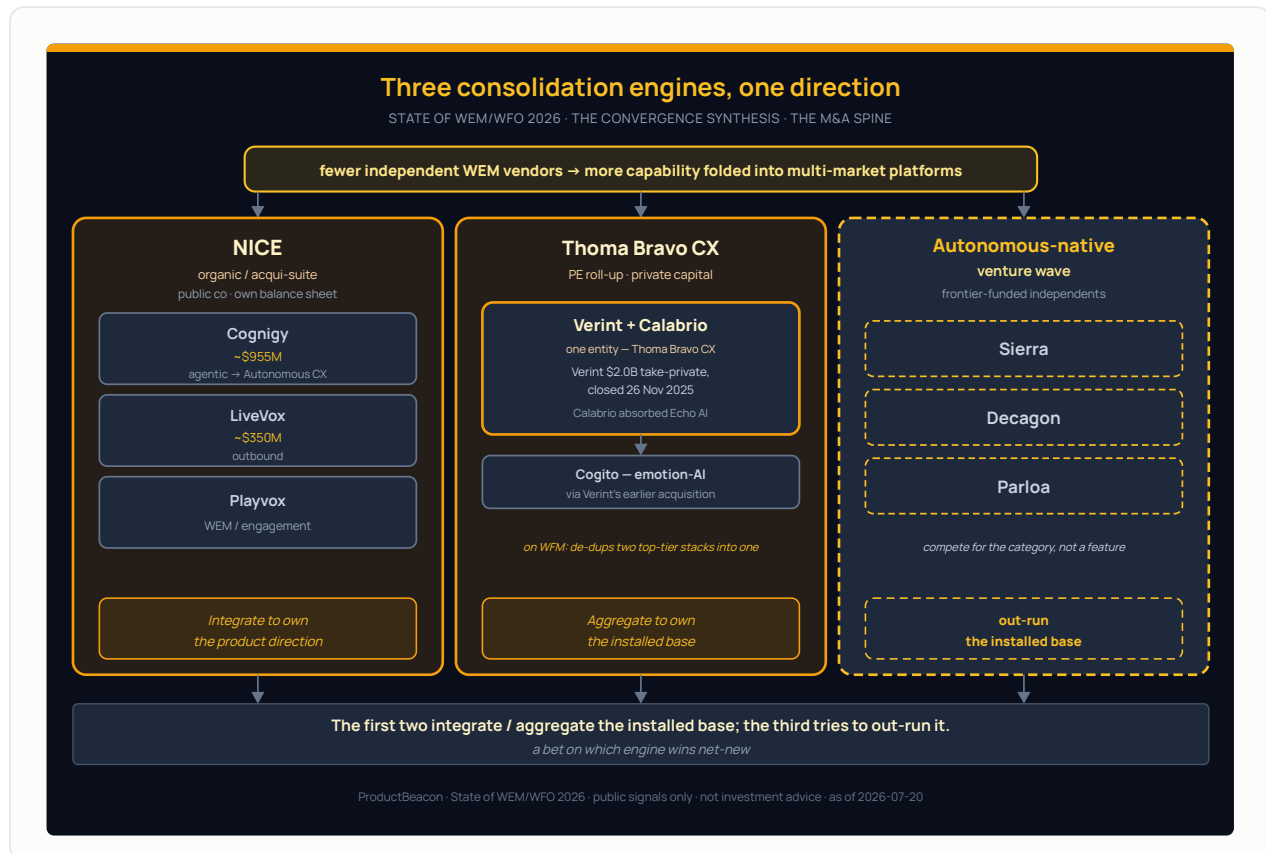


Figure C.5 — Three consolidation engines, one direction: NICE integrates, Thoma Bravo CX (Verint + Calabrio) aggregates, and the autonomous-native venture wave tries to out-run the installed base.

Winning & Losing: the unified verdict

This is my read across the markets: each claim is anchored to public evidence already cited in the chapters above, framed as opinion, and stated as a falsifiable prediction with a dated checkpoint.

Cross-Market Pattern Claims

Pattern Claim 1 – The One Engine Is Real at the Product Surface (P1 verdict)

Observation. The same suites card as distinct products across the full WEM stack: NICE on all five WEM-module markets, Genesys on five, Thoma Bravo CX on three. They do it increasingly under one named engine (NICE Enlighten; Five9 “Agentic Experience Engine”). And they expose assist vs autonomous as one platform gated by a human-in-the-loop SKU (NICE Mpower Copilot/Autopilot). All of it is on dated public surfaces cited in the five graded-market chapters.

My read. The “one AI brain collapses the stack” claim is confirmed *at the product/SKU surface*. It is not proof of one internal codebase, which no public source can establish, and which the report never asserts. It is the way the category leaders now position and price. The collapse is a commercial reality before it is necessarily an architectural one. **Conditional prediction.** If by **Q4 2026** at least **3** Gravity-tier vendors publicly name one engine/platform spanning ≥ 3 WEM modules *and* a Copilot/Autopilot-style human-gated SKU pair, P1 is confirmed at the surface. If the modules stay separately-branded, separately-priced products, the single-engine story is weaker than the marketing. **Sources.** The five graded-market contender cards; the cross-market vendor-card pattern set out in this section; the single-engine-gated-SKU evidence in the Autonomous CX chapter.

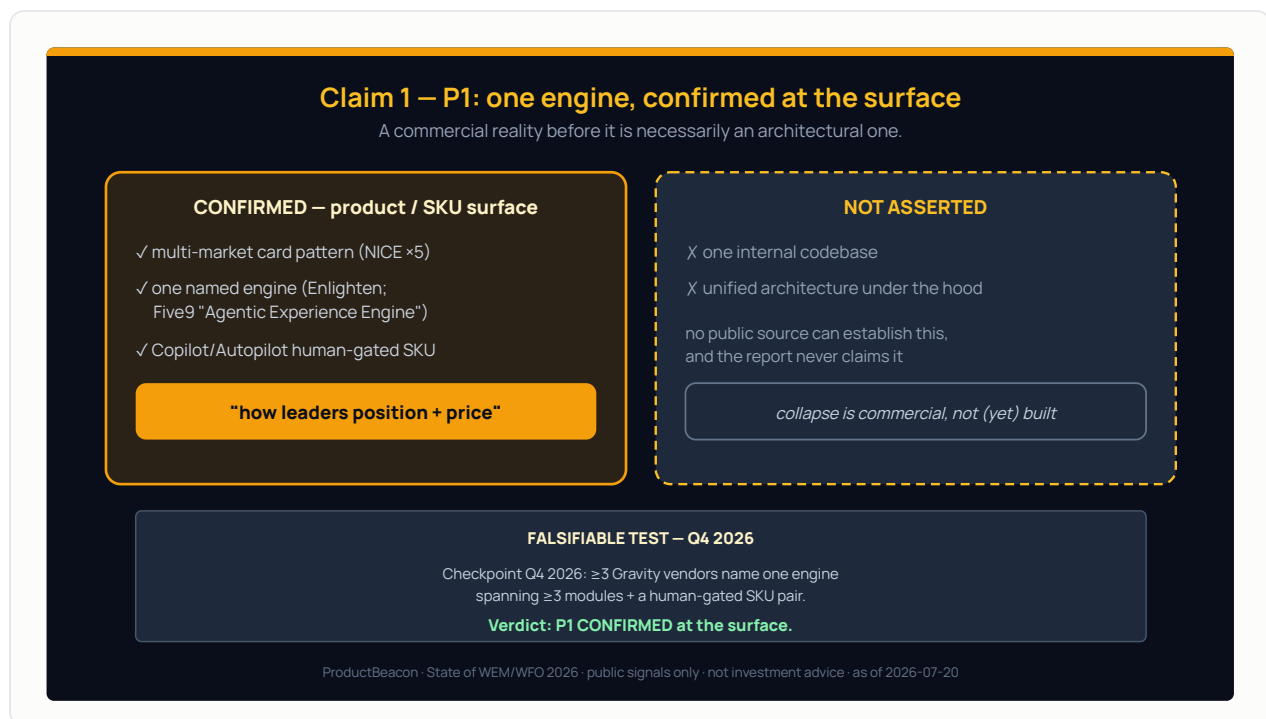


Figure C.6a – Pattern Claim 1 (P1): the one engine is confirmed at the product and SKU surface, not asserted as one internal codebase.

Pattern Claim 2 – The Repricing Is Real; the Displacement Is Not Yet (P2 confirmed / P3 contested)

Observation. Per-resolution / per-outcome pricing is published on dated public pages today. Sierra is outcome-based; Agentforce is \$2/conversation + \$0.10/action. Fin (formerly Intercom) is \$0.99/outcome; Decagon is ~\$0.50 (reported). Zendesk prices per automated resolution. The anchor pages were re-verified 2026-07-20; none withdrawn or reverted. The seat-displacement evidence, by contrast, is two-sided: Salesforce ~84% self-resolution vs Klarna's public reversal; Gartner 80%-by-2029 vs its ~40%-cancelled. **My read.** The seat → outcome **repricing** is an accomplished, observable fact; the seat **elimination** is a contested forecast. The report's central, defensible finding is precisely this asymmetry. The market has already changed how it *prices* WFO faster than it has changed how many humans it *staffs*. The pricing leads the displacement, and may lead it for years. **Conditional prediction.** If by **H1 2027** at least **2** Gravity-tier vendors price a flagship customer-facing CX-agent SKU primarily off per-seat (to per-resolution/conversation/action) on a dated public page, P2 is confirmed. The displacement (P3) remains *open* until sustained (non-pilot) autonomous fulfillment above **50%** on a primary channel is publicly reported without a Klarna-style reversal. **Sources.** The Autonomous CX pricing evidence; the seat-question chain traced through the WFM and Agent-Assist chapters; the Autonomous CX Terrain section.

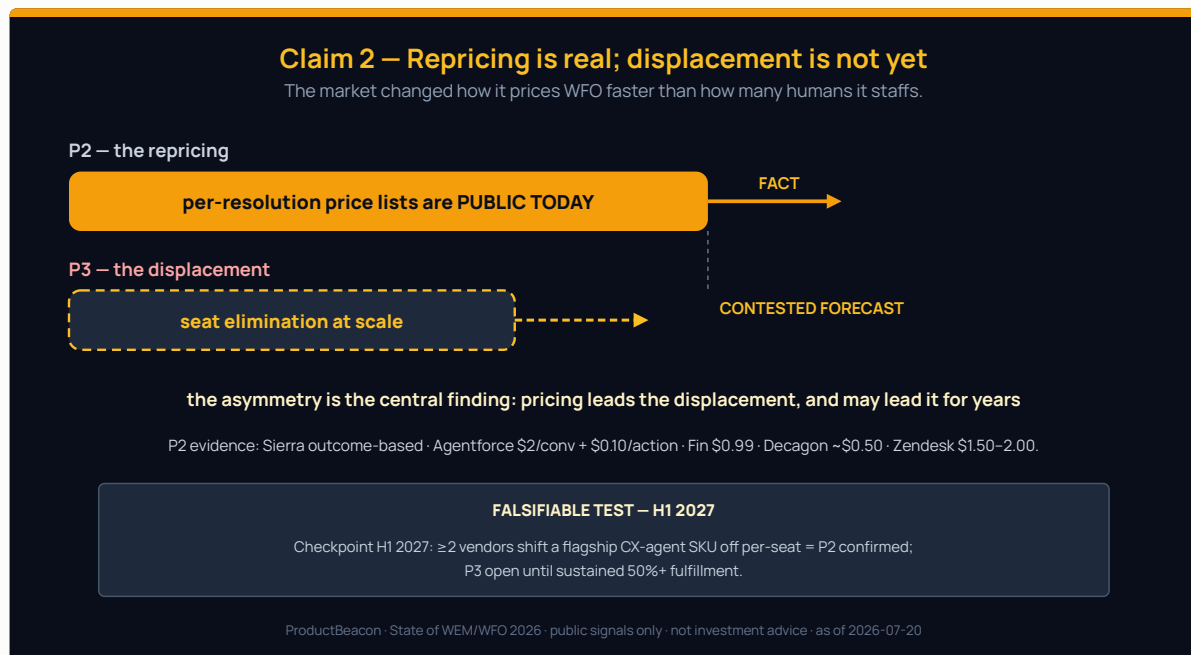


Figure C.6b – Pattern Claim 2 (P2 confirmed / P3 contested): the repricing is an observable fact today; the displacement is a contested forecast.

Pattern Claim 3 – The Unified Falsification Condition (the single falsifier)

Observation. The bet can fail three independent ways, which this synthesis consolidates into **one** dated falsification test rather than three adjacent ones. **My read.** The single-engine-collapse + seat-reset thesis is **downgraded from “confirmed” to “directional, not realized”** if three conditions hold together by **H1 2027**. Condition (a): independent / best-of-breed WEM (the Thoma Bravo Verint+Calabrio platform sold standalone, CallMiner, Observe.AI, the autonomous-natives) is still winning the **majority** of net-new competitive displacements against suite-bundled WEM. **AND** condition (b): **no ≥ 2** Gravity-tier vendors have publicly shifted a flagship WEM/CX-agent SKU off per-seat to per-outcome pricing. **AND** condition ©: no named enterprise reports **sustained** autonomous fulfillment above **50%** on a primary channel without a public reversal. If all three hold, the collapse is a marketing frame; if any two fail, the thesis stands. *Honesty note: clause (a) is the analyst-judgment leg (there is no public dataset of net-new WEM displacements), whereas (b) and © are publicly observable. The single cleanest real-time tell remains any Gravity vendor reverting off per-resolution to per-seat.* **Conditional prediction.** As above: **H1 2027** is the dated checkpoint; the three clauses are the threshold. The single most important real-time signal to watch: **any Gravity vendor publicly reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat** (the cleanest single falsifier of P2, the proxy currently carrying the thesis). **Sources.** The report’s original falsification condition from the scope definition; the fulfillment-reversal form in the Autonomous CX Winning & Losing section, reconciled here into one falsifier.



Figure C.6c – Pattern Claim 3: the unified falsification condition – three clauses dated H1 2027, plus the single cleanest real-time tell.

Winners

Reading the per-market verdicts together, this is my opinion across the whole stack, not a scoreboard. **The suites: NICE, Genesys, Salesforce, Five9.** They win the “one platform, already integrated, one engine” pull that recurs in the Quality, Performance, Assist, and Autonomous verdicts; the collapse rewards whoever the buyer already runs. **Thoma Bravo CX (Verint + Calabrio).** It is the private-equity-consolidated platform large enough to be its own suite: the wildcard that is neither pure independent nor legacy incumbent.

Watch

The autonomous-native independents: Sierra, Decagon, Parloa. This is the one market where independent capital genuinely contests the category rather than a feature. Whether frontier funding out-runs the installed base is the open question. **The best-of-breed holders.** CallMiner and Observe.AI in Quality, Assembled and Peopleware in WFM, AmplifAI in Performance, and Balto in Assist hold on depth, un-owned data, and outcome measurement. **The unified falsification condition.** The three clauses are dated H1 2027 in Pattern Claim 3. The single cleanest tell is any Gravity vendor reverting off per-resolution back to per-seat.

Losers

No graded vendor carries a public distress signal in any market's Funding & Fault-Lines section. What is losing, across markets, is a *structural position*, and the evidence is restructuring rather than failure: the standalone best-of-breed WEM business is folding into the consolidation engines. Verint was taken private (\$2.0B, closed 26 Nov 2025) and merged with Calabrio. Cogito was absorbed into that platform. NICE bought Cognigy (~\$955M) and LiveVox (~\$350M) into its owned stack. Read specific to each vendor's WEM/WFO business across markets, these are consolidation events, not deaths. The one position the whole report marks as genuinely exposed is per-seat licensing itself. The per-resolution price lists of Proxy P2 are already displacing it, in public.

The Naming Migration Tracks the Collapse

WFO → WEM → “CX-AI” is not just a label drift; it tracks the collapse. **“Workforce Optimization”** named an era when the product was *modules a human-staffed contact center bought* (record, score, schedule, coach). **“Workforce Engagement Management”** renamed it when the pitch moved to *the agent's experience and retention*. The 2026 vendor language is the third rename in progress: NICE's “the era of AI **and** human agents,” the “Agentic Experience Engine,” “manage performance across human **and** AI agents on the same queues.” The workforce being optimized, engaged, and managed is **no longer assumed to be human**. The category renamed itself each time the unit of work changed, and it is renaming itself again now. The freshness window (to 20 Jul 2026) put the third rename on new surfaces: Microsoft shipped “workforce engagement management” natively in Dynamics 365, to “plan, operate, and improve **human and AI workforce** performance” (microsoft.com, 22 Jun 2026). Salesforce launched Agentforce Contact Center WEM (salesforce.com, 22 Jun 2026). Zendesk's pricing page now carries a “Workforce

Engagement Bundle” SKU (zendesk.com/pricing, page updated 16 Jul 2026). The unit-of-work rename is spreading beyond the incumbent set. That is why a report that leads with “WEM” and carries “WFO” is documenting a live migration, not choosing a synonym.

The verdict

- **P1 (single-engine): Confirmed at the product/SKU surface.** Strongest at NICE/Five9/Salesforce; visible as the control-surface gate. It is not a claim about how the engine is built under the hood.
- **P2 (seat → outcome): Confirmed as observable pricing fact.** Per-resolution price lists are public today. This is the cleanest evidence in the report.
- **P3 (displacement): Open / contested.** Fulfillment is rising, but seat elimination at scale is a forecast with a live counter-signal (Klarna reversal). This is where the bet can still be lost.

Net: the State of WEM/WFO 2026 finds a market that has **already collapsed its products onto one engine and re-priced itself per outcome**. It has done so **ahead of – and not yet proven by – the human-seat displacement that the whole story is ultimately about**. The repricing is the present tense; the displacement is the bet. The falsification condition (in the Winning & Losing section) is dated H1 2027.

The per-market Winning/Losing verdicts consolidate into a best-of-breed-vs-suite read, market by market. Suites lead on the “one platform, already integrated, one engine” pull (Quality, Performance, Assist, Autonomous). Independents hold on depth, the un-owned data, and outcome-measurement: CallMiner/Observe.AI in Quality, Assembled/Peopleware in WFM, AmplifAI in Performance, Balto in Assist, and Sierra/Decagon/Parloa in Autonomous. The Thoma Bravo Verint+Calabrio platform is the wildcard: a PE-consolidated “independent” large enough to be its own suite.

Disclosures & Methodology

This is the full Disclosures surface for this report. The compact disclosure line at the top of the report (first line after the title) is its summary; the complete disclosures, trading position, and methodology are set out here.

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This report reports publicly disclosed funding, valuation, pricing, and product information for **market-structure analysis only**. Figures are as reported by the named outlets on the dates shown; **private-company valuations are point-in-time round marks, not current marks**. Capability, deflection, accuracy, and outcome figures are **vendor or named-outlet claims**, quoted as such, not independently verified or asserted as fact. **Nothing in this report is a recommendation to buy, sell, or hold any security**, or to engage or not engage any vendor.

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The market is cut into five graded markets, each chaptered here, plus the Convergence synthesis — with Recording & Compliance carried as a tiered-contingent context front, unnumbered and unchaptered — on a fixed per-chapter template with the taxonomy locked up front. The report makes **falsifiable pattern claims only**, each with a stated condition under which it would be wrong, never bare forecasts. The integrity line held throughout: **pricing is reported as fact; displacement is reported as forecast**. The central bet carries a dated falsification condition (H1 2027).

Governance (the discipline trail)

- **Armed lint gates** — a pattern-claim linter (NICE-insider-framing, AI-architecture-evidence, threshold-and-checkpoint, viability checks) and a de-militarized-register counter, both hardened twice by audit.
- **An audit between every phase** — three fresh auditors (legal / independence wall, sourcing, alignment) per market; every market cleared GO, each catching real defects the gates missed.
- **SOP-2 publication gate** — dual independent verification plus an adversarial NICE-hostile-counsel read is required before any external distribution.

Recurring “Not investment advice” applies to every Funding & Fault-Lines section in this report.

ProductBeacon Research · The State of Workforce Engagement Management 2026 · Not investment advice.

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